



PAGE 5

NATION

Sunetra Pawar calls Uddhav to seek support for Baramati bypoll



PAGE 6

NATION

Double engine misusing institutions to delete voters: TMC's Abhishek



PAGE 9

GLOBAL

Tamil Nadu-born Rini Sampath in race to become Washington DC mayor



PAGE 11

SPORTS

Bowling a major concern for CSK, says Gavaskar



AGENDA

NAXALISM

ENDGAME

GREAT OFFERS!



Scan to Subscribe

PIONEER IN SHORT

RAHUL GANDHI ATTACKS KERALA CM, BJP LINKS

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday intensified his attack on the LDF during campaign rallies across central Kerala, alleging a nexus between the ruling front and right-wing forces amid rising concerns over minority safety. Addressing meetings in Alappuzha, Idukki and Emakulam districts ahead of the April 9 Assembly polls, Gandhi claimed minorities faced increasing attacks nationwide, citing incidents in Manipur and Chhattisgarh. He accused Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan of aligning with forces responsible, and alleged a tacit understanding between the BJP and LDF to counter the Congress-led UDF.

IPL: RIZVI POWERS DELHI TO VICTORY

Sameer Rizvi's blazing knock powered Delhi Capitals to a six-wicket win over Mumbai Indians in their first home game of the 2026 IPL season on Saturday. Chasing 163, the 22-year-old struck a superb 90 off 51 balls, laced with seven fours and seven sixes, anchoring the innings after an early wobble. Delhi recovered through a 66-run stand between Rizvi and Pathum Nissanka (44), before Rizvi added 78 runs with David Miller to seal the chase with 11 balls remaining. Rizvi accelerated after Nissanka's dismissal, dominating the middle overs with a flurry of boundaries and sixes, though he fell short of a maiden IPL century. Earlier, Mumbai Indians posted 162 for six, built around Suryakumar Yadav's 51 and Rohit Sharma's 35. However, Delhi's disciplined bowling kept the total in check. Captain Axar Patel led the effort with an economical spell and key wicket, while Mukesh Kumar struck twice early to dent Mumbai's top order. Lungi Ngidi and T Natarajan also chipped in with crucial breakthroughs.

WEST ASIA CRISIS: IRAN DOWNS TWO US JETS

Iran shot down two US military aircraft on Friday, marking a major escalation in the conflict, with one service member rescued and at least one still missing. The incidents came nearly five weeks into the war and just two days after President Donald Trump claimed the US had "completely decimated Iran." Officials said a US F-15E Strike Eagle was downed over Iranian territory. One crew member was rescued, while the second remains unaccounted for, prompting a US search-and-rescue operation. Separately, Iranian State media reported a US A-10 attack plane crashed in the Persian Gulf after being struck, though the details and crew status remain unclear. The Pentagon notified Congress that the missing service member's status is unknown. Social media footage showed US drones, aircraft, and helicopters searching mountainous regions, while Iranian media urged civilians to report any "enemy pilot" and promised a reward. Experts note that the F-15E is equipped with emergency locator beacons in survival kits, which could assist in tracking the downed aircrew. The attacks come amid Iran's ongoing strikes on Gulf energy infrastructure and threats to the Strait of Hormuz, sending oil prices soaring and riling global markets. White House officials confirmed Trump had been briefed but offered no public update on the rescue efforts.

In Kerala, PM sends strong message on delimitation, women's quota Bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Thiruvananthapuram/Chennai

Speaking for the first time on the forthcoming women reservation Bill coupled with the delimitation process to be brought in a Special Session of Parliament this month, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday asserted that Lok Sabha seats would not be reduced in south Indian states that have successfully controlled population, and that the total number of seats will increase to benefit States across the country. Addressing an NDA Assembly election rally at Thiruvalla in Kerala, the Prime Minister said the Parliament session has been extended to April 16-18 to pass amendments to the law ensuring 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies. Talking about the Bills, Modi said that the extension will also safeguard South Indian states from losing any seats despite their success in population control. "There are false rumours being spread

Prime Minister Narendra Modi being felicitated during a public meeting ahead of the Kerala Assembly elections, in Thiruvalla, Kerala

that seats will be reduced in South Indian states due to population control, but this is completely untrue. Parliament will take steps to ensure that its seats are fully protected. States like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Goa, Telangana, and others that have done well in population control must not lose any Lok Sabha seats, even if

their population growth is lower," Modi said. Modi's statement came after Congress targeted the BJP by raising the delimitation issue. Congress argued that the southern states, which have effectively controlled their populations, should not be 'punished' with fewer parliamentary seats. Modi said that the

Government's goal was to ensure 33 per cent women's representation in Parliament from 2029 onwards and urged all parties to support the bill. "Our Government has ensured 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies. From 16-18 April, Parliament will reconvene to deliberate on the Nari Shakti Vandan Act and take it

forward. Our goal is to ensure 33 per cent women's representation in Parliament from 2029 onwards," he said, urging all parties to support the bill. The PM also held a massive roadshow in Thiruvananthapuram, drawing huge crowds. The city's streets turned into a sea of supporters as the NDA intensified its campaign for the April 9 Assembly polls. Senior BJP leaders and candidates-Rajeev Chandrasekhar, R Sreelekha, V Muraliedharan, and Karamana Jayan-joined the procession. This reinforced the party's show of strength in the state. Attacking the current regime in the State, Modi said that the countdown for the removal of the LDF Government in Kerala has started, and a BJP-led NDA will come to power in the state. Modi tore into the Congress and the Left, saying that while they dismiss everything — from *Kerala Story* to *Dhurandhar* — as lies, it is they who have "become pros at lying."

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Trump issues fresh ultimatum to Iran

US President Donald Trump speaking about the West Asia conflict at the White House

ASHOKE RAJ

New Delhi

US President Donald Trump has revived his earlier deadline, first issued in late March, when he demanded that

Iran either reach an agreement with Washington or allow unimpeded passage through the key maritime route. The stance marks a return to a more aggressive posture after a brief period of apparent diplomatic progress. Shortly after his initial threat to target Iran's power infrastructure, Trump had indicated that discussions with Iranian officials were "very good and productive," leading to a temporary delay in military action. Deadlines were subsequently extended more than once, raising hopes of a possible breakthrough.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

PM to inaugurate Delhi expressway to Devbhumi

RAJESH KUMAR

New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is all set to inaugurate the much-awaited six lane Delhi-Dehradun Expressway on April 14. Once operational, it will ease congestion in the National Capital Territory (NCT) of Delhi and reduce traffic on the Delhi-Meerut Expressway and other connecting highways. It will also slash travel times to the Uttar Pradesh border for commuters from east Delhi, south Delhi and Noida. A seamless travel corridor is envisaged for motorists from south Delhi, who can take the Nizamuddin route onto the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, connect to Akshardham, and then seamlessly transition onto the new Delhi-Dehradun Expressway via Geeta Colony to enter Uttar Pradesh. The expressway will have a designated speed limit of 100 kmph and cut travel time between Delhi and Dehradun from the current 6.5 hours to just 2.5 hours. Stretching 213 km from Akshardham Temple in Delhi, the expressway passes through Baghpat, Baraut, Muzaffarnagar, Shamli, and Saharanpur in Uttar Pradesh before ending at Dehradun. This six-lane, access-con-

A section of the six lane Delhi-Dehradun Expressway

FILE PHOTO

trolled corridor features seven interchanges, two railway overbridges, ten bridges, and fourteen wayside amenities to ensure high-speed travel with convenience and safety. The project also incorporates measures for environmental sustainability and wildlife protection, a 370-m-long tunnel near the Daat Kali temple, and Asia's longest 12-km elevated wildlife corridor. Built at an estimated cost of ₹11,970 crore, the project has generated excitement among residents and frequent travellers between the two cities. Improved connectivity is expected to boost tourism in Uttarakhand, especially to

THE EXPRESSWAY WILL HAVE A SPEED LIMIT OF 100 KMPH AND CUT TRAVEL TIME BETWEEN DELHI AND DEHRADUN TO JUST 2.5 HOURS

destinations near Dehradun and Mussoorie. Beautification work is underway along parts of the corridor, including painting roadside walls, cleaning and polishing streetlight poles, and checking surveillance cameras. Officials from the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) recently

inspected safety standards along a 74-km stretch, which includes the 12-km wildlife corridor. NHAI Project Director Narendra Singh and his team visited multiple locations in Saharanpur district, reviewed progress with ground officials, and issued directions, signalling that the expressway is nearing completion. The route will also include a spur to Haridwar and connect to the Char Dham Highway, enhancing access to Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh's hill stations and pilgrimage sites. NHAI officials added the construction was executed in four phases.

Chadha calls AAP allegations scripted

RAJESH KUMAR

New Delhi

Not willing to take allegations lying down, Raghav Chadha on Saturday described allegations raised by the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) as a scripted and coordinated campaign targeting him. In a video shared on X, he said he would expose "every lie" and responded to each charge levelled by the party, ending with a popular line from *Dhurandhar*, "*Ghayal hoon isiliye ghatak hoon*" (I may be wounded, but I am also stronger because of it). "Since yesterday, a scripted campaign has been

Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha addressing allegations raised by AAP

PTI

waged against me-featuring the same language, the

same talking points, and the same allegations. This is no coincidence; rather, it is a coordinated attack. Initially, I thought I should not respond to it; however, I subsequently felt that if a lie is repeated a hundred times, some people might actually come to believe it. Therefore, I decided to offer a response," Chadha said in the video, defending himself. "The Aam Aadmi Party made three allegations and said that because of these, Raghav Chadha should not be allowed to speak in Parliament. I would like to address all three," he said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Bhadralok signals West Bengal polls may redefine state's political balance

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

New Delhi

As West Bengal braces for the 2026 Assembly elections scheduled for April 23 and 29, a quiet but profound political realignment is underway. Assessments, circulating in political circles, project the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) securing between 125 and 136 seats out of 294. This is no modest uptick from the 77 seats won in 2021; it signals a potential breach of the 148-seat majority threshold if alliances and independents align favourably. What makes this projection intellectually compelling is not mere arithmetic, but the geography and sociology of the shift, the very *Bhadralok*

heartlands. Hooghly, Howrah and South Kolkata long considered intellectual bastions, which supported Left parties, Mamta Bannerjee and averse to saffron politics, are tilting towards the BJP. The drivers are stark and grounded in governance failures rather than ideological fervour. Law-and-order concerns have become the pivot. Recent Supreme Court observations on "complete breakdown of law and order" in the State triggered by incidents like the Malda hostage crisis involving judicial officers during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, have amplified public unease. In urban and semi-urban pockets, where educated

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee with TMC candidates Prasanjit Das (Gazole) and Prasun Banerjee (Chanchal), unseen, during a rally ahead of the Assembly elections, at Gazole in Malda district West Bengal

PTI

middle-class voters once viewed TMC as a bulwark against majoritarianism, stories of unchecked violence, political patronage and administrative paralysis, have eroded their trust. South Kolkata's intellectual enclaves, Hooghly's industrial corridors and Howrah's bustling trade hubs are no longer insulated; they are now asking whether 14 years of Trinamool rule have delivered security or merely rhetoric. This urban-intellectual drift is complemented by a deeper consolidation among key social groups. The Namasudra often referred to as Namo Sudra, Matua, and Kanjawara communities, historically marginalised yet numerically sig-

nificant backward castes, have shifted towards BJP in substantial numbers. These groups, many with roots in refugee experiences and Dalit movements, have responded to the BJP's outreach on citizenship, dignity, and economic inclusion. The Matua heartland in particular, once a TMC stronghold, has seen visible realignment, turning what were once fragmented caste votes into a cohesive bloc. The electoral math underscores the precision of the BJP's strategy. West Bengal's demographics offer a clear template: minorities, largely consolidated behind TMC, account for roughly 32 per cent of the electorate.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

IN BRIEF

Sanitation drive carried out in Daya Basti area



A special late-night sanitation drive was carried out in the Daya Basti area under the Karol Bagh Zone of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to remove legacy waste lying along the railway tracks. Around 300 metric tonnes of waste was successfully cleared during the operation through a well-planned and coordinated midnight effort. The drive was conducted under the supervision of Dilkhush Meena, Deputy Commissioner, Karol Bagh Zone, who was present at the site to monitor the work and ensure it was completed smoothly and on time. The MCD worked closely with the Railway Department, which provided full support and cooperation for the successful execution of the drive. Following the night operation, a special cleanliness drive was also conducted the next morning. The drive started from New Delhi Railway Station (Paharganj Gate No. 1) and covered routes towards Ramakrishna Ashram Marg and Sheila Cinema. All visible waste and garbage along these stretches were removed, leading to improved cleanliness in the area.

Campus-to-Campus Vande Mataram Campaign organised



The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), Delhi, organised a "Campus-to-Campus Vande Mataram Campaign" across various educational institutions in the national capital from March 23 to April 4, on the occasion of the completion of 150 years of Vande Mataram. As part of this campaign, mass singing of Vande Mataram was conducted on campuses across Delhi. On this historic occasion, students from 117 educational institutions, including the University of Delhi, Jawaharlal Nehru University, and Delhi Skill and Entrepreneurship University (DSEU), enthusiastically participated in the collective rendition of Vande Mataram.

Delhi remains under consistent cloud cover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capital experienced a slight increase in minimum temperature on Saturday, while the maximum temperature decreased due to persistent cloudy conditions throughout the day.

Although the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a yellow alert for the day, only isolated areas of Delhi received light rain during the night between Friday and Saturday.

On Saturday morning, the Safdarjung weather station, a key representative of the city's weather, did not record any rain, while other stations reported varying amounts: Palam received 1.9 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday; Lodhi Road recorded 0.3 mm; Ridge also noted 1.9 mm; Ayanagar experi-

enced 5.8 mm; and Pitampura saw 0.5 mm during the same period. No additional rain was observed until 5.30 pm, according to IMD data.

The minimum temperature rose to 20.7 degrees Celsius, which is 1.9 degrees above normal and 1.5 degrees higher than the previous day. In contrast, the maximum temperature reached 32 degrees Celsius, two degrees below normal and one degree lower than the day before.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president at Skymet, said, "This is due to the presence of a cloud cover, as a result of which lesser heat penetrates during the day and lesser heat escapes from the earth's surface at night."

Meanwhile, the IMD has issued a yellow alert for Tuesday, forecasting one or two spells of very light to light rain during the day, accompanied by thunderstorms, light-



ning and gusty winds of speed 30-40 km/h. An additional spell of light rain may occur during the evening hours on Tuesday.

Palawat added, "This will be because of the influence of

a western disturbance, as well as an induced cyclonic circulation that is being observed over northwest Rajasthan and central Pakistan. The temperature might see a slight drop after

Tuesday."

The MeT department forecasts that the maximum temperature will range from 30 to 32 degrees Celsius on Sunday, dropping to 28 to 30 degrees by Wednesday. The

64 lakh people in Delhi receiving subsidised food grains, says data

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 64 lakh people in Delhi are receiving subsidised food grains under the public distribution system (PDS), with the Government continuing free rations till December 2028, according to official data.

The figures show that 6,493,601 beneficiaries across 1,428,475 households are currently covered. Of these, 6,246,786 beneficiaries fall under the Priority Household (PHH) category, while 2,46,815 are covered under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY), meant for the poorest families.

For many families, the PDS remains a critical lifeline. In resettlement colonies and low-income neighbourhoods, monthly ration supplies often determine whether kitchens can run through the month without additional borrowing.

Officials state that Delhi has 13 districts and 70 circles



aligned with assembly constituencies to manage distribution. Food grains are supplied through a network supported by six Food Corporation of India (FCI) godowns located in Mayapuri, Okhla, Pusa, Narela, Ghevra and Shaktinagar.

In addition, two sugar godowns operated by the Delhi State Civil Supplies Corporation are located in Ghazipur and Siraspur.

Under the current entitlement, AAY cardholders receive 28 kg of wheat, 7 kg

of rice and 1 kg of sugar per card every month. PHH beneficiaries are entitled to 4 kg of wheat and 1 kg of rice per unit, according to the data.

The Centre had extended free food grain distribution under the scheme for five years starting January 1, 2024, making it available till the end of 2028.

Officials said the system continues to be streamlined to ensure targeted delivery, though challenges such as identification of genuine beneficiaries and prevention of leakages remain.

NCRTC, IIT Roorkee sign MoU to power research, innovation in urban transport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC) and the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Roorkee have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to strengthen collaboration in research, innovation and capacity building in the urban transport sector.

The MoU was exchanged on Saturday, April 4, in the presence of Managing Director, NCRTC, Shalabh Goel and the Dean of Resources and Alumni Affairs (DORA), IIT Roorkee, Professor RD Garg. Senior officials of NCRTC and associate deans and heads of departments/centres of IIT Roorkee were also present on the occasion.

The MoU aims to leverage the academic and research expertise of IIT Roorkee with NCRTC's experience in successful implementing India's first Nammo Bharat to address the challenges of the urban mobility sector and



pave the way for a greener and sustainable future.

Under this collaboration, both organisations will work together on research projects of mutual interest, with a focus on developing practical and scalable solutions for the urban transport sector. NCRTC may share real-world problem statements to be explored by IIT Roorkee's faculty and researchers, encouraging applied research aligned with industry needs. It also provides scope for technology demonstrations and potential transfer of innovations developed at IIT Roorkee, thereby bridging

the gap between academic research and real-world implementation.

The partnership will also facilitate internship opportunities for undergraduate, postgraduate, and doctoral students of IIT Roorkee, providing them with hands-on exposure to large-scale infrastructure projects and operational transit systems.

In addition, this agreement envisages capacity-building and upskilling initiatives for NCRTC personnel through specialised training programmes, certification courses, and workshops conducted by IIT Roorkee.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I Naveen Challoo, Parent of TITIKSHA, residing at C-14/1801, PRATEEK GRAND CITY, SIDDHARTH VIHAR, GHAZIABAD, U.P 201009 here by declare that my minor daughter TITIKSHA has changed her name to TITIKSSHA CHALU

PD(758)C
I Naveen Challoo, Parent/ Guardian of TRIAKSHA, residing at C-14/1801, PRATEEK GRAND CITY, SIDDHARTH VIHAR, U.P. 201009, hereby declare that my minor daughter TRIAKSHA has changed her name to TRIAKSHHA CHALU

PD(759)C
I hitherto known as PUSPA DHANIYA W/O RAM KUMAR R/O House No. 18/769, Gali No.-2, Siraspur, North West Delhi, Delhi-110042, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as PUSHPA DEVI.

PD(760)C
I, Deepak Gulati S/o Late Sh. Krishan Kumar Gulati, E-128, (SF), Tagore Garden Extn., Delhi, in death certificate name of my father recorded as Krishan Kumar and in miscellaneous documents recorded as Kishan Kumar Gulati and Kishan Lal. All names of my father are one and same person. Correct name is Krishan Kumar Gulati.

PD(761)C
I, Channa Samy, Father of- JC-880420M Nb/Sub Singaravelu C, R/o- Vill & PO- Pannandur, TK- Pochampalli, Dist- Krishnagiri, Tamilnadu - 635123, have changed my name from Channa Samy to Chinnasami Kariyagounder, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Banxumathi, Mother of- JC-880420M Nb/Sub Singaravelu C, R/o- Vill & PO- Pannandur, TK- Pochampalli, Dist- Krishnagiri, Tamilnadu - 635123, have changed my name from Banxumathi to Banumathi Chinnasamy, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(764)C
I, Padma, wife of- JC-880420M Nb/Sub Singaravelu C, R/o- Vill & PO- Pannandur, TK- Pochampalli, Dist- Krishnagiri, Tamilnadu - 635123, have changed my name from Padma to Padma Singaravelu, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(765)C
I, Byomlata, W/o of No.16015340H Hav Mukesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Gorai, Teh- Iglas, Dist- Aligarh, U.P.- 202145 have changed my name from Byomlata to Byomlata Devi, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(765)C
I, Indrawati, Mother of No.16015340H Hav Mukesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Gorai, Teh- Iglas, Dist- Aligarh, U.P.- 202145 have changed my name from Indrawati to Indravati, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(766)C
I, Renu Bhardwaj, W/o- No.14648897A Hav Manoj Kumar, R/o- Vill- Tilkari Nagra, Teh- Rasra, Dist- Ballia, U.P. - 221711, have changed my name from Renu Bhardwaj to Renu Devi, vide affidavit dated 25/03/2026 before Notary Public U.P.

PD(767)C
I, Rina Mukherjee, Mother of No.15217135N Hav (OPR) Biswajit Mukherjee, R/o- Vill & PO- Bagda, Dist- Purulia, West Bengal- 723151, have changed my name from Rina Mukherjee to Rina Mukhopadhyay, vide affidavit dated 04/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Surjeet Singh S/o Yashwant Singh Rawat, R/o RZ-26P/39, Gali No. 30, Indra Park, New Delhi- 110045, declare that name of mine & my wife has been wrongly written as Surjeet Singh Rawat & Anju Rawat in my minor daughter namely Siya Rawat aged 10 years in her school record. The actual name of mine & my wife is Surjeet Singh & Anju Devi which may be amended accordingly.

PD(769)C
I, JC-332625F SubMaj Kuldeep, R/o- H.No.366, AK Gopalan Nagar, Khatipura, Jhotwara, Jaipur, Rajasthan-302012, declare that in my service record my wife's Name & D.O.B. is wrongly recorded as Sushma Devi- 15/04/1980 whereas her correct Name & D.O.B. is Sushma- 06/04/1980 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(770)C
I, Kamla Pant, W/o Sh. Vinod Kumar Joshi, R/o H.No.G-374A, Adarsh Enclave, Band Road. Joshi General Store, Phase-6, Aya Nagar, New Delhi-110047 (Arpit Joshi) informs that in Son's birth certificate my & my husband's name has wrongly been mentioned as Kavita Vinod Kumar instead of Kamla Pant & Vinod Kumar Joshi.

PD(795)C
I, Kamla Pant, W/o Sh. Vinod Kumar Joshi, R/o H.No.G-374A, Adarsh Enclave, Band Road. Joshi General Store, Phase-6, Aya Nagar, New Delhi-110047 (Ananya Joshi) informs that in daughter's birth certificate my name has wrongly been mentioned as Kavita Joshi instead of Kamla Pant. In future my Name is Kamla Pant for all purposes.

Public Notice
General Public is informed that Flat No. 218, in 'Gaur Residency', Plot Nos. 1 & 2, Chander Nagar, Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad (U.P.), owned by Dr. Sanjay Kumar Aneja & Mrs. Monika Aneja, is under Sale / Purchase. Any person having any interest/claim, whatsoever, contact prospective buyer M/s. Shelly Sharma C/o Mr. Pankej Chauhan, Mob. No. 9990711105, within 15 days, else no claim shall be entertained.

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE is hereby given that Trishla Jain (hereinafter called the seller/s) claims to be owner and in possession of **Third Floor of Property no 71 , Block C, Kirti Nagar, New Delhi** (herein after called the said property) by virtue of sale deed dated 30.06.2025 regd. Doc. No. Doc no **2025 / 221/8416** executed by **Anju Khera**, said Trishla Jain agreed to create a mortgage the said Property in favour of our clients **IDFC FIRST BANK LTD, Rajendra Place Branch**, any person/s having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/ registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise howsoever, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within **7days** from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof.

Vishal Diwan (Advocate)
Diwan & Company
Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19
Mobile No. 9818399999

PUBLIC NOTICE
My Clients Sh. Jageshwar Sharma & his wife Gyanmati Both R/o C-99 Gali No.9, Ph 10, Shiv Vihar Karawal Nagar, Delhi have severed all their relations & disowned their son Deepak Kumar Sharma and daughter in law Preeti from all movable immovable properties due to their misconduct. my clients shall not be responsible for their acts.
P.P. Upadhyay (Advocate)
Ch. No.615, 6th Floor, Lawyers Chamber Block, Rohini Court, Delhi-110085

MODI INDUSTRIES LIMITED
CIN - U15429UP1932PLC000469
Regd. Office: Modinagar - 201204. (U.P.)
Tel: 01232-243115, 9084786567
Email: modiindustriesslimited@gmail.com
Website: www.modiindustries.net
LOSS OF DOCUMENTS
TO WHOM SOEVER IT MAY CONCERN
It is hereby informed that the original Sale Deed executed by Mr. Manjoor Mohiuddin in favour of Mr. Umesh Kumar Modi S/o Rai Bahadur Gujarmal Modi registered at Sub Registrar Office, Modinagar at Bahi No.1, Volume No. 686, Pages No. 521 to 526 as document No. 2578 registered on 28.03.2001 admeasuring 1 Biswa Pukhta (130 Sq. Mtrs/0.0130 Hectares) situated at Kharsa No. 388 Kha at Village Sikri Khurd, Mohalla Umesh Park, Paragana Jalalabad, Tehsil Modinagar, District Ghaziabad, Pincode 120124 is lost. The use of the original title deed by any person and/or entity shall be illegal. The owner (i.e. Modi Industries Limited) have already registered a Police Complaint in this regard and are in process for obtaining a certified copy of the said document.
Modi Industries Limited
Date: 4th April, 2026

Office of the Superintending Engineer
3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh
Email: sepwdpth@rediffmail.com

Letter No. : 1181/984C(Yata-A)-03/2026

Dated : 04/04/2026

National Competitive E-Tender Notice

The Superintending Engineer 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh invites tender through E-Tendering (**Two Bid System**) on behalf of Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand for following works. All other information will be available online from **date 07-04-2026 at 5.00 PM** onward on website <http://www.uktenders.gov.in>

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Earnest Money (in Lac)	Cost of Tender (₹)	Validity of Tender (day)	Period of Completion (months)	Contractor's Category of Registration
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Protection work on Naini-Saini Devat Kumdar to Kanari motor road in Pithoragarh constituency of Pithoragarh district under Honorable Chief Ministers announcement number 521/2025.	4.16	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	04	Category "C" or above for Road works in any State Govt./Govt. of India/Govt. undertaking.

Gangster arrested in Badarpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A member of the Nasir-Danish Pahalwan gang, wanted in over 20 criminal cases, was arrested following a brief exchange of fire with the police in the Badarpur area of southeast Delhi, officials said on Saturday.

The accused, Mohammad Saleem alias Ganja (48), sustained a bullet injury in his leg during the shootout and

was later admitted to Safdarjung Hospital for treatment, they said.

According to police, the STF team had received specific information about the movement of Saleem, who was allegedly planning to commit a theft or burglary in the area.

"Acting on the tip-off, a team was deployed in Badarpur during the intervening night of April 3 and 4. When the suspect arrived on a scooter, he was signalled

to stop, but he attempted to flee," a senior police officer said.

During the chase, he lost control and fell on the road. He then pulled out a semi-automatic pistol and opened fire at the police team, firing two rounds.

The police team retaliated in self-defence, firing two rounds. During the exchange, one bullet hit the accused in his left leg, following which he was overpowered and taken into custody.

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक,
यूनिट-18, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज, उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम)
मकान सं०-7बी/108, बौद्ध विहार मझोला योजना सं०-4, भाग-2 (निकट संविधान साहित्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर आजाद पार्क के सामने) दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद-244103
पत्रांक - 769/एम-18/144
दिनांक : 02.04.2026
ई-निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय) की ओर से Construction of barat Ghar Mohalla Kayasthan Ward No. 03 at Nagar Panchayat Kundarki, District - Moradabad अनुमानित लागत रु० 147.17 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 06.05.2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 06.04.2026 से दिनांक 06.05.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement की वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 07.05.2026 को अपराह्न 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट-18, सी०एण्ड डी०एस०, उ०प्र० जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु० 10,000.00 + GST(18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्वोरमेंट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध हैं। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक,
यूनिट-18, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज, उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम)
मकान सं०-7बी/108, बौद्ध विहार मझोला योजना सं०-4, भाग-2 (निकट संविधान साहित्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर आजाद पार्क के सामने) दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद-244103
पत्रांक - 770/एम-18/145
दिनांक : 02.04.2026
ई-निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय) की ओर से Construction of Marriage Hall/ Barat Ghar at Nagar Palika Parishad, Dhampur, District - Bijnor अनुमानित लागत रु० 214.45 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 08.05.2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 08.04.2026 से दिनांक 08.05.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement की वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 09.05.2026 को अपराह्न 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट-18, सी०एण्ड डी०एस०, उ०प्र० जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु० 10,000.00 + GST(18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्वोरमेंट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध हैं। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

Chattarpur’s Mandi Road expansion project awaits approval

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly a year after the Delhi Government announced plans to hand over the widening of the crucial Mandi Road in Chattarpur to the NHAI, work on the project has yet to begin.

The 8.8-kilometre stretch, which connects Mehrauli in south Delhi to Faridabad in Haryana, remains heavily congested during peak hours, serving as a key link for commuters travelling between Gurugram and the Chattarpur area.

In April 2025, Public Works Department (PWD) Minister

Parvesh Sahib Singh announced that the project would be handed over to the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) and that the road would be declared a national highway.

However, the proposal to facilitate the handover is still awaiting approval, delaying the commencement of on-ground work. There was no response from the PWD minister on the matter.

“Given its role in facilitating freight movement to industrial zones and connecting to national highways, the project has broader national and regional significance beyond local urban

transit,” an official said.

According to an initial project report, the existing road is narrow and flanked by farmhouses, residential properties and individual shops.

The scale of land acquisition required prompted the Delhi government to propose transferring the project to NHAI, which is considered better equipped to handle such processes.

“We are trying to expedite the work on the widening of Mandi Road. There are some trees and other issues that are being worked out,” Gajinder Yadav, Chhatarpur MLA, said.



Mandi Road begins near the Chattarpur metro station on MG Road and extends to Faridabad Road, crossing into Haryana. Owing to its strategic importance and rising traffic demand, authorities have proposed that the stretch be declared a national highway and linked to NH-148A.

“In view of its strategic importance, existing and future traffic demand and its direct connectivity with NH-148A, Mandi Road of total length may be considered for declaration as a national highway,” the plan stated.

The road, however, continues to face heavy congestion

during morning and evening rush hours, with delays in approvals and land acquisition keeping the long-pending widening project on hold.

The road was conceptualised in 2012, and the central government agreed to pay almost 25 per cent of the total cost from its Urban Development Fund.

If constructed then, the road would have helped motorists avoid NH-48 today when commuting to Gurgaon and back, a nightmare at the moment because the lanes have been closed to facilitate the construction of two underpass-

es and a flyover to connect the highway with the Dwarka expressway.

Passing through some rural areas of the city with posh farmhouses, residential properties and individual shops on both sides, the width of Mandi Road is very inconsistent, varying at many spots between eight and 18 metres.

The road markings, streetlights, footpath and traffic signals are similarly inconsistent. Government officials said that PWD has been asked to widen the 9-km stretch to a consistent 30 metres and properly align it with the main MG road.

No LPG shortage in Delhi: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday firmly reassured residents that the supply of both domestic and commercial LPG in the capital is stable, adequate and well within control. She emphasised that there is no shortage of LPG — or any other fuel — in the national Capital and urged people not to be misled by rumours or panic, calling for calm and restraint.

Sharing the latest data, the Chief Minister said that on April 3, a total of 1,11,504 LPG bookings were recorded across Delhi.

In contrast, the three oil marketing companies together delivered 1,26,379 cylinders — well above the number of bookings.

This clearly indicates that pending demand is being rapidly cleared and that the supply chain is functioning efficiently and without dis-



ruption. As a result, the average delivery time for domestic LPG cylinders in Delhi has now reduced to 4.37 days, ensuring timely, reliable doorstep service for consumers.

To curb black marketing and hoarding, the government has established a dedicated control room (011-23379836 and 8383824659), which is continuously monitoring the situation and acting swiftly on complaints.

Acting on credible and verified inputs, several cases

were referred to the Delhi Police control room, following which coordinated action was carried out.

Police teams conducted 22 raids across multiple locations in the city. During one such operation in North Rohini, an FIR was registered, and six illegally stored LPG cylinders were seized.

The Chief Minister underscored that the Government remains fully vigilant and will continue to take strict action against any unlawful activities.

CM REKHA URGED PEOPLE NOT TO BE MISLED BY RUMOURS OR PANIC, CALLING FOR CALM AND RESTRAINT

The chief minister said the administration is maintaining constant oversight to ensure uninterrupted LPG supply and strict enforcement against any violations.

She advised residents not to crowd gas agencies or LPG godowns, stressing that once a cylinder is booked, it will be delivered directly to homes within the stipulated timeframe. Visiting distribution centres is unnecessary and only adds to avoidable inconvenience.

Reiterating the government’s commitment, the Chief Minister said Delhi is fully geared to ensure a seamless and uninterrupted LPG supply.

Govt plans drone clusters, smart governance, disaster response under new policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government’s proposed drone policy is likely to focus on creating drone research clusters, establishing dedicated flight testing facilities, enabling the use of drones in traffic management, and providing subsidies to support the drone ecosystem, officials said on Saturday.

According to officials, in a recently held meeting, the policy framework was discussed, where plans to rope in the Drone Federation of India (DFI), a leading non-government organisation in this area, were approved.

Earlier this year, the government set up a committee under the chairmanship of the IT department secretary to examine the feasibility of the Delhi Drone Policy.



“A comprehensive drone policy is being planned to ensure safe and regulated drone operations. Along with this, the government is working on an IT dashboard, a digital monitoring system to provide effective governance,” IT minister Pankaj Singh said.

According to officials, the policy’s key objectives include regulating drone usage to prevent misuse,

enabling government agencies to use drones for surveillance and mapping, and strengthening integration with the DGCA’s Digital Sky platform.

“The Delhi Drone Policy is focused around five focus areas, including public awareness and enforcement under these events, outreach, zoning signage, sensitisation workshops, safety framework and counter-drone

standard operating procedures will be worked out,” the official said.

Additionally, government drone usage will involve policing, disaster response, and traffic management in the city. “The policy also intends to plan the sector usage of drones in real estate projects, telecom and media,” officials added.

According to the plan, the government is considering capacity-building initiatives like drone awareness workshops in schools, establishing centres of excellence, setting up Remote Pilot Training Organisations (RPTO), and launching pilot training projects. “A supporting drone ecosystem, facilities like drone clusters for research, flight testing facilities, and subsidy and state GST reimbursement could be part of the policy,” the official said.

Govt deploys trash skimmer machines at Najafgarh Drain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has deployed two advanced dual-purpose weed harvester cum trash skimmer machines at the Najafgarh Drain — one of the biggest contributors of pollutants into the Yamuna. The machines were formally inaugurated and flagged off by Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh.

The Najafgarh Drain has long carried floating waste, invasive weeds, and untreated pollutants into the Yamuna. By targeting the problem at its source, these machines are expected to significantly reduce the pollutant load entering the river while also improving



drainage efficiency across the city.

Powered by a 112 HP engine and equipped with a storage capacity of approximately 14 cubic metres, the machines can cut, collect, and remove dense aquatic vegetation such as water hyacinth along with floating trash. Built with marine-

grade steel, they are designed for durability across varied water conditions, including shallow stretches.

Their advanced conveyor system ensures continuous harvesting and unloading, enabling faster and uninterrupted operations.

With a combined invest-

ment of ₹2.90 crore, the initiative reflects a clear shift towards modern, technology-led solutions in urban governance. Officials confirmed that the machines are ready for immediate deployment following the inauguration.

Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said that cleaning Najafgarh Drain is directly linked to cleaning the Yamuna. We are now using modern, made-in-India machines aligned with the vision of Swachh Bharat to deliver real, visible change. These dual-purpose harvesters are not just machines - they represent technology-led governance in action.”

“Built on a stable catamaran design and equipped with a dual weed-cutting

system, these machines can efficiently remove weeds and floating waste in one go. This ensures continuous cleaning, better water flow, and reduced waterlogging. Our focus is clear - efficient systems, effective execution, and outcomes that people can see on the ground,” the minister added.

Officials emphasised that beyond routine maintenance, the deployment will strengthen flood preparedness ahead of the monsoon while contributing meaningfully to the larger mission of Yamuna cleaning.

The flag-off marks a shift from reactive measures to proactive, technology-backed governance, where cleaner drains will lead to a cleaner Yamuna and a more resilient Delhi.

Govt forms dedicated cell for better coordination of departments, agencies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has formed a dedicated special internal cell under the Urban Development Department for more efficient coordination of the stakeholder agencies involved in development works.

The decision to constitute the 20-member cell, including officers from the Delhi Jal Board, Public Works Department, Irrigation and Flood Control, Environment and Forest, Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and Delhi Development Authority (DDA), among others, was taken in a meeting of a high-level committee on the rejuvenation of



the Yamuna chaired by the Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last month, they said.

The cell headed by the member secretary of the Delhi Pollution Control Committee will discharge the function of submitting draft compliance reports. It will coordinate the issues among the departments concerned and the exchange of information.

The panel will also work as a coordination committee for road-cutting permissions

between departments. Restoration of streets in unauthorised colonies and villages where sewer networks and house connections are in place or yet to be laid out will also be coordinated by the committee, the officials said.

All work agencies will share their plans over a year, a decade and 15 years for effective coordination and synchronisation of developmental efforts and avoiding multiple road-cutting through clubbing work.

The departments and agencies have been directed to cooperate with the cell, adhere strictly to the prescribed timelines and submit regular status of work, they added.

Govt tightens norms for supply of commercial LPG cylinders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has tightened norms for the supply of commercial LPG cylinders, making it mandatory for businesses to either have or apply for a Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connection in areas where the network is available, according to an official order.

In an order issued by the Food, Supplies and Consumer Affairs Department on April 2, the government amended a key clause of its recently notified policy on distribution of commercial LPG cylinders.

Under the revised rules, commercial and industrial consumers will be eligible to receive LPG supplies only if they are registered with the concerned oil marketing company (OMC) and have applied for a PNG connection, wherever the network exists.

According to the order, in areas where PNG infrastructure is not yet in place, consumers will be required to submit an application expressing their intent to switch to PNG once it becomes available.

Officials said OMCs will be required to verify documents at least once to ensure compliance with these conditions. Records of



consumers who have expressed intent to shift to PNG will also be shared with Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) for further action.

“When supplying to commercial gas consumers, the OMCs shall at least once collect documentation records to ensure that the consumer is registered with the OMC and has either applied for a PNG connection or has submitted an application indicating the intent to obtain a PNG connection upon its availability,” the order stated.

The order also provides some flexibility. Businesses that need LPG alongside PNG for their operations

can apply to the additional commissioner of the department, explaining their needs. A decision on such requests will be taken in consultation with the three OMCs.

“The OMCs could also collect such applications and submit them to the Additional Commissioner for a prompt decision. The Additional Commissioner shall promptly dispose of the same in consultation with the three Oil Marketing Companies,” the order stated.

The rest of the policy, notified on March 26 along with a subsequent addendum, will remain unchanged, the order said.

746 challans in week-long crackdown to decongest IIT intersection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A week-long enforcement drive at the busy IIT intersection in south Delhi saw 746 traffic challans issued, including 329 for improper parking, as authorities moved to ease chronic congestion at the arterial junction, the Delhi Traffic Police said on Saturday.

The intersection, where Outer Ring Road meets

Aurobindo Marg, faces daily bottlenecks due to CNG queues, roadside parking near commercial establishments, and peak-hour school traffic, they said.

“During the drive, 746 challans were issued, including 329 for improper parking, to improve compliance and ensure smoother flow of traffic,” a senior traffic police officer said.

The drive, led by the traffic police along with Delhi



Transport Corporation and local stakeholders, focused

on clearing encroachments, enforcing lane discipline and

regulating vehicle movement at key pressure points.

Authorities also deployed personnel at all four arms of the intersection to prevent roadside parking, regulated queues at the CNG station, and directed establishments and the nearby school to manage entry and exit more efficiently. “A joint deployment has been put in place to regulate traffic and facilitate pedestrian movement at the junction,” the officer added.

Indian traditional knowledge is pillar of our soft power: Speaker

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

“Astrology represents a civilisational effort to understand time not as a sequence of moments but as a meaningful continuum,” says Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Saturday at the Astro Cultural Mahotsav, Astro Conclave 2026.

Gupta emphasised the profound necessity of introspection in modern life. Speaking at the Constitution Club of India, Gupta remarked that in an era dominated by the “speed of discourse,” platforms that encourage patient inquiry and traditional wisdom are vital for maintaining societal harmony and direction.



The speaker highlighted that India’s civilisational journey has always been defined by a unique synthesis of reason and intuition. He noted that astrology, in its classical sense, is not merely a practice but a philosophical effort to understand time as a meaningful continuum.

Gupta observed that such systems of knowledge reflect a deep-seated belief in the interconnectedness of

human existence and the cosmos, inviting a sense of reflection and humility that remains deeply relevant in the 21st century. Emphasising the global impact of Indian heritage, Gupta spoke about the role of traditional knowledge as a pillar of India’s “soft power.”

He stated that when India’s intellectual traditions, including philosophy, arts, and ancient sciences, are presented with authenticity and intellectual clarity, they serve as powerful bridges for international dialogue.

He noted that the world increasingly looks toward India’s rootedness to find a balance between modern advancement and ancient wisdom.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Election of the Executive Committee of Shri Ram Mulakh Darbar (Regd.no. 17882) held on 26.03.2026 at Sanyas Road, Kankhal, Haridwar, for the year 2026-27.
The General Public and all the concerned Government Departments are duly hereby informed that the following valid members of Shri Ram Mulakh Darbar were elected on 26.03.2026 in the AGM of SRMD, as the newly constituted Governing Body of Shri Ram Mulakh Darbar Society for the year 2026-27 under the chairmanship of, a social worker, Mr. B. S. Rawat Ji.
President: Guru Maa Smt. Prabha ji, Senior Vice-President: Param Pujya Acharya Bal Krishna ji and Shri C. D. Grover ji, General Secretary: Smt. Anjlina Puri Ji , Secretary: Dr. Neha Sharma ji and Shri Deepak Kumar Garg ji,Treasurer: Smt. Smarika ji, MEMBERS OF THE EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE: - Sh. Rachit Rawat Ji, Sh. Vinod Bansal Ji, Sh. Tilak Raj Ji, Smt. Nisha Dhura, Shri B. S. Rawat Ji and Shri Jagmohan Ji were elected as EC of SRMD (Regd. No. 17882)
Guru Maa Smt. Prabha Ji, President: Shri Ram Mulakh Darbar, Sanyas Road, Kankhal, Haridwar

IN FOCUS



A National Security Guard personnel with a dog during rehearsals ahead of a joint exercise in preparation for Ujjain Simhashta-2028 at Lal Parade Ground in Bhopal

PTI

IIT (ISM) Dhanbad to host R&D fair from April 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Dhanbad

The IIT (ISM) Dhanbad in Jharkhand will host a two-day national research and development fair from April 6 on innovation-driven growth, an official said on Saturday.

Jharkhand Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar will inaugurate the 'InvenTiv 2026', which will be attended by prominent dignitaries and industry leaders, including Athar Sahab, managing director of Zuari Industries, Vaishali Nigam Sinha, co-founder of ReNew Foundation and Sandeep Kumar of Tata Steel, according to a statement issued by the institute.

"InvenTiv 2026 is not just about showcasing innovations, but about creating pathways for their adoption

and impact. By bringing together academia, industry and investors, we aim to accelerate the journey from ideas to implementation and contribute meaningfully to India's innovation-driven growth," IIT (ISM) Director Prof Sukumar Mishra said.

By aligning research outputs with national priorities, the platform aims to speed up the journey from laboratory prototypes to scalable, market-ready solutions, while reinforcing India's push towards 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' and Make in India, the release said. The two-day event will also feature MoU signings, seed fund support to startups, technology demonstration zone inaugurations, investor interactions, academia-industry matchmaking, and startup pitching sessions, it added.

Investigation agencies now harassing locals: CM Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday claimed the culprits behind the violence and gherao of judicial officers in Malda district's Mothabari have escaped, and investigators were harassing the innocent locals in the name of the NIA, the agency assigned to probe the case.

Addressing an election rally at Manikchak in Malda, she urged the gathering not to approach judicial officers scrutinising 'under adjudication' cases post-SIR. Instead, submit applications before tribunals for the re-inclusion of names of those erroneously removed from the voters' list, the TMC supremo



said. Apparently referring to the ISF and the AIMIM, Banerjee said, "Two communal parties gheraoed the judges and escaped. Now, investigators are harassing innocent locals in the name of the NIA. They have picked up some 50 innocent people in the name of investigation."

She let out a gasp of disbelief after an overwhelming number of hands were

raised from those attending the public meeting in Manikchak when Banerjee asked for a show of hands of those whose names were deleted from the electoral rolls. "There is no need to hold political rallies and meetings of our party. My priority is to extend help to these people to apply before tribunals to include the names wrongly deleted from the electoral rolls," the TMC

supremo instructed the party's local leaders present on the stage.

Blaming Union Home Minister Amit Shah for the electoral roll purge, Banerjee addressed the BJP leader as "Motabhai" and alleged that he was driving a wedge through the officers' fraternity in the state administration in the name of pre-election transfers.

Seven judicial officers were held hostage inside the local BDO office in the Mothabari area of Malda district, and an eighth was confined inside a vehicle for about nine hours on Wednesday after a large crowd, protesting post-SIR deletion of names from voters' lists, turned violent by blocking roads, vandalising vehicles and attacking police personnel.

Rescue mission intensifies as US aircrew missing

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

A high-risk search operation is underway after a US fighter aircraft was brought down over Iranian territory, leaving one crew member still unaccounted for and raising fresh concerns about the conflict's trajectory.

According to US officials cited by US media, two personnel were aboard the aircraft when it went down.

One has since been recovered, while efforts continue to locate the second, believed to have ejected over hostile terrain. The Pentagon and US Central Command have yet to publicly comment on the incident. The unfolding situation has shifted attention from aerial dominance to the dangers faced by American personnel on the ground. The prospect of a US service member evading



capture inside Iran presents a complex challenge, combining urgent rescue priorities with the risks of deeper military exposure.

Reports indicate that helicopters deployed for the recovery mission came under fire but managed to withdraw safely. In a separate development, another US aircraft crashed in the

region after being hit, though its pilot ejected successfully. Details regarding injuries remain unclear.

Iranian authorities have meanwhile called on civilians to assist in locating the missing crew member, with images circulating online that allegedly show debris from the downed jet. The aircraft is believed to be an

F-15E Strike Eagle, which typically carries a pilot and a weapons systems officer.

Military experts note that while US aircrew receive specialised training to survive behind enemy lines, operating undetected in unfamiliar territory—particularly without language proficiency—adds to the difficulty of such situations.

The episode comes at a sensitive moment in the conflict. US President Donald Trump has recently projected confidence about weakening Iran's military capabilities, even as tensions continue to escalate on multiple fronts. The latest incident, however, underscores the unpredictability and human risks of the war.

Iranian regional officials have issued stark warnings, suggesting rewards for those who locate or detain the missing airman, intensifying

fears over the individual's safety. Beyond the immediate rescue effort, the broader conflict continues to take a toll. US casualty figures have risen, and questions persist over the effectiveness of military operations against Iran's remaining capabilities, particularly its missile and drone arsenal.

The war has also had far-reaching consequences, from instability across the Middle East to rising energy costs affecting global markets.

At home, public opinion in the United States appears increasingly wary, with growing calls for a quicker resolution to American involvement.

As the search continues, the fate of the missing crew member remains uncertain—serving as a stark reminder of the personal stakes behind a widening geopolitical conflict.



CM Yogi visits a stall during School Chalo Abhiyan in Varanasi

PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Varanasi

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday served mid-day meals to children on the launch of the 'School Chalo Abhiyan' and distributed textbooks and gifts to the students, an official statement said.

During the programme, Adityanath, along with dignitaries, released the booklet titled 'Shaikshik Navachar Evam Uplabdhiyan'. A short

film related to the campaign was also screened.

The chief minister, along with other officials, served mid-day meals to the students at the Composite School in Shivpur and urged children to come to school every day.

He also distributed textbooks for the new academic session.

Adityanath presented certificates to 5 "nipun" schools of the district and as many students.

Kishan Reddy remarks on Telangana CM is laughable: Cong



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Hyderabad

TPCC official spokesperson Bandi Sudhakar Goud strongly criticized Union Minister Kishan Reddy, stating that his comments on the implementation of the Six Guarantees are utterly laughable.

He said that while Chief Minister Revanth Reddy is moving forward with effective governance by systematically fulfilling the promises made to the people before the elections, Kishan Reddy, unable to digest the growing public support for the Chief Minister, is resorting to spreading blatant falsehoods. Sudhakar Goud remarked that Kishan Reddy is speaking like a blind man who refuses to see the reality, despite having clear evidence before him. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Revanth Reddy, Telangana is witnessing the phased implementation of the Six Guarantees, including farmer loan waivers, 200 units of free electricity for nearly 50 lakh households, free bus travel for women, Indiraam housing for the homeless poor, Aarogyasri health scheme for the underprivileged, fee reimbursement for students, and the creation of around 60,000 jobs.

He questioned whether Kishan Reddy is unaware of these achievements and urged him to introspect.

Snow in hills, rain in plains as western disturbance sweeps north India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The higher reaches of Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir on Saturday witnessed fresh snowfall as a spell of wet weather gripped north India, bringing rainfall to parts of Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan.

Rains and hailstorms have continued to lash the northern states intermittently this week, with wheat growers in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan staring at major losses due to crop damage.

The national capital, meanwhile, witnessed rain during the night between Friday and Saturday in isolated areas. However, the maximum temperature in the city dropped due to persistent cloudy conditions throughout the day. In Jammu and Kashmir, the snowfall also led to the closure of many important



Residents clear snow following fresh snowfall, in Sissu, Lahaul and Spiti district of Himachal Pradesh

PTI

inter-district roads, officials said.

The Met Office warned of brief but intense heavy showers in isolated parts, which may lead to flash floods and landslides at a few vulnerable places and waterlogging in a few low-lying areas.

Sadhna Top and other higher reaches in Kupwara, Mughal Road in Shopian, Margan Top connect-

ing Anantnag with Kishtwar, and Razdan Top, Gurez, and Tulail in Bandipora district, received fresh overnight snowfall.

The Affarwat mountain in Gulmarg tourist resort, the Sonamarg-Zojila axis, and some other hilly areas of the valley also received snowfall. The plains of the valley, including the summer

capital Srinagar, received rains, they added. The wet weather brought down the day temperature across the valley as people had to layer up to battle the fresh cold.

Similarly, both maximum and minimum temperatures decreased in Himachal Pradesh, with light to moderate rain and snowfall observed in several areas.

The Shimla Meteorological Office has issued an orange alert for hailstorms, thunderstorms, lightning, and gusty winds with speeds of 40 to 50 kmph in the Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi, and Shimla districts on Tuesday and Wednesday.

In the higher reaches of Lahaul and Spiti and Kullu, fresh snowfall was witnessed over the past 24 hours since Friday evening. The weather department also predicted a wet spell in the state till April 10. In the national capital, the

minimum temperature rose to 20.7 degrees Celsius, which is 1.9 degrees above normal and 1.5 degrees higher than the previous day. In contrast, the maximum temperature reached 32 degrees Celsius, two degrees below normal and one degree lower than the day before.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president at Skymet, said, "This is due to the presence of a cloud cover, as a result of which lesser heat penetrates during the day and lesser heat escapes from the earth's surface at night."

Additionally, the air quality in Delhi showed significant improvement due to fresh showers and gusty winds the day before. The 24-hour average air quality index (AQI) was reported at 137 (moderate) at 4 pm on Saturday, compared to an AQI of 266 (poor) recorded at the same time on Friday, according to

Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data. Parts of Rajasthan recorded rainfall and gusty winds over the past 24 hours due to a cyclonic circulation with more thunderstorms and hail activity forecasted for the region in the coming days, the IMD said on Saturday.

"A new and strong western disturbance is likely to become active over parts of Jodhpur and Bikaner divisions from the afternoon of April 6, leading to a high possibility of thunderstorm and rainfall activity in some areas," the IMD said.

The impact of the cyclone is expected to peak on April 7. "Under its activity, several parts of Jodhpur, Bikaner, Ajmer, Jaipur, Bharatpur and Kota divisions are likely to experience strong thunderstorms, gusty winds of 50-60 kmph, moderate to heavy rainfall and isolated hailstorms," it said.

FROM PAGE - 1

In Kerala, PM sends strong message...

Speaking at another public address in Pathanamthitta district, Modi said that the saffron party workers in the State have signalled a strong mood to bid farewell to the Left rule. On the Sabarimala gold loss issue, Modi said that the LDF and UDF conspired to defame pilgrimage to the shrine and now the temple has become "a target of their loot".

Late evening in neighbouring poll-bound Tamil Nadu, Modi held a meeting with senior leaders of the BJP in the State at a private hotel in Chennai. According to party sources, Modi held the meeting with senior leaders, including Union Commerce Minister and BJP's election in-charge for Tamil Nadu, Piyush Goyal, Minister of State for Information and Broadcasting, L. Murugan, State BJP President Nainar Nagenthiran and former State presidents Pon. Radhakrishnan, Tamilisai Soundararajan, and K. Annamalai.

The meeting lasted nearly 45 minutes, in which BJP's national in charge and co-in charge for Tamil Nadu, Arvind Menon and P. Sudhakar Reddy, respectively, and the party's women's wing national president, Vanathi Srinivasan, were also present. The leaders apprised Modi regarding the ongoing election-related work in the State, sources said.

Trump issues fresh ultimatum to Iran

The renewed warning suggests that those efforts may have stalled. Iran has not officially responded to the latest ultimatum, but previous statements from Tehran have rejected external pressure and warned against military threats. The situation

therefore remains volatile, with the risk of miscalculation on both sides. The Strait of Hormuz remains one of the most critical corridors in the world, with a substantial share of global oil shipments passing through it. Any disruption in the waterway could have immediate consequences for international energy markets, potentially driving up oil prices and fuelling economic uncertainty worldwide.

Chadha calls AAP allegations scripted

"The first allegation is that when the Opposition walks out of Parliament, I remain seated and do not join them. This is completely false—a blatant lie. I challenge anyone to show even a single instance where the Opposition walked out and I did not join them. The Parliament has CCTV cameras everywhere—bring out the footage and the truth will be clear," he added.

"The second allegation is that I refused to sign the impeachment motion against the Chief Election Commissioner. This too is false. No leader from the party ever asked me—formally or informally—to sign it. In fact, several Rajya Sabha MPs from the party themselves did not sign the motion. So why is the blame being placed solely on me? Moreover, such a motion requires 50 signatures in the Rajya Sabha, and that number could easily have been met. So why the noise?" he said.

Speaking about the third allegations of raising "trivial issues" in the Parliament, Chadha said: "The third allegation is that I am afraid and therefore raise trivial issues. Let me clarify - I did not go to Parliament to shout, create chaos, or break micro-

phones. I went there to raise public issues. I have spoken on GST, income tax, Punjab's water, Delhi's air pollution, the condition of Government schools, strengthening public healthcare, and problems faced by passengers in Indian Railways. I have even raised issues like menstrual health, which people often hesitate to discuss, along with unemployment and inflation. You can check my four-year parliamentary record - I went there to create impact, not disruption."

Bhadrakol signals West Bengal polls may...

The remaining 68 percent the Hindu majority, forms the decisive battleground. BJP's internal calculus aims for 42 percent of these majority votes, a threshold that, when combined with an additional three percent shift of women voters peeling away from TMC, could decisively turn the tables on TMC.

Women, often the silent arbiters in Bengal's family-level political decisions, are showing signs of disillusionment with issues of safety and economic stability. The RG Kar Medical College incident and the general law and order situation has not gone down well with women and young voters.

BJP's layered targeting of voters with caste, gender and urban governance has revealed a sophisticated understanding of micro-trends that traditional pollsters sometimes miss.

Leader of Opposition Suvendu Adhikari, the BJP's most recognizable face in the state, is taking the fight directly to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. By contesting from Bhabanipur seat, considered Mamata's tra-

ditional turf alongside his Nandigram base, Adhikari is forcing a high-stakes symbolic battle. The BJP's decision to field heavyweights like Dilip Ghosh in Kharagpur Sadar further stretches TMC's defensive lines across South Bengal's semi-urban and industrial belts.

Adhikari's move reframes the election as a referendum on leadership credibility, governance delivery, and the limits of personality cults. This is not mere symbolism; it is an intellectual challenge to the TMC's narrative of invincibility.

For decades, Bengal's educated elite prided itself on a secular, progressive ethos that kept communal forces at bay. Yet today, sections of that same elite academics, professionals, and cultural voices in South Kolkata and the Howrah-Hooghly axis are reassessing.

The shift is not born of majoritarian zeal but of pragmatic disillusionment; repeated cycles of violence, perceived minority appeasement at the cost of majority security and a governance model that prioritises street-level control over institutional integrity. The BJP's pitch, in this context, is less about ideology and more about restoration of rule of law, economic opportunity, and administrative competence.

But the deeper story is already written in the streets and drawing rooms of Hooghly, Howrah and South Kolkata. Bengal's intellectual class, long the custodian of the state's political conscience, appears to be signalling that governance failures can no longer be papered over by identity politics.

The 2026 verdict may not just decide who rules it may mark the moment Bengal's voters chose pragmatism over patronage, order over chaos and a new political equilibrium.

India secures Iranian oil supplies, dismisses claims of disruption

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India has affirmed that its energy imports remain stable despite ongoing disruptions in West Asia, stating that crude oil and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supplies — including those sourced from Iran — are proceeding without difficulty.

In a statement issued on Saturday, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas rejected speculation about supply constraints and clarified that Indian refiners have already secured adequate crude for the coming months. It also underlined that there are no payment-related obstacles affecting imports from Iran.

The clarification comes in response to reports and social media claims suggesting that a shipment of Iranian crude intended for Vadinar port in Gujarat had been rerouted to China due to



payment issues. The ministry categorically dismissed these assertions as inaccurate.

Explaining the mechanics of global oil trade, officials noted that cargo destinations mentioned in shipping documents are often provisional. Shipments can be redirected mid-journey based on commercial considerations and operational flexibility, making such diversions a routine aspect of the business rather than a sign of disruption.

India, which sources crude from over 40 countries, allows its refining companies the freedom to procure supplies from a wide range of markets depending on pricing and logistical factors. The Government reiterated that this diversified sourcing strategy continues to safeguard the country's energy security.

Addressing concerns over LPG availability, the ministry also confirmed the arrival of an

Iranian LPG cargo at Mangalore. The vessel, carrying approximately 44 thousand metric tonnes, docked on April 2 and is currently unloading, countering claims of any disruption in gas supplies.

Notably, this is the first time in several years that India has publicly acknowledged sourcing energy from Iran. Prior to 2019, Tehran was among India's key oil suppliers, contributing a significant share of its crude imports. However, purchases were curtailed after the United States withdrew from the Iran nuclear agreement and reinstated sanctions, which led to the termination of sanction waivers for countries including India.

The latest statement signals a pragmatic approach by New Delhi as it navigates volatile global energy markets while ensuring uninterrupted supply for domestic needs.

BJP *atmanirbhar* in polls only when ECI is supporting it: Sibal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal on Saturday cited examples of five voters who were allegedly registered both in West Bengal and Bihar to take a swipe at the BJP, saying the party is only *'atmanirbhar'* in elections when the Election Commission of India is supporting it.

Sibal's allegations come days after West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee accused the BJP of trying to include illegal voters from NDA-ruled Bihar, Rajasthan, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh in the electoral rolls of West Bengal to turn the poll outcome in favour of the



saffron party.

Addressing a press conference here, Sibal said, "Way back in November last year when elections were taking place in Bihar and Chhath puja was over, I showed a video - four trains were sent to Bihar from Karnal and other parts of Haryana and I alleged that these trains were being sent for the purposes of

voting in Bihar."

"The railway ministry had then made a statement that these were being sent for Chhatt puja and I then mentioned that Chhath puja was over in October so why were they being sent later," he said.

Then the railway ministry gave an explanation that when there is a rush, it normally runs these trains, Sibal said and pointed out that he countered the ministry by releasing a video in which people on trains were heard stating that they were being sent by the chief minister and that money was being paid by BJP.

Then the railway ministry kept quiet, he added. So the point is that even in elections they are only *'atmanirbhar'*

when the election commission is with them, Sibal said.

"Now what is happening in West Bengal? If you remember we had made allegations to the effect that in Maharashtra 40 lakh voters were added and 5 lakh voters in Delhi were added. These issues were raised by several political parties but after the polls," the Independent MP said.

Luckily in West Bengal, things have come to light before the polls, Sibal said.

"We have the instance of at least five people who are voters in Bihar and are registered both in Bihar and West Bengal," he said and went on to list those five voters while displaying their details and Epic numbers in the two States.

AAIB flags safety lapses in Pawan Hans chopper crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

A preliminary report by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has revealed that critical safety protocols were not followed in the crash of a Pawan Hans helicopter near Mayabunder in the Andaman & Nicobar Islands. The accident, which occurred on February 24, resulted in the death of one passenger and serious injuries to several others.

In its preliminary report on the accident, the AAIB recommended that the aviation safety watchdog conduct spot checks on the operations of all commercial helicopter operators to check their compliance with this requirement. The body also recommended to the DGCA to sensitise its pilots to arm floats for all applicable operations.

A Pawan Hans helicopter crashed into the sea after taking off from Ranghat helipad in the Andaman & Nicobar Islands with seven persons on board for Mayabunder helipad on February 24 was not activated during the approach.

The Pawan Hans's Airbus helicopter AS365N3 bearing registration number VT-PHY on approach to Mayabunder helipad, which was conducted by the co-pilot, after turning on to finals, "descended with high rate of descent" and crash landed into the sea, as per the preliminary report.



"On contact with water body, the helicopter floats did not activate. The helicopter toppled to its Starboard side and as the depth of the sea at the crash location was only 4-5 ft, the port side of the helicopter was above the water-line," it said.

In the accident, one passenger died, two passengers including one infant suffered serious injuries and two passengers sustained minor injuries while both the crew escaped unhurt, the preliminary report stated.

"The floats were not armed in the cockpit during the approach, although the same is required by the Standard Operating Procedure for operations at Port Blair as approved by the DGCA in the company operations manual," the AAIB said in the preliminary report.

The floats or emergency flotation system of a helicopter are inflatable bags installed on the machine to prevent sinking after a water landing.

Kerala CM Vijayan slams Rahul over nuns' attack remark

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Saturday slammed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his allegation that he had sided with those who attacked nuns in Chhattisgarh, terming the remarks "ignorant and an instance of excessive rhetoric."

The arrest of two Catholic nuns from Kerala in BJP-ruled Chhattisgarh in July last year on charges of human trafficking and forced religious conversion triggered a political row in the State, with Congress and CPI(M) targeting the saffron party over the incident.



In a strongly worded statement, Vijayan said Rahul appeared to have forgotten the Congress party's role in enabling legal provisions that are now being

Owaisi slams Gujarat's UCC Bill; calls it unconstitutional

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) chief Asaduddin Owaisi on Saturday said the Uniform Civil Code Bill and the amendment to the Disturbed Areas Act passed recently by the Gujarat assembly are unconstitutional.

After a marathon debate of more than seven hours, the Gujarat assembly last week passed the UCC Bill that seeks to put in place a common legal framework to govern marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion.

It stipulates a seven-year jail term if marriages are conducted through force, coercion or fraud, and also prohibits bigamy and polygamy. It makes registration of marriages and live-in relationships mandatory.

The assembly also passed a Bill to amend the Gujarat Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property and Provision for Protection of Tenants from Eviction from Premises in the Disturbed Areas Act 1991.

"The UCC is a directive principle, not a fundamental right. It is mentioned in Article 44 of the Constitution. During the constituent assembly debate, Babasaheb Ambedkar did not say that after the code is framed, the State shall enforce it upon

all the citizens. The code shall apply only to those who make a declaration and voluntarily agree to be bound by it," Owaisi claimed.

In the Bill, which is a "cut-paste" of the one passed in Uttarakhand, the Hindu Marriage and Divorce Act and the Hindu Succession Act have been applied to all communities except for the Scheduled Tribes, so it is not a uniform bill, he told reporters.

"It is violating Article 25 (freedom of religion) of Muslims. They are the affected party. It is unconstitutional. If someone has to get a divorce now, they'll have to prove adultery and stay in judicial custody. This is all a part of the Hindu religion. Why are you applying it to us (Muslims)?" Owaisi asked.

He also slammed the provisions in it regarding live-in relationships and questioned the RSS and BJP on it. It destroys the sanctity of marriage and is against Islam, Owaisi contended.

The Bill to amend Gujarat Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property and Provision for Protection of Tenants from Eviction from Premises in the Disturbed Areas Act 1991 introduces a clearer definition of "aggrieved person" to include not just the buyer and seller of a property, but any resident living within the notified specified area, he said.



All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) President Asaduddin Owaisi addressing a press conference in Ahmedabad, Gujarat

Jammu and Kashmir failed to utilise development funds: CAG

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Painting a dismal picture of finances in the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir, a latest report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India for the year 2023-24 has brought to light the complete failure to utilise funds meant for developmental activities and asset creation.

On the other hand, highlighting serious procedural lapses, the CAG report pointed out that an amount of ₹5,214.45 crore was incurred under 35 schemes

and sub-heads in nine grants without budgetary provisions during 2023-24.

According to the CAG report, "The entire budget provision of ₹10,597.90 crore under 31 Grants involving 160 schemes remained unutilised during the year," resulting in denial of benefits to the public.

The audit also flagged a "rush of expenditure" at the end of the financial year. "Expenditure exceeding 50 per cent of the total was incurred in March 2024 under 11 major heads across 10 grants," it noted.

Referring to the broader

financial management violations in Jammu and Kashmir, the CAG in its report noted that savings amounting to over ₹34,000 crore were not surrendered by various departments during 2023-24, in violation of prescribed budgetary norms.

The CAG has recommended a series of corrective measures to improve financial management in J&K, stressing the need for realistic budgeting and stronger expenditure controls.

As per the Jammu and Kashmir Budget Manual, departments are required to



surrender anticipated savings to the Finance Department.

"It was noticed that savings under 36 Grants and two Appropriations amounting to ₹34,917.96 crore (32.99 per cent) were not surrendered at all," the CAG report

on finances for the year ended March 31, 2024, said.

The CAG said that similarly, a total provision for expenditure during 2023-24 was ₹1,57,212.90 crore.

"The actual gross expenditure during the year was

₹1,26,054.97 crore (80.18 per cent). This resulted in savings of ₹31,157.93 crore during 2023-24 which were not surrendered," the report said.

The CAG report also clearly indicated that the overall expenditure remained about 20 per cent lower than the total Grants and Appropriations.

The CAG said that more than half of the allocated funds remained unspent in ten key departments. These include Tribal Affairs (₹455.44 crore, 80 per cent), Public Health Engineering (₹5,357.21 crore, 70 per cent), Industries and Commerce (₹739.98 crore, 68

Nation Focus



PM to launch BJP's Bengal campaign from Cooch Behar

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to visit Cooch Behar on Sunday to launch the BJP's campaign for the West Bengal Assembly elections, a senior party leader said. Modi is scheduled to address a 'Bijoy Sankalpa Sabha' at the historic Ras Mela grounds around noon, marking the start of the party's intensified outreach in north Bengal.

During the rally, Modi is expected to outline the party's vision for a "developed West Bengal," highlight issues raised in the BJP's recently released 'people's chargesheet' against the ruling TMC Government in the State, and focus on governance, law and order, and alleged corruption.



Even God is not safe in Kerala, alleges Nirmala Sitharaman

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday raised the Sabarimala gold loss issue during an NDA poll campaign event at Perumbavoor and said even 'God is not safe' in Kerala. While addressing party workers during a roadshow, she said the southern State may be known as 'God's Own Country'. "But God is not safe in Kerala. Even Lord Ayyappa's gold was taken away. So, my humble request is that...we don't want UDF and LDF anymore in the State," Sitharaman said. Launching a scathing attack on the CPI(M)-led ruling LDF and the Congress-led UDF, she accused the traditional fronts of mismanaging Kerala's economy through alternate stints in power.

Stalin challenges NDA over three language policy in Tamil Nadu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Sankarankovil

Chief Minister MK Stalin on Saturday alleged Prime Minister Narendra Modi has made the people wait for cooking gas cylinders and claimed people ask "Modi ji where is LPG?" and wondered if the PM had answers.

Addressing an election rally here, Stalin threw an open challenge to Union Education Minister Dharmendra

of the nuns in Chhattisgarh and that senior party leaders had intervened on the ground.

In contrast, the Left veteran alleged that the Congress response lacked sincerity, with only some Kerala leaders reacting, while the party's leadership in Chhattisgarh remained largely silent.

Posing a question to Rahul, the CM asked whether the Congress would be willing to repeal similar laws in States where it is in power, including Himachal Pradesh.

"As far as the CPI(M) is concerned, Rahul Gandhi need not attempt to judge the party by the Congress's political standards," Vijayan added.

Stalin challenges NDA over three language policy in Tamil Nadu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Sankarankovil

Chief Minister MK Stalin on Saturday alleged Prime Minister Narendra Modi has made the people wait for cooking gas cylinders and claimed people ask "Modi ji where is LPG?" and wondered if the PM had answers.

Addressing an election rally here, Stalin threw an open challenge to Union Education Minister Dharmendra



Pradhan, PM Modi and Amit Shah and asked whether the NDA had the courage to declare during their election campaign that they would implement the 3-language policy in Tamil Nadu.

The DMK president said in this election too, people must give a resounding defeat as a gift to the alliance formed by the AIADMK, which had pushed Tamil Nadu into a pit in every field during its ten-year rule, and the BJP, which is driving the country towards an unprecedented decline.

States Focus



PUNJAB GEARING UP FOR SIR OF ELECTORAL ROLLS: CEO

Punjab is gearing up for the upcoming SIR of electoral rolls, with all preparatory activities progressing in a structured and time-bound manner in anticipation of a notification from the Election Commission regarding the SIR exercise schedule, officials said on Saturday. Highlighting the progress achieved so far, Punjab Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Anindita Mitra, informed that a comprehensive pre-Special Intensive Revision (SIR) mapping exercise has been undertaken across all districts of the state. According to the latest data as of April 4, 74.27 per cent of the electors in Punjab have been mapped with the last intensive revision records.



PALANISWAMI SLAMS STALIN FOR DUBBING AIADMK ANTI-MUSLIM

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami has lashed out at DMK chief M K Stalin, saying the chief minister was painting his party as "anti-Muslim" just because an alliance was formed with the BJP. Addressing an election rally at Ambur near here on Friday, the AIADMK chief gave a point-by-point rebuttal to several accusations made by Stalin. The leader of the Opposition said that Stalin says "Edappadi Palaniswami has seen many failures", and this statement smacked of arrogance, and he needs to go back into the past.

Double engine misusing institutions to delete voters: TMC's Abhishek

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Saturday targeted the BJP for its "double-engine" pitch, saying one engine runs on misusing democratic institutions and the other on recruiting "local agents" like AIMIM, ISF and AJUP to stoke "communal discord".

In a play of words, he said in a social media post that the people of Bengal will choose a Government that is of the people, by the people, and for the people and not a dispensation that is "off the people, buy the people, and far from the people".

"Double engine this, double engine that. You know what the BJP's real double engine is? One engine runs on misusing democratic institutions, weaponising the Election Commission to delete genuine voters, transferring honest officers to destabilise the state machinery, and illegally importing outsiders to rig the electoral rolls," Banerjee said.

"The second engine runs on recruiting local agents



like AIMIM, ISF and AJUP to stoke communal discord, create unrest, split votes, and hand over advantage to the BJP. But the people of Bengal have seen through this dirty game completely," the Diamond Harbour MP alleged in the social media post.

Banerjee, the national general secretary of the TMC, said Bengal will choose "Maa-Mati-Manush", a political slogan coined by party supremo Mamata Banerjee.

Later, addressing a political rally in Birbhum, Abhishek Banerjee alleged that the Narendra Modi Government at the Centre has forced people to stand in queues for hours during

demonetisation, LPG crisis and Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls.

"The BJP takes hasty decisions every time without considering the consequences and their effect on people."

Accusing the BJP of plotting to omit lakhs of names from the electoral rolls under the garb of SIR, he said anyone whose name does not figure in the electoral rolls post-SIR, the TMC will extend help for them for re-inclusion of names into the poll list.

"From roads, to Parliament and in the Supreme Court, the TMC has always stood by the people," he said.

CM Vijayan afraid of Modi as he wants to protect his children, alleges Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kochi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday launched a scathing attack on Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, alleging that he is "afraid" of Prime Minister Narendra Modi because he wants to protect his children.

Addressing an election rally in Fort Kochi, Rahul claimed that the CM was "compromised" by corruption and made an apparent reference to the Exalogic case allegedly involving his daughter,

without naming anyone.

The case involves allegations of illegal financial transactions between Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) and Exalogic Solutions, a now-defunct IT firm owned by Vijayan's daughter, Veena.

"Which father will not try to protect his children? But the problem is that you allowed things that now require protection. You did things that require protection," he said.

Rahul said it was important to understand whose protection a Left Front leader was



Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addressing a public meeting ahead of Kerala Assembly elections in Alappuzha, Kerala

EC suspends 4 cops over Suwendu nomination chaos

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Saturday directed the suspension of four Kolkata Police officials and initiation of disciplinary proceedings against them for "failing" to maintain law and order during BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari's nomination filing in the hotly contested Bhabanipur seat.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah had accompanied Adhikari for the filing of the nomination papers on April 2 in the seat in south Kolkata, where the leader of the Opposition in the outgoing Assembly is pitted against incumbent Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

In a communique to the West Bengal chief secretary, the poll panel said the direction is based on a recommendation from state Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal.

The massive directed action against Kolkata Police's Deputy Commissioner (DC-II), South Division, Siddhartha Dutta, Officer-in-Charge of Alipore Police Station Priyankar Chakraborty, Additional OC Chandi Charan Banerjee, and Sergeant Saurabh Chatterjee.



"The commission has agreed to the proposal and directs that the aforementioned police officers be suspended and disciplinary proceedings be initiated against them immediately," it stated.

The poll body has asked the state authorities to ensure that its directions are implemented without delay and that a compliance report be submitted by 11 am on Monday.

Moreover, the poll panel has sought an urgent proposal from the state Government to fill up the vacant posts, including that of DC-II, South Division, and the officer-in-charge positions at Alipore Police Station.

The BJP held a massive roadshow before the filing of the nomination on April 2 that moved through the constituency, considered Mamata Banerjee's bastion, with Shah and Adhikari standing on an open-hood, flower-decked vehicle.

seeking. "He is seeking the protection of the most right-wing forces in the country. That is the nature of politics in Kerala," he alleged.

"The CM is sacrificing governance to protect his children. His past actions had trapped him, with the people of Kerala bearing the consequences," he claimed.

Rahul further alleged that the LDF was no longer a Left formation but had aligned with "the worst political force" in the country, which he said targets people based on their faith—whether Christians, Muslims,

Sikhs or Jains. He termed it a "direct attack" on the Constitution of India, which guarantees freedom of belief.

"How can the CM stand with them? How can he not feel ashamed after his Left training? He is aligned with this force," Gandhi said, adding that Vijayan must answer to the people of Kerala.

Rahul also reiterated his criticism of Modi, alleging that the PM was under pressure from US President Donald Trump over issues related to the Adani Group and the Epstein files.

Congress turned Barak Valley into crime hub: Nitin Nabin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ram Krishna Nagar (Assam)

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Saturday alleged that the previous Congress governments in Assam had turned Barak Valley into a "crime hub" for vote bank politics. He said people punished the grand old party for its "politics of appeasement of infiltrators" by voting it out of power in the state.

Addressing a poll rally in support of the party's Ram Krishna Nagar candidate in Sribhumi district, Nabin said, "Previous governments had turned Barak Valley into a crime hub for vote bank politics. The politics of appeasement was at its peak as Congress governments were more concerned about infiltrators than the local people."

He said people decided to

"punish" the Congress and voted it out of power, and installed a BJP-led NDA Government with a "clear vision for development".

He exuded confidence that the NDA will retain power in the northeastern state with a massive mandate in the April 9 elections.

Asserting that the BJP-led Government has ensured taking forward 'Virasat-vikash' (heritage-development) together, Nabin said crime has been checked in the southern part of the state.

"No criminal dares to trouble the people anymore as they know that Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma will not spare anyone," he said. The BJP national president listed the various developmental initiatives of the Government in the last 10 years, while pledging to take forward the progress.



AINRC-BJP alliance exhausted, DMK-Congress confused: TCK's Vijay

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Puducherry

Attacking both the ruling and Opposition blocs in poll-bound Puducherry as having failed the aspirations of the local people, TVK chief Vijay on Saturday positioned his party as a credible alternative, promising 100 per cent efforts to secure full statehood and a slew of welfare measures including free electricity.

The actor-politician labelled the ruling AINRC-BJP combine as "exhausted," and the Congress-DMK bloc as "confused."

"In Tamil Nadu too, the DMK-Congress is a confused alliance. In Puducherry too, it is similarly a confused alliance. Then there is another alliance, the alliance of NR Congress (AINRC) and BJP. That is not a joined alliance; it is an exhausted alliance that couldn't stay

together," Vijay said.

Canvassing votes for his party nominees for the April 9 polls, he said, "I have selected candidates who stand with the people on the ground. I have entrusted them to you. We stand on the side of our people. Our people stand on your side.

The atmosphere in the coastal town was electric hours before the TVK chief arrived at the venue. Thousands of supporters and fans lined the arterial roads of Puducherry, waving the party's dual-colored flags and shouting slogans of "Thalapathy" (commander), as he is addressed.

The road leading to the rally site was a sea of yellow and maroon, with massive cut-outs of the leader flanking the streets. Despite the sweltering heat, the crowd remained undeterred, transforming the roadshow into a vibrant display



Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief Vijay during a roadshow in Puducherry on Saturday

of strength that brought traffic to a standstill across major intersections.

Opening his speech by introducing his candidates for Orleampet and Thattanchavady, the latter witnessing a contest between Chief Minister N Rangasamy and former CM Ve Vaithilingam (Congress), Vijay

urged the electorate to shun the traditional blocs.

He said DMK-Congress alliance is so "confused" that in some constituencies, "they even oppose each other" despite being allies. "It is an alliance only in name," he remarked.

Targeting the ruling bloc, the TVK leader alleged that

AINRC and the BJP are constantly at loggerheads, creating a climate of uncertainty.

"One day there is news that there is an alliance, and the next day they say there isn't. They are playing a political game using us as a tool," he said, asserting that TVK is contesting alone to maintain its integrity.

Vijay focused on the long-standing demand for Puducherry's statehood. He questioned why neither the Congress nor the BJP had granted statehood despite both having held power at the Centre for several years.

"The late Sushma Swaraj-led committee recommended statehood 20 years ago, yet no Government has implemented it," he pointed out. He vowed that a TVK administration would work relentlessly to obtain "full statehood without the interference of the Lieutenant Governor".

Foreign delegations to be on 2-day Assam visit from April 8

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Foreign delegations from various election management bodies will visit Assam for two day Assam Polls - Foreign delegations from April 8 in connection with the forthcoming assembly polls in the State. The visiting team will comprise representatives from several countries, including Angola, Bhutan, Egypt, Portugal, Sri Lanka, Mexico, Benin, and Croatia, an official release said on Saturday.

Elections to the 126-member Assam assembly will be held on April 9. Votes will be counted on May 4. The initiative under the International Election Visitors' Programme (IEVP) aims to provide an opportunity to observers from



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at an election rally in Mahmara, Charaideo Assam

abroad to witness and understand India's electoral processes first-hand, it said.

On April 8, the delegates will participate in briefings by the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), and visit dispatch centres and control rooms to observe the poll preparedness at the field level. They will visit multiple polling stations in some Assam districts on April 9 to observe voting procedures, security arrangements and use of election technologies, the release said.

The programme is designed to showcase the scale, transparency, and robustness of India's electoral process, while fostering international cooperation and the exchange of best practices in election management, it added.

PROSPECT

PATNA, THRISSUR STUDENTS
TOP ACAD QUAD CROSSWORD



Dhairya Pandey of Don Bosco Academy, Patna; Shraddha Shree of St Michael's High School, Patna; Jacob Brahmakulam of Thrissur, Kerala; and Ramakrishnan Krishnan of Chennai have won the First position in four different categories of the online daily crossword challenge known as ACAD QUAD for the month of March 2026. The competitive phase of this year-long contest runs between February 1 and October 31 every year. The categories in which Dhairya, Shraddha, Jacob, and Ramakrishnan have stamped their superiority are ACAD School, ACAD College, ACAD Senior, and ACAD Global, respectively. According to a Press release, in the School category, Dilkhus Kumar and Bittu Kumar, both from Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Residential School, Begusarai, Bihar, have, respectively, won 2nd and 3rd positions. Samridhi Salgaonkar of Goa Dental College and Tisha Taneja of IIT Madras have taken 2nd and 3rd positions, respectively, in the College category.

NBCC UNVEILS SUSTAINABLE,
NEW-AGE CORPORATE OFFICE



Srinivas Katikithala, Secretary, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), inaugurated the newly renovated Corporate Office of NBCC (India) Limited at Lodhi Road, New Delhi. Sanjeet, Joint Secretary & Financial Advisor, MoHUA, Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), Ritu Pande, CVO, along with Independent Directors and senior officers of the company were also present on this occasion.

The inauguration ceremony was marked by traditional rituals, including a pooja ceremony, lamp lighting, and unveiling of the inauguration plaque, followed by a walkthrough of the upgraded office premises and interaction with senior officials and employees.

Addressing the gathering, Katikithala lauded NBCC's continued contribution to nation-building through its role in executing landmark infrastructure and redevelopment projects. He emphasised the importance of modern, efficient, and sustainable workplaces in enhancing productivity and fostering innovation within public sector enterprises.

On the occasion, CMD, NBCC, expressed gratitude to the Chief Guest for his presence and guidance, and reiterated the company's commitment to evolving as a modern, agile, and people-centric organisation aligned with national priorities.

The renovated corporate office, spread across approximately 40,000 sq ft, marks a significant milestone in NBCC's organisational growth and transformation.

Nutrica launches yellow mustard
oil, boosts natural cooking lineup

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lifestyle and wellness brand Nutrica of fBN Agritech Limited has announced the launch of Nutrica Yellow Mustard Oil, further strengthening its portfolio of natural cooking essentials, offering families and home cooks a pure and authentic kitchen staple that supports everyday cooking without compromising on taste or quality.

With consumers increasingly moving towards cleaner and more natural cooking ingredients, Nutrica Yellow Mustard Oil unrefined to retain its natural antioxidants and full-bodied nutrition, caters to health-conscious families, fitness enthusiasts, and home cooks who seek authentic flavours without compromise. It preserves the natural aroma, taste, and nutritional value of yellow mustard seeds, making it a dependable choice for everyday Indian cooking, from tadkas and sauteing to curries, marinades, and traditional recipes.

Nutrica Yellow Mustard Oil stays true to tradition by preserving the rich taste and natural character of mustard without chemical processing, making it a trusted choice for families seeking genuine and reliable kitchen staples. The product is available in two convenient pack sizes, a 1 Litre PET bottle and a 5 Litre tin container, catering to both nuclear and joint family



enthusiasts, and home cooks who seek authentic flavours without compromise. It preserves the natural aroma, taste, and nutritional value of yellow mustard seeds, making it a dependable choice for everyday Indian cooking, from tadkas and sauteing to curries, marinades, and traditional recipes.

Nutrica Yellow Mustard Oil stays true to tradition by preserving the rich taste and natural character of mustard without chemical processing, making it a trusted choice for families seeking genuine and reliable kitchen staples. The product is available in two convenient pack sizes, a 1 Litre PET bottle and a 5 Litre tin container, catering to both nuclear and joint family



PROF GEETA
BHATT

It has been nearly two decades since the Indian Young Lawyers Association filed a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) in the Supreme Court questioning the limitations imposed on the entry of women in the Sabarimala Temple at Periyar Tiger Reserve in Keralam. Since then, a verdict was given by the five-judge constitution bench in 2018 which held that the limited entry of women in the temple was unconstitutional. It was later referred to the bench for a review petition in 2019 and is now set to commence arguments from April 7, 2026 in front of a nine-judge bench of the Supreme Court. This is an extraordinary situation where secular justifications and misogynistic allegations have been used to adjudicate matters which are rooted in religious faith.

The deity at Sabarimala, Lord Ayyappa is 'Naisthik Brahamchari', a lifelong celibate who resides in his abode, the Sabarimala temple. Hence, the women of a given age were restricted from entering the temple. The court case which had been filed earlier portrayed the said practice as obscurantist and biased against women in the age group of 10 to 50 years of age. The prejudice towards the biological clock of women was the major bone of contention in the court arguments while completely ignoring the living faith and nature of tradition at Sabarimala. Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) which governs the temple, informed

that more than 51 lakh devotees, both men and women visited Sabarimala from 2025-26 thereby, generating 429 crore as contributions from devotees. The 'Memoir of the Survey of the Travancore and Cochin States' written by British lieutenants, Benjamin Swain Ward and Peter Eyre Conner published in 1893 and 1901 States their observation of the tradition where more than 15,000 men and women attended the festival but women of certain age had restrictions. The LDF State Government in 2018 threw its weight behind unrestricted entry of women in the submitted affidavit to the court and the Supreme Court judgement the same year declared the ban on entry of women unconstitutional.

The State Government's subsequent move to enforce the 2018 verdict met with significant public backlash. Lakhs of devotees were driven to bring the entire state to standstill in defence of their deity; temple hundis overflowed not with offerings but with paper strips inscribed with Ayyappa's name and the temple priest (Tantri) handed over the temple keys to the state rather than presiding over what was seen as the dishonour of age-old traditions.

Constitutional morality when seeks to protect legitimacy of equality, dignity, freedom in legal framework, it is also bound to protect the Hindu deities who are recognised as per law 'juristic entities' capable of owning property and paying taxes. The lone dissenting judge in the 2018 Sabarimala judgement, Justice Indu Malhotra had stated that the belief in a deity, and the form in which it manifests itself is also a fundamental right protected by Article 25(1) of the Constitution.

A matter of faith is being project-



ed selectively as discriminatory towards women when temples dedicated to women devotees are present within 200 kms of the vicinity of Sabarimala. Attukal Bhagvathy temple in Tiruvananthapuram is devoted to goddess Bhadrakali and allows only women devotees to pray inside during the ten-day Pongal festival. This all-women temple festival holds a Guinness book of world record for the largest congregation of women at a single place. Chakkulathukavu temple in Alappuzha district every year has 'Nari Puja' (worshipping of women) as a tradition where the head priest washes the feet of women as a gesture symbolising the divine status women are bestowed in Bhartiya culture.

The argument to allow women devotees between the age of 10 to 50 into Sabarimala takes away the right of Lord Ayyappa to reside in celibate form in this temple. Even those who take the pilgrimage to

Sabarimala, follow the abstinence ritual for 41 days for Lord Ayyappa's blessings so as to follow the deity's ascetic yogi avatar in the temple, detaching from material desires, focusing on inner cleansing. It becomes pertinent to note here that the litigants want rights for women to pray the Lord in a particular temple even though there are hundreds of Lord Ayyappa temples across Keralam where both men and women can pray. The tradition of celebrating the menstruation of goddess at the Shiva Parvathy Chengannur temple in the four day festival celebrating feminine energy where the goddess is taken in a large procession to the river on an elephant, later received by Shiva at the temple gate where they encircle the temple premises as a couple is a reflection that menstruating women are no taboo in the context of the arguments placed in Sabarimala court case.

The upcoming hearing of the

review petition has included cases of other religions like the entry of Muslim women in mosque, entry of Parsi Women in fire temple after marrying a non-Parsi and the practice of female genital mutilation (FGM) among the Dawoodi Bohra community. Linking of cases which pertain to practices which have entirely different religious tenets with the practice followed in Sabarimala is not appropriate as the concerns raised about other religious practices are on dignity to life and discriminatory social traditions largely practised towards women.

For example, in the Hindu belief system, gods and goddesses are acceptable when they take human form and live human lives but the same would be considered blasphemous among Muslims. These cases need to be addressed separately, in the context of whether such practices are considered immoral or contrary to public order or socially harmful. Each and every place of worship has its distinct version of cultural sanctity which is pivotal to the deity. It is incumbent of the State to give equal rights to all for worship sans interference in their belief to stand as a secular State.

The devotees of Lord Ayyappa stand firmly with the deity which has compelled the present State Government to dilute its earlier stand of supporting the 2018 Supreme Court judgment regarding entry of women in age group 10 to 50 in the temple. Traditions and cultural practices evolve with time but the distinction of social evils from the right of a devotee, character of worship in a religious denomination to connect to the deity reflects on the wisdom and sensibility of the State and judiciary.

The author is Director of Non-Collegiate Women's Education Board (NCWEB)

IFFCO posts record pre-tax profit of ₹4,106 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a landmark achievement for the Indian cooperative sector, the Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Limited (IFFCO) has clocked an all-time high pre-tax profit of over ₹4,106 crore for the financial year 2025-26. Announcing the results, IFFCO Chairman Dileep Sanghani described the performance as a "saga of victory" and a testament to the enduring spirit of the cooperative movement.

The fertiliser major, which began its journey in 1967 with a modest 57 societies, now stands as a global titan representing over 36,000 societies. Sanghani attributed the success to the hard work of farmers and the dedication of employees, while expressing "heartfelt gratitude" to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the central leadership for their constant guidance.

The financial year saw IFFCO setting new bench-



marks in logistics and demand fulfilment. The cooperative recorded sales of 118.75 lakh metric tonnes of fertilisers, against a nationwide supply of 119.68 lakh metric tonnes. The Chairman noted that the rising sales of urea and DAP have further solidified IFFCO's pivotal role in ensuring national food security.

A significant highlight of the year was the rapid adoption of nano-fertiliser technology. Sales of nano-products exceeded 30.1 lakh bottles, with Nano Urea Plus and Nano

DAP emerging as cost-effective, eco-friendly alternatives for the farming community.

"We have paved the way for a new revolution in Indian agriculture," Sanghani said, highlighting that Nano NPK Liquid and Granular variants have been notified under the Fertiliser Control Order — a world first. To meet growing demand, IFFCO inaugurated its fourth nano-fertiliser plant in Devanahalli, Bengaluru, boosting total production capacity to nearly 950,000 bottles per day. Beyond balance sheets, the

cooperative has made significant strides in social responsibility. Effective November 1, 2025, IFFCO implemented a guaranteed minimum wage of ₹20,000 per month for contract employees, a move that benefited thousands and cost the organisation approximately ₹140 crore.

On the international front, IFFCO's footprint now spans 40 countries. Plans are currently underway to establish a joint venture for nano-fertiliser production in Brazil, taking Indian innovation to the global stage.

Reiterating the organisation's commitment to the Prime Minister's vision of 'Viksit Bharat @ 2047', Sanghani emphasised that IFFCO would continue to harmonise modern technology with organic practices. He also thanked Union Ministers Amit Shah, JP Nadda, and Shivraj Singh Chouhan for their unwavering support in navigating global supply chain challenges.

Assam Rifles seize ₹2.10 cr heroin in Silchar

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a major anti-narcotics success, Assam Rifles Battalion, in coordination with the Police, carried out a swift, intelligence-based operation in the general area of Meharpur.

During the operation, suspect movement was detected, and the vehicle attempted to evade the security forces, leading to a brief chase before being intercepted. The swift response by the joint team resulted in the recovery of 30 soap cases of heroin weighing approximately 349 grams, with an estimated market value of ₹2.10 crore.

Three individuals were apprehended in



connection with the recovery. The recovered contraband, along with the apprehended individuals, has been handed over to the police for further investigation.

MCGL captains ratify terms for inaugural season

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

In a departure from the traditional administrative-heavy governance of club sports, the Matrix Club Golfers League (MCGL) convened its franchise owners and team captains at the Grand Hyatt on Golf Course Extension Road this Thursday. The session served as a final "alignment" before the league's inaugural season tees off on April 8 at the ITC Classic Golf & Country Club.

Founded by Manjit Bagri and operated under the Matrix Golf banner, the MCGL is positioning itself as a league built on the architecture of peer accountability rather than bureaucratic oversight. The pre-season roundtable saw captains from across the Delhi NCR scrutinising player manifests



with a level of intensity usually reserved for championship Sundays.

What sets the MCGL apart in the competitive amateur circuit is its reliance on self-governance. In a bold move, the league requires no official handicap certificates. Instead, handicaps are self-

declared, resting on the social pressure of a community where most competitors have played alongside one another for years.

"The league will take its shape from the way it is played, not from how it is promoted," stated Manjit Bagri, Founder of MCGL. This philos-

ophy was put to the test during the ratification session, where rosters were vetted by rival captains. Once a captain signs the manifest, they waive the right to protest a rival's handicap, effectively making the course the final arbiter.

The league adopts a fixed squad system, eschewing the "one-off" entry model of typical club tournaments for a structured season that requires each franchise to commit a 14-member roster. This squad is bifurcated into two distinct categories: the Alpha Tier, comprising eight players with handicaps ranging from 0 to 12, and the Omega Tier, consisting of six players competing with handicaps between 13 and 18.

To prevent "sandbagging," the league has introduced a "Live Calibration" safeguard. If a player's gross score in Stroke Play falls four or more strokes

below their declared handicap, the handicap is reduced immediately. This adjustment is applied retrospectively to the current round and prospectively for the remainder of the season.

The inaugural season, running from April 8 to May 15, consists of eight matchdays following a round-robin format leading into semi-finals and a final. With a targeted prize purse of ₹15,00,000, the stakes are high for the amateur circuit.

As the captains filed their signed manifests at the close of the Gurgaon meet, the atmosphere was one of mutual respect and competitive tension. With the terms of engagement now set in stone, the focus shifts to the fairways of the ITC Classic, where the first matches of this experiment in self-governed golf will begin next week.

Karuna Gopal to represent India at
global futurist dialogue in Moscow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant recognition of India's growing influence in urban transformation and futuristic governance, Karuna Gopal, President of the Foundation for Futuristic Cities, has been invited by the Russian Embassy to address the International Open Dialogue titled "The Future of the World: A New Platform for Global Growth" in Moscow.

The high-level summit is poised to serve as a non-politicised, solutions-oriented forum, drawing senior policymakers and eminent industry leaders from over 100 countries. The dialogue will focus on critical themes of global governance, sustainable development, and human-centric economic and technological progress.

The official invitation extended to Gopal highlights her "high global reputation and outstanding versatile expertise in urban transformation and future cities." It further noted that her unique skill in fostering societal dialogue makes her contribution to the international forum "invaluable."

As a renowned global thought leader and futurist, Gopal has graced the international stage at prestigious events such as the Artificial Intelligence Journey (AIJ) 2024 and the BRICS Innovation Forum 2023 in Moscow, the Commonwealth Local Government Conference (CLGC) 2023 in Rwanda,



and the landmark COP21-UNFCCC in Paris. Her expertise is highly sought after by world leaders, evidenced by her keynote at the World Government Summit in Dubai in 2018, delivered upon the personal invitation of the UAE Prime Minister.

Beyond her work with the Foundation for Futuristic Cities, Gopal currently leads the Policy Research division for Women within the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Her expertise in emerging technologies is further evidenced by her role as the Advisor for the Centre of Excellence in AI for Sustainable Cities at IIT Kanpur.

She has also contributed to India's public sector governance, having served on the Board of Engineers India Limited (EIL) under the Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

The Moscow dialogue is expected to reinforce the collaborative efforts between nations in navigating the complexities of the 21st-century technological landscape while ensuring sustainable urbanisation.

FROM THE

WORLD

NETHERLANDS

Dutch police

probe blast

Dutch police are investigating a small explosion outside a Christian centre that promotes Israel. Police in Gelderland province said in a post on X that nobody was injured in the explosion on Friday night and that it caused only limited damage at an address in Nijkerk, in the central Netherlands. Police appealed for witnesses and said nobody has been arrested. The group Christians for Israel said the detonation targeted its Israel Centre in Nijkerk and was caused by an explosive device.

In a statement on its website, the group expressed shock and said the blast fits a pattern of attacks on Jewish sites that are intended to sow fear. Authorities reinforced security around Jewish sites in the wake of explosions last month outside synagogues in Liege.

PAKISTAN

Dacoits steal Govt equipment

Dacoits in the riverbed areas who once robbed people on the highways between Sindh and Punjab provinces of Pakistan have now started stealing equipment, including surveillance cameras, installed for the security of the travellers. The worst hit is a 200-kilometre stretch on the Sukkur-Multan motorway (an access-controlled road) from Sukkur in Sindh to Rahim Yar Khan in Punjab province. A senior police official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said surveillance cameras, speed cameras, solar panels, lights, accessories and poles have been removed by these dacoits. "They have also damaged solar reflectors and switched off street lights, which makes it easier for them to carry out their activities," he said.

He revealed that dacoits have been stealing highway surveillance cameras since last month, severely hindering law enforcement's ability to monitor security and enforce speed limits.

2 men and boy ordered to stay in UK custody



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Two young men and a boy were ordered Saturday to remain in custody after appearing in court on arson charges in the torching of four ambulances owned by a Jewish charity in London.

The March 23 blaze in Golders Green, a north London neighbourhood with a large Jewish population, destroyed four ambulances belonging to the volunteer organisation Hatzola Northwest, which provides emergency care in the area. Oxygen cylinders in the vehicles exploded, breaking windows in an adjacent apartment block.

British men Hamza Iqbal, 20, and Rehan Khan, 19, and a 17-year-old of dual British-Pakistani nationality, all from east London, were charged Friday with arson and being reckless as to whether life would be endangered. The younger man cannot be named for legal reasons because he is under 18 and will be held in a youth detention centre.

Strike hit close to Bushehr nuclear facility, says Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

Iran's atomic agency says an airstrike has hit near its Bushehr nuclear facility, killing a security guard and damaging a support building. It is the fourth time the facility has been targeted during the war. The agency announced on Saturday's attack on social media.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on social media on Saturday that radioactive fallout from continued attacks on the Bushehr nuclear power plant "will end life" in regional capitals, not Tehran.

He accused Western governments of remaining silent about the repeated attacks



Israeli security forces inspecting damage at an apartment building struck by an Iranian missile in Israel AP

on the plant. The fourth attack on the Bushehr complex occurred Saturday, killing a security guard and damaging a support building. No increase in radiation levels was reported, according to the International Atomic Energy Agency.

Bushehr is located some 750 kilometres south of Iran's capital, Tehran.

The facility uses low-enriched uranium from Russia, along with Russian technicians, to supply about 1,000 megawatts of power for Iran.

Mediators are still working on a ceasefire

Mediators from Pakistan, Turkey and Egypt are still working to bring the United States and Iran back to the

negotiating table, according to two regional officials.

The regional powers are working on a compromise to bridge the gap between the American and Iranian demands to stop the war and reopen the crucial Strait of Hormuz, they said.

They said the yet-to-be finalised compromise aims at paving the way for both sides to meet in Pakistan.

It includes a cessation of hostilities for a certain period of time to allow a diplomat settlement, according to a regional official involved in the efforts and a Gulf diplomat briefed on the matter.

They spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss closed-door diplomacy. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas

Araghchi on Saturday reiterated his government's willingness to restart talks in Pakistan, but said they seek a "conclusive and lasting" end of the conflict. Araghchi said he spoke by phone Friday with Turkey's foreign minister to discuss the latest developments.

Meanwhile Meloni assured Qatar's leader during a visit Saturday that Italy would contribute to restoring Qatari energy infrastructure damaged by Iranian bombing, noting its natural gas production is critical to global energy security, her office said in a note.

Meloni is the first EU, G20 and NATO leader to visit the Gulf region since the start of the US-Israel war on Iran.

Pak would hit Kolkata in 'future' conflict: Asif

M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

Pakistan's Defence Minister Khawaja Asif on Saturday warned India that it would respond with a strike in Kolkata to any "future misadventures." "If India tries to stage any false flag operation this time, then God-willingly, we will take it to Kolkata," Asif said while talking to reporters at his hometown of Sialkot, some 130 kms from Lahore.

He claimed that there are reports that a false-flag operation has been designed through their own men or through the Pakistanis in their detention by laying down some



Pakistan's Defence Minister Khawaja Asif

bodies somewhere and saying "they were terrorists and had done so and so." He, however, did not provide any evidence in support of his claim.

On Thursday, Asif said that Pakistan's response to any attack would be "swift, calibrated, and decisive."

Asif was responding to the remarks by his Indian counterpart Rajnath Singh, who earlier said that any "misadventure" from India's neighbour in the prevailing situation would invite an "unprecedented and decisive" action.

The Pahalgam attack that took place on April 22 last year resulted in a four-day conflict between the two countries. (PTI)

7 Nepalese injured by debris of missiles in Abu Dhabi

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Seven Nepali nationals, who sustained injuries from the debris of missiles intercepted by the UAE's air defence system in Abu Dhabi, "are out of danger", Nepal's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Saturday.

"Six of the injured have already returned to work after receiving treatment, while one remains under medical care," according to the ministry's spokesperson, Lok Bahadur Chhetri.

Due to the escalating conflict in West Asian countries, Foreign Ministry officials are working even on holidays to gather information on the situation, he said. The Nepali Embassy in Dubai has also confirmed that all those injured on Friday are out of danger. The embassy has informed that it is in contact with the injured Nepalis. Embassy officials have already met with



Bulldozer removes the rubble of a destroyed building in an Israeli airstrike in Lebanon AP

four of those who were discharged from the hospital on Friday. "All four of them are in good condition, and coordination is underway to provide necessary assistance," Chhetri said.

The Nepali national currently undergoing treatment in a hospital is recov-

ering and is expected to be discharged in a few days, he added. Chhetri stated that the Foreign Ministry is regularly monitoring the situation in the UAE and other countries, ensuring that those in difficulty receive timely assistance from relevant authorities.

European ministers push for energy profit caps

DEREK GATOPOULOS
■ Brussels

The finance ministers of Spain and four other European countries are urging the European Union to impose a bloc-wide wind-fall tax on energy companies, concerned that surging oil and gas prices driven by the war in Iran will fuel inflation and strain households.

Spanish Economy Minister Carlos Cuerdo said on Saturday that his counterparts from Germany, Italy, Portugal and Austria had signed a letter to the European Commission citing "market distortions" caused by the price spike.

"The conflict in the Middle East has caused oil prices to rise, placing a significant



Spanish Economy Minister Carlos Cuerdo

burden on the European economy and on European citizens," the letter, dated Friday and made public by Cuerdo in an online post, said.

"It is important to ensure that this burden is distributed fairly," it added.

Europe is largely dependent on imported oil and

gas, leaving it vulnerable to external shocks. In 2022, turmoil in energy markets following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine pushed inflation into double digits in many European countries.

At the time, the EU imposed a "solidarity contribution" that included caps on excess energy profits. "Given

the current market distortions and fiscal constraints, the European Commission should swiftly develop a similar EU-wide contribution instrument," the letter said.

"It would also send a clear message that those who profit from the consequences of the war must do their part to ease the burden on the general public." Driven largely by higher oil prices, the annual inflation rate in the 21 countries that use the euro rose to 2.5 per cent in March, from 1.9 per cent in February.

Iran has blocked most tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz — a choke-point for about 20 per cent of global oil — in a move that threatens to stress fuel markets for months. (AP)

Fire at a gas lighter factory near Bangladesh's capital kills 5 people

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dhaka

A fire broke out at a factory manufacturing gas lighters near Bangladesh's capital on Saturday, leaving at least five people dead, authorities said.

The blaze broke out in the Kadamtali area of Keraniganj near Dhaka.

Seven firefighting units were deployed to extinguish the blaze, the fire department said. It took several hours to bring it under control.

Firefighters recovered five bodies by the evening and they couldn't immediately be identified.



People look at the charred remains of a gas-lighter manufacturing factory in Keraniganj on the outskirts of Dhaka, Bangladesh PTI

Floods triggered by heavy rain in Afghanistan leave 77 dead in 10 days, say authorities

ABDUL QAHR AFGHAN
■ Kabul

Widespread flooding, landslides and lightning strikes triggered by heavy rain and storms across Afghanistan have left 77 people dead and 137 injured over the past 10 days, the country's Disaster Management Authority said on Saturday.

More rain has been forecast for the coming days throughout Afghanistan, and the authority warned the public to stay away from river banks and areas prone to flooding.

So far this year, dozens of people have died due to extreme weather in



Residents carrying furniture in a wheelbarrow as they clear an area damaged by heavy flooding in Jalalabad AP

Afghanistan, an impoverished country that is highly vulnerable to extreme weather events.

Earlier this year, heavy snowfall and flash floods left dozens of people dead across the country.

The recent toll includes 26 people killed over the past 48 hours, the disaster authority said. Overall, 793 homes have been completely destroyed and a further 2,673 have been damaged, while floods and landslides have destroyed 337 kilometres (about 210 miles) of roads, it said.

Businesses, agricultural land, water wells and irrigation canals have also been

damaged, with more than 5,800 families affected overall, the authority said.

Several highways connecting the country's capital to the provinces have also been damaged by floods and landslides, forcing travellers to take long, circuitous routes to reach Kabul, Public Works Ministry spokesman Ashraf Haqshinas said Saturday.

They include the Kabul to Jalalabad highway, which is the main route linking the capital to the Pakistani border and eastern Afghan provinces.

A landslide and rockfalls, as well as flooding, shut the highway on Thursday

morning, and Haqshinas said crews were working to re-open the road.

The Public Works Ministry warned travellers to be cautious when using roads in affected areas.

Flooding has also shut the Salang Pass, a high mountain pass in the Hindu Kush mountain range that connects Kabul to the country's north, including the major cities of Kunduz and Mazar-e-Sharif.

Snow and heavy rain often trigger flash floods that kill scores, or even hundreds, of people at a time in Afghanistan. In 2024, more than 300 people died in springtime flash floods. (PTI)

Russian drone strikes on Ukraine kill 5 people

VOLODYMYR YURCHUK
■ Kyiv

Russian drone strikes on Ukraine overnight killed five people and injured 30 more, Ukrainian officials said on Saturday.

The attacks came as Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy travelled to Istanbul for talks with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan. He will also meet with Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew, the spiritual leader of Eastern Orthodox Christians.

Russia fired 286 drones at Ukraine overnight, 260 of which were downed, the Ukrainian Air Force said in an online statement.

Five people — three



Ukrainian Emergency Services on Saturday rescue workers put out a fire of a residential building damaged following a Russian strike in Sumy, Ukraine

AP

women and two men — were killed in the city of Nikopol in the Dnipropetrovsk region, and 19 others, including a 14-year-old girl, were wounded,

head of the regional military administration Oleksandr Hanzha said.

The attack damaged market stalls and a shop.

In the city of Sumy, not far

from the border with Russia, a strike injured 11 people, including a 15-year-old, the National Police said.

Residential areas were hit, and houses, cars and utility

networks were damaged in the attack.

In the Capital, Kyiv, a drone strike caused a fire on the first floor of a three-story office and warehouse building, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said. No casualties were reported.

The Russian Defence Ministry claimed Saturday that its forces fired "long-range air- and ground-based precision weapons, as well as strike drones" at unspecified "military-industrial and energy facilities used by the Ukrainian Armed Forces."

In a separate statement, the ministry said that the Russian military overnight shot down 85 Ukrainian drones over nine Russian regions, the annexed

Crimea region and the Black Sea.

In Russia's Rostov region, on the border with Ukraine, one person was killed and four sustained injuries, according to the region's governor, Yuri Slyusar.

The attack sparked a fire at a warehouse facility of an unspecified logistics company, and another fire on a dry-cargo vessel flying a foreign flag several kilometres from the shore, Slyusar said.

In the Samara region's city of Tolyatti, one person was wounded, Governor Vyacheslav Fedorishchev said.

The roof of a residential building was damaged, and windows were shattered in several apartments, he said. (AP)

Ex-Xinjiang party chief under probe over violations



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ BANGKOK

The disciplinary body for China's Communist Party said Friday it has placed the former Xinjiang party chief under investigation over suspected violations of discipline and law.

Ma Xingrui is a member of the party's Central Committee and served as party secretary of the Xinjiang region in China's northwest. He also previously served as director of the National Ethnic Affairs Commission and deputy party chief in Guangdong province.

It was unclear what violations Ma allegedly committed. Ma is the latest senior official to be removed from power this year.

China's Xi Jinping removed the top general in charge of the country's military in January. Ma was replaced by Chen Xiaojiang last July as party

chief of Xinjiang, a region that had become well-known internationally for a yearslong campaign of extrajudicial detentions.

China had detained a million or more minorities, including ethnic Uyghur Muslims, saying it was in response to a series of attacks by a small number of Uyghur extremists.

By 2021, when Ma had become secretary, China said it had shut most of the detention centers. But at least a few camp sites had been converted into prison-like centers, and information leaked to the AP showed that thousands of Uyghurs were thrown into prison.

In March, China passed a law that experts say cements its assimilationist approach towards its ethnic minority groups, building on years of policy changes at the provincial level in Xinjiang and elsewhere.

Pakistan Govt slashes petrol price by PKR 80 per litre

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad



A day after an unprecedented surge in fuel prices triggered severe backlash, Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif has announced slashing the petrol price by PKR 80.

Sharif in a midnight address Friday announced that the Government has decided to reduce petrol levy by PKR 80 per litre, making the commodity available to the end consumer for PKR 378 per litre.

The Government on Thursday announced an unprecedented hike of 43 per cent and 55 per cent in the prices of petrol and high-speed diesel (HSD), respectively.

The rise in petrol price from PKR 321.17 to PKR 458.41 per litre came as the Government levy increased from PKR 105 to PKR 160 per litre.

The Government had also increased HSD price by PKR 184.49 per litre — from PKR 335.86 to PKR 520.35 — but had abolished the levy, prompting demands that the Government should follow suit with regard to petrol price, providing some relief to citizens.

"I am announcing an immediate reduction of PKR 80 per litre in petrol levy," he said, adding that the new price of PKR 378 per litre would take effect from midnight, with petrol available at the revised rate at petrol stations across the country.

The Pakistan prime minister said the petrol price would remain unchanged

for at least one month.

He emphasised that the situation in the Gulf region was responsible for the hike in petroleum prices, but the Government was making every effort to keep prices in check.

"Through careful savings and prudent use of resources, we tried to shield you from the storm of inflation," he added.

Sharif said previously it was decided that federal cabinet members would not receive their salaries for two months as part of austerity measures taken by the Government to deal with the fuel crunch.

However, now they would have to go without salaries for six months, he announced.

"Over the past three weeks, I did not consider it appropriate to pass on the daily increase in oil prices to the public, as I am fully aware of the challenges faced by the common man in making ends meet," he said.

Additionally, the prime minister announced relief measures for vulnerable segments, including a subsidy of PKR 100 per litre for motorcycle users, PKR 70,000 to 80,000 to goods transport vehicles, and PKR 1,00,000 to passenger vehicles. (PTI)

Tamil Nadu-born Rini Sampath in race to become Washington DC mayor

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington



Tamil Nadu-born Rini Sampath has become the first South Asian candidate to be on the ballot for the primary for the election for the mayor of Washington DC.

The 31-year-old Government contractor from the Democratic Party has based her election campaign on the theme 'Fix the Basics' and the promise of "A new DC."

"I'm not a politician. I don't owe any special interest groups. It's time for an outsider who is relentlessly focused on fixing our basic city services," Sampath says on her campaign website.

Born in Theni in Tamil Nadu, she came to the US as a seven-year-old and has been a resident of Washington DC for more than a decade.

"It's clear we

have a real path to victory. In just four weeks, we made the mayoral ballot as the first South Asian candidate in DC history to do it. That's what a lean, people-powered campaign can accomplish. Imagine what we could do with the resources to reach every voter across the city," she said.

Washington DC is dominated overwhelmingly by Democrats and the city never has had a Republican mayor

since the elections to the post began in 1975.

Before that, the city was administered by a Board of Commissioners appointed by the US president.

The District of Columbia is administered by a popularly elected mayor and a 13-member district council.

"As Mayor of DC, my priority will be to make sure our city lives up to its basic commitments to our residents. Fill the potholes. Stop the catastrophic wastewater spill in the Potomac. Lower prices. Improve 911 wait times," Sampath said.

The primary is scheduled for June 16, while the general election will be held on November 3.

Others in the mayoral race are Janeese Lewis George, Kenyan McDuffie, Gary Goodweather, Robert L Gross and Rhonda Hamilton. (PTI)

Artemis II's astronauts capture Earth's blue beauty

MARCIA DUNNAP
■ Cape Canaveral



A view of Earth taken by NASA astronaut and Artemis II Commander Reid Wiseman from of the Orion spacecraft's window after completing the translunar injection burn on April 2, 2026

AP

The Artemis II astronauts have captured our blue planet's brilliant beauty as they zoom ever closer to the moon.

NASA released the crew's first down-linked images on Friday, one-and-a-half days into the first astronaut moonshot in more than half a century.

The first photo taken by commander Reid Wiseman shows a curved slice of Earth in one of the capsule's windows.

The second shows the entire globe with the oceans topped by swirling white tendrils of clouds. A green aurora even glows, according to NASA.

"It's great to think that with the exception of our four friends, all of us are represented in this image," said NASA's Lakiesha Hawkins, an exploration systems leader.

She added the mission was going well.

As of late Friday afternoon, Wiseman and his crew were more than 180,000 km from Earth and were quickly gaining on the moon with another 240,000 km to go.

They should reach their destination

on Monday.

The three Americans and one Canadian will swing around the moon in their Orion capsule, hang a U-turn and then head straight back home without stopping. (AP)

Second suspect arrested in Brooklyn street shooting

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

A second suspect in the stray-bullet killing of a 7-month-old baby on a Brooklyn street was arrested on Friday, police said, two days after a shooting the police commissioner called "a tragedy that truly shocks the conscience."

Matthew Rodriguez, 18, was apprehended in Pennsylvania by New York Police Department detectives working with US Marshals, the NYPD said.

The suspected shooter, 21-year-old Amuri Greene, was arrested shortly after the drive-by gunfire that killed Kaori Patterson-Moore.

Greene pleaded not guilty to murder and other charges at

an arraignment Friday.

Kaori was in her stroller when a two men sped down a street on a moped Wednesday afternoon.

Greene, riding on the back of the vehicle, fired into a group of people on a street corner, according to a court complaint.

Kaori's mother, Lianna Charles-Moore, told the *New York Post* that after hearing what she initially believed were fireworks, she was comforting her startled 2-year-old son - who had been grazed by a bullet - when she looked to her left and saw her baby daughter bleeding.

The infant had been shot in the head.

"My daughter was innocent. She didn't deserve that," Charles-Moore told the newspaper.

She said her daughter



was just about starting to crawl and had recently begun saying "Mama," Greene told police he was aiming for another person in the crowd, according to the court complaint.

Police said the moped sped

and crashed into a car two blocks away, hurling both men off the vehicle.

Greene was injured and soon was hospitalised in police custody, but the moped driver fled.

Authorities haven't yet released court papers that detail Rodriguez's alleged role.

But they haven't indicated they were looking for anyone other than the gunman - alleged to have been Greene - and the moped driver.

Greene was being held without bail after his arraignment.

His attorney's name wasn't in electronic court records as of Friday night, and no working telephone number could immediately be found for Greene's or Rodriguez's relatives.

Senegal limits foreign trips for officials

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dakar



Prime Minister Ousmane Sonko

The Senegalese Government has banned all but essential foreign trips for Government ministers as part of cost-saving measures triggered by the energy crisis linked to the Iran war.

Senegal, like many African countries, imports most of the petroleum products it consumes, leaving its economy vulnerable to supply disruptions such as the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which has sent the price of crude soaring.

Prime Minister Ousmane Sonko said that his office was taking steps to limit public expenditure, pointing out that the country's initial budget forecasts were based

on an oil price of \$62 per barrel, which is now almost double as a result of the Iran war.

"I have taken a number of drastic measures to restrict everything related to Government spending, including the cancellation of all nonessential missions

abroad," the Government-owned *Le Soleil* newspaper quoted Sonko as saying.

He added that he canceled several trips, including to Niger, Spain and France.

"No minister in my Government will leave the country except for an essential mission," Sonko said.

President Trump signs order intended to stabilise college sports, threatens lost federal funding

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington



President Donald Trump tried to put some teeth into his latest attempt to save college sports. The threat of cutting funding to cash-starved schools that don't comply is real, even if the stricter rules Trump wants to come out of the executive order he signed Friday could take a while to figure out.

In the order signed hours before the women's Final Four tipped off one of the biggest weekends in college sports, Trump went after eligibility rules, transfers and the spiralling costs associated with an industry that now pays its players millions of dollars per year.

He called on

federal agencies to ensure schools are following the rules and threatened to choke off federal grants and funding — a similar approach his administration has taken to force universities around the country to alter policies involving diversity, equity and inclusion, transgender

rights and even the kinds of classes they offer.

In some ways, forcing those changes might seem like child's play compared to making major changes to college sports.

The NCAA, the newly created College Sports Commission, the four power conferences, dozens more

smaller ones and hundreds of educational institutions all have a say here: It's a big reason Congress, which Trump instructed to act quickly, has been stuck for more than a year on this.

"I'm glad to know the President wants Congress to pass something," said Sen Maria Cantwell, D-Wash., a key member of the Senate committee looking into changes, who mentioned ongoing bipartisan negotiations.

Trump's order was his second since last July and it included a laundry list of proposed fixes, many of which lawmakers and college leaders have been pushing for since the approval of a USD 2.8 billion settlement changed the face of games

that were once played by pure amateurs.

In one of the more clear-cut demands in this order, Trump called for "clear, consistent and fair eligibility limits, including a five-year participation window," that limits athletes to one transfer with one more available once they get a four-year degree.

"I'm extremely supportive of the President's order," said Cody Campbell, the Texas Tech regent and billionaire who is helping shape policy.

"I'm very excited that we're making progress and look forward to continued work in the (Congress) to permanently preserve a system that's done so much for America."

At a college sports round-table he hosted last month,

Trump said he anticipated any order he signed would trigger litigation.

Athletes have largely won the freedom to transfer almost at will via the portal along with the ability to be paid by schools that are now doling out more than USD 20 million a year to their athletes.

Some of those players have also been suing the NCAA about eligibility limits, and their right to do that has been a major sticking point in the Congressional deliberations.

Trump also raised the need to fix revenue-sharing in a way that protects Olympic sports, which are most in peril if the college funding model spirals out of control.

Sarah Hirshland, the CEO of the US Olympic and

Paralympic Committee, said Trump's order "sends an important signal about the value of preserving and promoting investment in women's and men's collegiate Olympic sports in America."

As much as the changes he directs, Trump's call for the Education Department, the Federal Trade Commission and the attorney general's office to evaluate "whether violations of such rules render a university unfit for Federal grants and contracts" stands out as a way to force change.

Several universities across the country have made policy changes to comply with federal orders and avoid funding-related showdowns with the Government. It hasn't

prevented big-named schools like Penn State and Florida State from facing huge debts.

"From what I saw, some of the social media traffic, it's pretty clear that he made clear that we need Congressional action to sort of seal the deal on a number of these things, which is good, because we do," NCAA President Charlie Baker said.

Commissioners at the Atlantic Coast and Southeastern Conference released statements thanking Trump for weighing in, with the ACC's Jim Phillips saying "there continues to be significant momentum to preserve the athletic and academic opportunities for the next generation of student-athletes and we appreciate the ongoing efforts."



BRIEFLY

PCB mulling Younis Khan as Director Domestic Cricket



Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) is eyeing former captain and the country's highest Test run getter Younis Khan to take over as head of the domestic cricket department, according to sources. A reliable source aware of the development said PCB Chairman Mohsin Naqvi was keen on having Younis for the important post of Director Domestic Cricket. "Khurram Niazi who is a career bureaucrat and currently heads the domestic department has been posted in Islamabad and will report soon for his new assignment. Which is why the board is looking at Younis to take over as Director Domestic cricket," the source said. He said Khurrum, who was brought in on deputation like other bureaucrats into the PCB, ran the domestic cricket department for over two years. "Naqvi now wants a proper experienced cricketer to manage domestic cricket affairs which remains a source of debate in Pakistan cricket," the source stated. He said the PCB would only announce Younis' appointment when he signs a contract with the Board. Currently, negotiations are taking place. The 48-year-old Younis, who appeared in 118 Tests and 265 ODIs, is the only Pakistani player to score over 10,000 Test runs and has worked in the past as batting coach of the national side. But, he left the role after developing difference of opinion with some Board officials.

Nteka strikes late to give Rayo Vallecano win over Elche



Rayo Vallecano left it late to beat 10-man Elche 1-0 and record its first La Liga win for almost a month on Friday. The Madrid-based club had not picked up three points since beating bottom side Oviedo on March 4 but returned to winning ways thanks to a second-half goal from Randy Nteka. It was helped by the dismissal of Elche's Pedro Bigas six minutes before halftime. The veteran center half was booked midway through the first half and picked up a second yellow for a high challenge and was shown a red card. Pedro Diaz hit the post in the second half and Elche goalkeeper Matias Dituro made smart saves but Nteka got on the end of a nice cross from Alvaro Garcia with 16 minutes remaining to give the home side the win. It was the Angola international's first goal of the season and a vital one for Rayo, which climbed two places into 12th. Elche remained in 17th spot, one place above the relegation zone.

Lauren Coughlin surges through gusty round for a 5-shot lead at Shadow Creek

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ North Las Vegas

Lauren Coughlin continued her strong play at Shadow Creek even in windy conditions that played havoc with the second-round scores at the Aramco Championship to shoot a 3-under 69 and open a five-shot lead.

Coughlin was 8 under. Hyo Joo Kim kept alive her hopes for a third straight LPGA Tour tournament victory, shooting 73 to match Leona Maguire (71) at 3 under.

Coughlin entered the day in a three-way tie for the lead after opening with a 67, but now has created clear separation. She nearly won here last year when it was a match-play event before



falling to Madelene Sagstrom in the final pairing.

Now Coughlin is close again. Even with a sizable lead, though, she isn't ready to celebrate. "There is a lot of golf to be played," Coughlin said. "As you can see, you can

Bangladesh Cricket Board reaches out to BCCI

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Dhaka

The Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB) has approached the BCCI to salvage India's white-ball tour in September and repair ties, strained after Dhaka's decision to pull out of the T20 World Cup in India.

It is understood that BCB president Aminul Islam Bulbul's regime could end soon and an interim board may start discussions with the Indian cricket Board.

BCB, believed to be run by sports ministry advisor and anti-India hardliner Asif Nazrul, decided not to send the team to India on the pretext of security issues after Mustafizur Rahaman

wasn't allowed by the BCCI to play in the IPL.

BCB requested that their matches be shifted to Sri Lanka but the ICC did not find merit in it, ruling out any security issue in India for the team. The Indo-Bangla cricket ties have traditionally been cordial, but recent developments have led to a marked deterioration.

"Yes, BCB has sent a letter to Indian cricket board. Not only about Indian men's team's white ball tour of Bangladesh in September, there is a men's 50-over Asia Cup which BCB is set to host next year," a BCCI source told PTI on conditions of anonymity. It is understood that BCB is desperate to host India since



six white ball matches played by Men In Blue will sort board's finances for the year with revenue generated from the linear and digital broadcast right sales.

Tamim in line for BCB presidency? The BCB among many things in the agenda

has discussed resignation of four directors during BCB president Aminul Islam Bulbul's reign.

There is strong resentment in the Bangladesh cricket corridors about Bulbul's continuation especially after he expressed helplessness to

Tamim Iqbal urged the Bangladesh government and BCB to take a prudent and practical stand instead of hostile retaliation over the India issue.

convince the interim-government head Muhammad Yunus to send the team to India. "The investigation committee that is looking into the T20 World Cup non-participation fiasco will present its report to the government on April 9. "It would be interesting to find out how Bulbul would be placed once that report is tabled.

In that case, an interim board will take over and the re-elections will be held in 90 days. All eyes will also be on

Bangladesh's foreign minister's visit to Delhi," said a source tracking developments. It is understood that former Bangladesh skipper and country's greatest opener Tamim Iqbal could be a strong candidate for BCB presidency.

Iqbal, who urged the government and BCB to take a prudent and practical stand from their hostile retaliation, is a choice which the Indian cricket board would also not mind. (PTI)

Dembele grabs brace as PSG warm up for Liverpool with win

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Paris

Ousmane Dembele scored twice in the first half as Paris Saint-Germain beat Toulouse 3-1 and increased its lead of Ligue 1 to four points on Friday. The game was brought forward to give PSG more recovery time ahead of next

Wednesday's Champions League quarterfinal with Liverpool at the Parc des Princes.

PSG came into the match having scored 12 goals in its last three games and it took the lead midway through the opening period when Dembele crashed a superb volley into the top corner



from the edge of the 18-yard box. However, four minutes later goalkeeper Matvey Safonov could not secure a

wicked in-swinging corner and Rasmus Nicolaisen headed home the rebound to level the scores.

Zaman was already being watched by umpires: Sources

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Pakistan batter Fakhar Zaman was already being watched closely by the umpires even before they changed the ball and awarded five runs penalty against Lahore Qalandars in the Pakistan Super League (PSL), source have revealed.

Zaman was handed a two-match ban after being found guilty of ball-tampering during a PSL match. "The Karachi Kings management had brought to the notice of the fourth umpire and subsequently the match referee from the 13th over onwards that they suspected Fakhar was doing something to the ball," said a source. The source claimed the referee



had asked the on-field umpires to keep a watch on the Lahore Qalandars team,

particularly Zaman. "Before the final over, umpire Faisal Afridi had already been

watching closely. He asked for the ball and on inspecting it suspected it had been tampered with a foreign object," he added. "That is why the decision to change the ball and award penalty runs was given," he stated.

Zaman after being banned had also appealed to the technical committee of the PSL to overturn the referee's decision but they rejected his ban on the grounds that there was enough circumstantial evidence available to the umpires and match referee to take action against Zaman. The Pakistan batsman had to sit out for the Lahore game against Multan Sultans on Friday night because of the ban and is set to miss another game on April 9.

Shyam Sunder Swami bags bronze; Rakesh, Anjum fourth in Bangkok Para Archery

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bangkok

Shyam Sunder Swami secured a bronze medal for India after edging past senior teammate and Paris Paralympic bronze medalist Rakesh Kumar in a closely-fought playoff at the World Archery Para Series here.

Swami prevailed 143 (10*) to 143 (9) in the bronze medal match of the compound men's individual event, with the contest being decided on a tie-break after both archers were locked at identical scores. A mixed team bronze winner at Paris Paralympics, Rakesh ended his campaign in fourth place following the heartbreak in



the shoot-off. In the W1 women's individual event, Anjum Tanwar also finished fourth after going down 2-6 in her bronze medal match against an opponent from the Republic of Korea. The

Bangkok meet follows the Asia Cup first leg held recently at the same venue, where India delivered a strong showing with a haul of 10 medals — two gold, four silver and four bronze.

Kochhar slips but stays in top-5



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chiba (Japan)

Indian golfer Karandeep Kochhar returned a card of 73 in the third round to slip Tied-4th at the International Series Japan, here Saturday.

Kochhar after bogey free rounds on the first two days (67-65) had five bogeys on a windy third day though his three birdies lessened the blow. With 73 he is now 8-under and Tied-4th after being Tied-second at the halfway stage. Korea's Hongtaek Kim kept the lead for the third straight day after a see-saw contest over the closing stages that saw Shugo Imahira from Japan join him in front.

Kim, who started the round with a one-shot lead, fired a one-over-par 72 to sit on 10-under, with playing partner Imahira, in with a 71. Korea's Yubin Jang is one back following a 71 at Caledonian Golf Club, outside Tokyo, with Australian Travis Smyth and Kochhar, another stroke behind. The other Indian in the field Jeev Milkha Singh struggled to 7-over 78 and was now 6-over for two

rounds and Tied-71st.

The other Indians: Gaganjeet Bhullar, SSP Chawrasia, Jyoti Randhawa and Shaurya. Bhattacharya had missed the cut. Kochhar, playing in the lead group birdied the second, but bogeyed the third and the fourth. Another birdie on the sixth was followed by the ninth. On the back nine, two bogeys and one birdie meant a round of 73.

Kim did well to hang on to the lead on a windy day after a back nine saw him make bogeys on 10, 12 and 14, while Imahira, Jang and Smyth all birdied 18. The 32-year-old is chasing his second win on the Asian Tour, having claimed the GS Catlex Maekyung Open on home soil two years ago, while success tomorrow would be his maiden title on The International Series.

He admitted to not having the greatest preparation coming into the week as his wife recently gave birth to their second child. Imahira had struggles of his own on the inward half, dropping shots on 14 and 15 before his closing birdie.

Aditi best Indian after second day at Aramco; Pranavi, Avani make cut

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Las Vegas

Aditi Ashok was the top placed Indian golfer after the second round even as Pranavi Urs and Avani Prashanth also made the cut at the Aramco Championship here. Aditi, a five-time LET winner, including Hero Women's Indian Open, carded 1-under 71 to move into the top 15 of the leaderboard.

The two other Indians to make the cut are Pranavi (76-75) and Avani (75-76), both placed T-59 on the leaderboard with a score of 7-over par. However, Diksha Dagar was unable to make the cut



due to a difficult second round where she carded six-over 78 for a total of nine-over par. She shot three-over 75 on the first day. Lauren Coughlin became the sole leader heading into the weekend as she carded a three-under 69 on a windy day to take her score at eight-under par as Hyo Joo Kim and Leona Maguire are tied for

second place with a score of three-under par.

Hyo is looking for her third title in as many weeks and Leona Maguire are tied for second place with a score of three-under par. Aditi (73-71) made four birdies, one bogey and one double bogey in her second round to take her total to one-over par. The birdies were made on the 10th, 11th, 18th and ninth holes. The bogey was made on the seventh and the double bogey came on the third hole. Avani Prashanth and Pranavi Urs found themselves just inside the cut after the second round as the cut was set at 7-over par.

We did not execute at the right time: Ruturaj

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad lamented a below-par bowling effort after a five-wicket defeat to Punjab Kings in the Indian Premier League clash here on Friday, admitting it simply wasn't their day despite fielding a balanced attack of three seamers and two spinners. Despite posting an imposing 209 for 5, powered by young Ayush Mhatre's 43-ball 73, Chennai Super Kings failed to contain the Punjab Kings batters, as a collective effort led by skipper Shreyas Iyer's 50 saw them chase down the target with ease in 18.4 overs.

"We felt we had three



seamers going in, and obviously we have two good wrist spinners bowling in tandem, especially in the middle after the powerplay.

We felt that, you know, it will help," said Gaikwad after the match. "But I think, you know, slight off day for both of them. So, I think, that is what

cost us. Sometimes we executed really well. Sometimes we just didn't execute at the right time," he added.

He felt the team failed to build momentum with the ball in the middle overs, which could have helped slow down the opposition batters. "There was a point when it (required run-rate) went to 11, and a couple of good overs would have taken it to 12-13. We just did not get momentum in the middle (with the ball). "Tough one (to take)."

Focusing on the positives, he said the batting performances of young Mhatre and Shivam Dube stood out, though he added that the bowling needs improvement. Winning skipper Shreyas Iyer

said the superb start provided by openers Priyansh Arya and Prabhsimran Singh was key to chasing down the big total. "The way we started today, that was an exceptional start for us. I feel the way they (Arya and Prabhsimran) have been batting has been phenomenal and it stabilises the rhythm for us.

"I am glad everyone is getting to bat. It gives immense confidence to the team. Whenever we are in a pressure situation, people are aware on how to handle it. We just decided in the dressing room, we will play a brand of cricket to impress each other — that gives us a certain sort of clarity, and basically challenging each other."

Rizvi, bowlers power DC to six-wicket win over MI

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
■ New Delhi

Impact substitute Sameer Rizvi continued his red-hot form with another fine half-century as an all-round Delhi Capitals outclassed Mumbai Indians by six wickets in their first home game of the 2026 IPL season here on Saturday.

Chasing 163, the 22-year-old Rizvi (90 off 51 balls) took apart the MI attack with a fluent knock studded with seven fours and as many sixes. After suffering a top-order wobble for the second successive game, Delhi Capitals steadied through a 66-run stand for the third wicket between Rizvi and Pathum Nissanka, who

scored 44 off 30 balls.

Rizvi then added 78 runs with David Miller (17 not out) as the hosts completed the chase with 11 balls to spare.

Initially playing second fiddle to Nissanka, Rizvi shifted gears after the Sri Lankan's dismissal, taking on the bowlers with ease.

The youngster smashed back-to-back fours followed by two towering sixes, including one over deep backward point, to plunder 20 runs off the 11th over bowled by Corbin Bosch.

He continued the assault in the next over, whipping consecutive sixes off Mayank Markande to seize complete control of the chase. He was unlucky to miss out on his

debut IPL ton but received a standing ovation from the crowd when he Bosch got him out.

This was after Delhi Capitals bowlers dominated to restrict Mumbai Indians to a modest 162 for six despite stand-in skipper Suryakumar Yadav's a patient half-century.

Suryakumar anchored the innings with a 36-ball 51, hitting three fours and two sixes, while Rohit Sharma hit 35 even as other MI batters found it difficult in the middle.

Delhi's bowlers, however, kept things tight. Skipper Axar Patel was exceptional, conceding just 22 runs in his four overs and removing the dangerous Rohit Sharma.



Leg-spinner Vipraj Nigam (1/24 in 3 overs) chipped in with a wicket, while Kuldeep Yadav (0/31 in 3 overs) proved slightly expensive. The pace trio of Mukesh Kumar (2/26), Lungi Ngidi (1/34) and T Natarajan (1/24) also played their part, sharing four wickets between them.

Mukesh struck early, removing the in-form Ryan Rickelton with a good-length delivery that was miscued to Axar at mid-off.

Two balls later, he produced a return catch to dismiss Tilak Varma for a duck, leaving Mumbai Indians two down inside the powerplay. Rohit (35) and Suryakumar then steadied the innings with a 53-run

partnership. Rohit got going with the first six of the match, dispatching an overpitched ball from Nigam over long-on, while Suryakumar followed up with a maximum off the next delivery.

However, Delhi spinners tightened the screws soon after. Axar accounted for Rohit, who mistimed a shot to the cover region where Nitish Rana completed a fine catch. Vipraj then dismissed Sherfane Rutherford (5), with Mukesh taking a good catch close to the boundary.

Suryakumar, leading in the absence of Hardik Pandya, tried to accelerate alongside Naman Dhir (28) as Mumbai crossed the 100-run mark. (PTI)

YOUNG TALENT AT THE TOP ORDER SPECIAL: RICKY PONTING



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Lauding the Indian players in Punjab Kings' roster as "special" talents, head coach Ricky Ponting says the franchise had the aim of rebuilding the team around the "highest-quality" domestic players. The PBKS had retained just Prabhsimran Singh and Shashank Singh, and went into the auction with a heavy purse of ₹110.5 crore, and made some high-end buys such as Shreyas Iyer, Yuzvendra Chahal and Arshdeep Singh.

They have been forming the team's core since IPL 2025. "Our young Indian talent, the guys at the top of the order, are pretty special. To build some of those Aussie guys around them, we had a really clear strategy going into the auction (2024) about trying to rebuild this whole team from the bottom up, and change and be different as a franchise," Ponting told jioHotStar.

Deshpande's brilliant final act ensures thrilling win for RR over GT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Tushar Deshpande bowled a magnificent final over by landing six consecutive deliveries on either blockhole or wide yorker length in an exhibition of high-class bowling as Rajasthan Royals edged out Gujarat Titans by six runs in an IPL humdinger here on Saturday.

This was Royals' second successive win in the tournament while the Ashish Nehra coached GT team has now lost two matches in a row. Riding on half-centuries from Dhruv Jurel (75 off 42 balls) and Yashasvi Jaiswal (55 off 36 balls), Royals scored 210 for 6 in their 20 overs.

Despite Sai Sudharsan's 73 which oozed class, GT were starting down the barrel at 161 for 7 before Kagiso Rabada (23 not out) and stand-in skipper Rashid Khan (24) took the team close to a win

with 10 needed off the final over.

But Deshpande had other ideas as he started the final over with a wide but then was on target with three singles and a wide fuller delivery that Rashid conceded

a dot. In the end, only four runs were scored and the Titans would feel that they let it slip big time after a solid opening stand. With Shubman Gill absent due to spasms, Sai Sudharsan (73 off 44 balls)

had a new partner in debutant Kumar Kushagra (18 off 14 balls) but it was the Tamil Nadu man who did bulk of the scoring in the 78-run opening stand. When it came to sheer elegance and grace, Sudharsan hardly has any peers among the new breed of T20 batters.

Even the sixes that he hit – three apart from nine boundaries –, seemed like caressed through the orbit. For Kushagra, it was about playing the second fiddle. However once Sudharsan was snapped by Bishnoi with a half-tracker, suddenly, GT lost track with the leg-spinner tormenting them with altered length and variations.

From 107 for 1, suddenly, they were reeling at 133 for 5 and subsequently became 161 for 7 with all recognised batters back in the hut.

However Rabada and Rashid had other ideas as they launched brutal yet swift counter-attack which wasn't enough in

the end. Earlier, Jurel beautifully merged aggression and discretion in his 42-ball 75 to guide Rajasthan Royals to a challenging 210 for 6 after opting to bat.

In the RR innings, Jaiswal looked like getting back into the groove with a 55 off 36 balls after 'Boy Wonder' Sooryavanshi smashed 18-ball 31 in an opening stand of 70 in just 6.2 overs.

Jurel seemed settled in his new role as No. 3 and showed that there is place for conventional shots and yet can strike at more than 150. The pick-up pull off Ashok Sharma after completing his fifty was a delight – a testimony to his strong core and good hands. He hit five maximums and an equal number of boundaries.

For Gujarat Titans, Ashok Sharma (1/37 in 4 overs), in only his second IPL game, emerged as the 'Next big pace hope' having clocked 154.2 clicks and consistently bowling northwards of 145 kmph.

longer it's here, or if it's here to stay, but that certainly changes the dynamic of cricket and probably sways it a little bit towards batting power." He added that identifying and securing the right talent has become increasingly challenging as the game evolves.

"Constantly around the world, evaluating what's happening and how guys are playing. One of the greatest challenges in T20 franchise cricket is securing talent. And that, through competitions, is becoming difficult as teams bundle players. "But we are constantly looking at where the game is going next and trying to secure players that we think will be the next big thing, or where the game will go. "So again, you say, how

long is the impact player rule here? Will all-rounders come back into the game, or will it continue to be a dashes, an aggressive batting style? I don't know. I'd like to see the balance between bat and ball a little bit more. But look, I'm constantly, with others, looking at that and trying to stay as relevant as possible."

Shashank hails Priyansh: O opener Priyansh Arya's 11-ball 39 provided a flying start to PBKS' chase of 210 and fellow batter Shashank Singh praised him for his mental clarity. "We know with IPL, the second season is the most important. Because the teams do find the weaknesses in you. But with Priyansh, what we as a team really liked last year is that he's mentally very tough.

Bowling a major concern for CSK, says Gavaskar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Former India captain Sunil Gavaskar believes five-time champions Chennai Super Kings' primary concern is their bowling, urging the side to address it to revive their campaign.

CSK have lost their first two matches of the season, including a five-wicket defeat to Punjab Kings on Friday.

"From what we've seen so far, CSK's biggest concern for the rest of the tournament will be their bowling. It means they may have to consistently score around 225-230 to give their bowlers a chance," Gavaskar said on Star Sports' 'Amul Cricket Live'.

"Most teams now have significant batting depth, like we saw with Punjab Kings where Marcus Stoinis came in at No. 7 and struck the ball cleanly with proper cricketing shots. With many sides batting deep, Chennai will need to get their bowling in order." Young Ayush Mhatre top-scored for CSK with a 43-ball 73, guiding the team to 209 for five.

"I believe Number 3 is a good position for Ayush Mhatre. He has batted lower down the order in the Under-19 setup, but three could suit him well," Gavaskar said.

"He was dismissed first ball in the previous game but showed no signs of being affected by it. That's the beauty of the Gen Next mindset, they don't dwell too much on the past and focus on the present. It's a fantastic attitude." Gavaskar also praised Rohit Sharma for his improved fitness and its



impact on his batting. "We've all seen the change in Rohit Sharma's physical condition. He has clearly worked very hard and the rewards are visible. His footwork looks quicker, he has more energy, and that gives him more time at the crease. "Elegant players often make batting look effortless, but that comes from preparation and hard work. Some of the shots he played recently reminded you of Rohit in his early twenties, when he made batting look ridiculously easy."

"It's great to see him scoring runs again because he's such a delightful player to watch." Former India batter Cheteshwar Pujara lauded Priyansh Arya for his 11-ball 39 that provided a flying start to Punjab Kings' chase of 210. "Priyansh Arya is picking the length very early. On that pitch, whenever the ball was slightly short, he didn't miss out and often hit it for six," Pujara said.

"We saw that against bowlers like Matt Henry and Khaleel Ahmed, he is not missing the fuller deliveries either, which means the margin for error for bowlers becomes very small.

Don't think there is a thing called finishers anymore: Fleming

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Chennai Super Kings head coach Stephen Fleming does not believe the traditional finisher's role holds the same relevance in modern T20 cricket, citing the shift towards all-out aggression from the outset, but expressed confidence in his side's resources.

CSK have overhauled their squad, with the batting unit dominated by top-order specialists, leaving gaps in the middle and lower order, particularly in the finisher's role.

"Look, I don't think there is a thing called finishers anymore. It's right from ball one, everyone is going at a rate of knots. It's not build up to the 16th over and then go harder. Everyone's going

hard from ball one," Fleming told reporters after CSK's five-wicket loss to Punjab Kings.

"So, the run rates of 10, 11, 12 all the way through are what's expected, and you're not really getting the big peaks towards the end. It's just a more aggressive approach to get to 40. So, you actually have to have players all the way through that are

going to be aggressive, and that's certainly the team that we've got.

"Keep in mind, we've got Brevis on the sideline, and we've got one of the best finishers in MS who's injured, so there's some power there, but Brevis through the middle. I'm really content with the pace that we can go." World Cup-winning

India batter Sanju Samson, who was brought in from Rajasthan Royals ahead of the season, has struggled in his first two outings.

However, Fleming backed the opener, saying two innings are not a cause for concern. "He's training well, and when he gets going, he's often a match winner and wins games. So, two winnings don't define an area of concern at all."

Fleming also called for a better balance between bat and ball, saying the Impact Player rule has tilted the game in favour of batting.

"I think with this competition in particular, the impact player rule has a massive part to play. Other tournaments around the world, it's not as frantic as this," he said.

"I'm not sure how much

longer it's here, or if it's here to stay, but that certainly changes the dynamic of cricket and probably sways it a little bit towards batting power." He added that identifying and securing the right talent has become increasingly challenging as the game evolves.

"Constantly around the world, evaluating what's happening and how guys are playing. One of the greatest challenges in T20 franchise cricket is securing talent. And that, through competitions, is becoming difficult as teams bundle players. "But we are constantly looking at where the game is going next and trying to secure players that we think will be the next big thing, or where the game will go. "So again, you say, how

long is the impact player rule here? Will all-rounders come back into the game, or will it continue to be a dashes, an aggressive batting style? I don't know. I'd like to see the balance between bat and ball a little bit more. But look, I'm constantly, with others, looking at that and trying to stay as relevant as possible."

Shashank hails Priyansh: O opener Priyansh Arya's 11-ball 39 provided a flying start to PBKS' chase of 210 and fellow batter Shashank Singh praised him for his mental clarity. "We know with IPL, the second season is the most important. Because the teams do find the weaknesses in you. But with Priyansh, what we as a team really liked last year is that he's mentally very tough.

Confident RCB eye second win on the trot against CSK

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru will be highly optimistic about pulling off their second win on the bounce in IPL when they face Chennai Super Kings, who have been hampered by Sanju Samson's lukewarm start and a lack of strong bowling options, here on Sunday.

The Royal Challengers are well rested after their first game back on March 28 against Sunrisers Hyderabad, which they won by six wickets at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium.

That fresh mind and body apart, the RCB are an infinitely better side than their rivals now, a stark contrast from the past when the Chennaities were bustling with talents through their ranks. Now, RCB have that

luxury. They have a settled top-order under the watch of Virat Kohli, who has kept himself relevant in the age of range-hitting with an impeccable set of skills.

After a phase of wasted talent, Devdutt Padikkal seemed to have woken up the inner white ball giant, evident in his blistering 26-ball 61 against SRH.

Rajat Patidar seemed to have found peace with his dual role of leading the side and giving meat to RCB middle-order. But it was in the bowling that RCB have massively improved. Once perceived as their Achilles Heel, the Bengalureans have turned the tide adding some worthy names and made their bowling immune to the vagaries of conditions.

The defending champions were expected to be hamstrung by the absence of



Josh Hazlewood but Jacob Duffy stepped in seamlessly, destroying SRH top-order with a three-wicket haul.

He appeared to have struck a chord with the Australian, a connection that was evident in his bowling strategy as he troubled the Hyderabad batters with

highly accurate short-pitched deliveries. Once Hazlewood comes back, which may not happen in the match against CSK, their bowling will be even stronger.

The hosts might also ponder bringing in left-arm pacer Mangesh Yadav in place of Abhinandan Singh

for this match. Krunal Pandya and Suyash Sharma are not among the T20 spinners elite, but have served RCB's purpose well with stifling middle-over spells and they will now have to contain CSK's able middle-order of Shivam Dube, Sarfaraz Khan and Ayush Mhatre.

The script, rest assured, will continue this weekend too, but CSK would want a change in it. But for that, the Chennai bowlers need to change their script. They have given away 338 runs in 30.5 overs for only seven wickets in two matches – highly inappropriate in the T20 format even considering the batters' aggression.

Their spinners Noor Ahmad and Rahul Chahar came a cropper against Punjab Kings on Friday, conceding 84 runs in eight overs between them even without

Tasked to work on India's 2036 Olympics, Commonwealth Games bids: Leander

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Indian tennis legend Leander Paes on Saturday said he has been entrusted with responsibilities related to India's bid for the 2036 Olympic Games, describing it as a key to his new role in public life.

The seven-time Olympian said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had given him the task of working on youth development and sports while helping the country pursue its ambition of hosting the Olympics in 2036. In his first media interaction in Kolkata

after joining the BJP, Paes said, "Modi ji gave me a clear vision – to work for the youth and sports. He has given me the responsibility of the 2036 Olympics. I have to work hard with a team to bring the Olympics to this country."

He also said that he would contribute towards hosting the Commonwealth Games in Gujarat. The tennis legend said hosting the Olympics could help transform India's sporting ecosystem and strengthen its global standing. Drawing parallels between sporting success and economic strength, he noted that



India should aim to achieve similar success by building a strong sporting culture and investing in infrastructure and grassroots talent development.
— LEANDER PAES, TENNIS PLAYER

the top medal-winning nations at the 2024 Summer Olympics, including the US, China, Japan, Australia and Great Britain, are also among the world's leading economies.

Paes said India should aim to achieve similar success by building a strong sporting culture and investing in infrastructure and grassroots

talent development. "In sports and sports education lies the ability to build a superpower," he said, adding that developing young athletes would be key to India's Olympic ambitions. Paes also stressed the need to improve sports infrastructure in states such as West Bengal, noting that the state still lacks an indoor tennis stadium and

often relies on temporary wooden courts for international events such as the Davis Cup. Paes said his broader mission is to impact the lives of 250 million children over the next two decades through sports and education, adding that India's youth would play a decisive role in the country's Olympic aspirations and global rise.

Calling his transition from sport to public life a "new game", Paes said he would approach the responsibility with the same passion and commitment that defined his tennis career.

Welcome this spring like an old friend who just rolled into town. Let the petals pile up across the streets, rally your favourite people, and dive straight into the brilliant, overgrown mess

Walking Into Spring

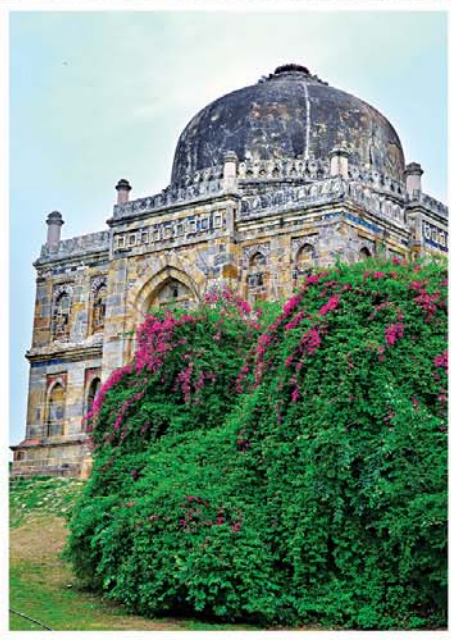
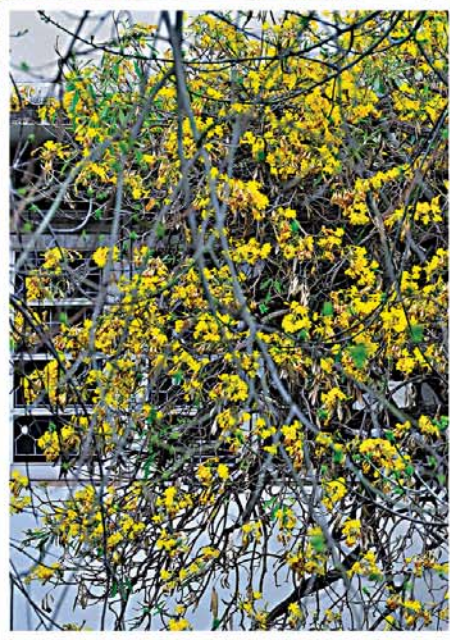
Bright bougainvillea and breezy cottons: how these blooming streets finally slow the whole city down

SAKSHI PRIYA

Have you ever found peace just gazing at trees? There is something about getting lost in that mesmerising rainbow of colours during an evening walk near Delhi’s historic lanes that resets everything. As you pass through the quiet avenues, an important question always pops up: is Sunder Nagar really that “sundar”? Crowds instinctively flock to Sunder Nursery or Lodhi Garden, though it is obvious most are just chasing the perfect photo backdrop. Those incredible blooming branches basically just end up as colourful backdrops for the weekend grid. Almost everyone completely misses the chance to just stand still and look at the trees — skipping the opportunity to actually feel the season by noticing the rough bark, the fresh leaves, and the heavy colours dripping from the canopy.



How does a spring manage to breathe so much life into centuries-old stone? Heading over to Sunder Nursery for some open space shows exactly how history and nature mix



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

right now, with the lawns completely packed with people trying to enjoy the perfect weather before the brutal summer heat ruins it. Even with the crowds, the trees deserve to be the main event, especially the massive Semal or silk cotton tree that drops heavy red flowers hitting the grass with a soft thud. Standing quietly under the canopy allows a moment to actually notice the rough bark and follow the fallen flowers back to the Bara Gumbad or Sikandar Lodi’s tomb, and one might even hear the dry pods of the Indian elm rattling in the breeze while groups of friends in bright spring outfits blend seamlessly into the greenery.

Escaping the manicured lawns to find something genuinely wild requires heading over to the Ridge and walking into the rocky and uneven ground of Buddha Jayanti Park for a much rougher version of spring. The paved paths fade into dirt trails and trees where the Palash, known as the flame of the forest, puts on a huge display of orange and red flowers against the dry brush. The air actually smells different here with the scent of dry earth and old wood taking over as the traffic noise finally disappears, leaving a quiet spot where nature is left alone and full of birds and bugs that usually go unnoticed unless someone really stops to look

and catch the scent of a blooming Bakain or Chamrod tree. The catch with a Delhi spring is that it passes way too fast, since everyone knows the scorching May winds are only a few weeks away and will soon strip all these branches bare. But right now the city is finally exhaling, and the trees are running the schedule by giving enough shade and colour to make the usual city chaos feel like it barely matters.

Walking these lanes alone with your music clears the head, shrinking the world to just the swaying branches. But honestly, heading out with friends is what actually makes the season feel real. Sharing a loud laugh under a tree or arguing over which hidden lane looks the best turns a basic afternoon into a lasting memory. It is exactly the push needed to finally look up from the screens and step right into the middle of the mess before the colour disappears entirely. So, go ahead and welcome this spring like an old friend who just rolled into town. Let the petals pile up across the streets, rally your favourite people, and dive straight into the brilliant, overgrown mess. This fleeting window of colour demands to be fully lived in — right here, right now — before the brutal summer winds roll in to sweep the canvas clean.

Fill the cup before Monday drains it again



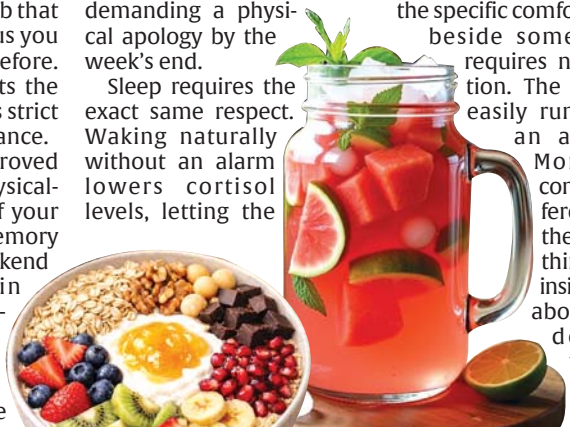
TEAM VIVA

There is only one person guaranteed to stick around for every single second of this life — the face in the mirror. So why does that person usually end up treated like an afterthought by the time Friday rolls around? The weekend begins with the simple act of making a drink slowly, just because there is nowhere else to be. You pour an iced latte, hold a hot ginger tea, or grab that exotic water with citrus you prepped the night before. That first quiet sip sets the pace. This downtime is strict neurological maintenance. Brain researchers proved that chronic stress physically shrinks the parts of your brain that handle memory and emotions. The weekend is mandatory brain repair. The real question is why it took you this long to actually start resting. Cooking a favourite



brunch from scratch allows melting butter and warm spices to fill the house, offering a sensory pleasure the weekday denies. While the food simmers, proper self-care takes over. A face mask goes on, and the full skincare routine finally gets attention with the cleanser and serum that sat untouched all week. Skin carries the weight of long days exactly like the mind does, absorbing the stress and dry office air, demanding a physical apology by the week’s end. Sleep requires the exact same respect. Waking naturally without an alarm lowers cortisol levels, letting the

body repair what the long week broke. Even basic adulting carries a quiet satisfaction when approached differently. Folding warm laundry or scrubbing a kitchen counter creates a physical order that instantly settles internal chaos, turning tidying into a meditative ritual alongside a good playlist. Somewhere between these chores and the quiet moments, pull loved ones close over a long lunch to find the specific comfort of sitting beside someone who requires no explanation. The world can easily run itself for an afternoon. Monday hits completely differently when there is something still left inside. Nothing about a slow, deliberate weekend is wasted time.



SAKSHI PRIYA

“Wherever there is beauty, there is an element of divinity; as a legacy, I want to be happy because while problems in life must be solved, happiness is the only thing worth keeping.” Spoken with a quiet focus by Jayant K, these words anchor ‘Journey with the Divine Flow’ at the Travancore Palace Gallery. Stepping into this space involves witnessing the instinctive vision of a seeker who uncovers the sacred within a petal’s curve or a warrior’s stride. Jayant K, India’s Ambassador to Spain and Andorra, bypasses the formulaic rules of a trained painter. He builds a visual philosophy where internal intensity carries greater weight than academic precision.



JAYANT K
India’s Ambassador to Spain and Andorra

Layers of Peace on Canvas

Why layered paint holds the secret to a balanced life

Curator Gargi Seth guides the viewer through an intimate map of a soul seasoned by decades of geographic displacement.

The exhibition offers a dialogue where creativity serves as a vital life force amidst the rigmarole of uprooting. Creations like *Autumn Into The Sky* and *The Valley of Flowers* capture nature’s fleeting perfection. Rather than relying on clever visual tricks, the paintings are built with thick, physical layers of colour that reveal a genuine, earned depth far beyond formal training.

In exploring movement, *Flamenco* and *A Whirlpool of Emotions* highlight a deep connection to music and physical grace, turning the frames into windows of introspective silence. Taking on the *Gita*, the brushwork dismantles the usual towering, remote image of Krishna. Instead, we see a grounded, flesh-and-blood companion, a sharp

tactician caught in a deeply private, unspoken exchange with Arjuna, effectively shutting out the roaring chaos of the warring world altogether. This ancient presence flows into the bright explosion of colour in *Holi*. Inspired by the tender enquiry of why Radha remains fair while he possesses a darker hue, the brush captures the moment the world becomes dyed in a celestial blue. This exploration continues in the serenity of *3 Moons*, mirroring a single face of tranquillity to suggest that a million sculptures might shine with one unified grace. The spiritual depth builds further in *Shiva Shakti*, while the internal struggles of the heart find a vessel in *Hanuman*, representing the courage required to serve the light within. Jayant K urges the younger generation to cultivate a large inner space, as a life lived with such intense passion remains a great gift to the world.

He left the audience with a thought that captures the core of his artistic search: “We can’t curb a passion, can we? Only when you fall in love with the subject of a painting can you sit in front of it for months; otherwise, it remains a blank.



Jayant K urges the younger generation to cultivate a large inner space, as a life lived with such intense passion remains a great gift to the world



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

IN TRENDS

THE INTERNET SPLITS OVER RAMAYANA TEASER

TEAM VIVA

Nitesh Tiwari’s *Ramayana* teaser finally arrived this week, sparking an immediate and intense debate across social media. While many are already hailing it as a definitive cinematic masterpiece, others remain unconvinced by the heavy reliance on CGI and specific casting choices. Fans on X shared their

excitement, stating, “There is nothing Ranbir Kapoor can’t do; this is a divine experience,” while skeptics point e staggering ₹4,000 crore budget, noting, “Underwhelming for such a cost; most shots look like generic AI work and Ranbir is a mismatch.” Despite the technical nitpicking, the grand scale and the Zimmer-Rahman score have ensured the film remains the week’s most discussed trend.



FOR SUGGESTIONS, FEEDBACK OR ADDITIONAL INFORMATION, PLEASE WRITE TO US AT FEATURES@DAILYPIONEER.COM

The Pioneer AGENDA

NAXALISM ENDGAME

The Government's assertion that Naxalism has been 'more or less wiped out' from Bastar marks a watershed in India's long and arduous struggle against the insurgency. Yet, the challenge ahead is no less significant: to secure a lasting victory by winning the ideological battle, preventing any resurgence, addressing the underlying roots of injustice, and transforming former conflict zones through sustained governance and inclusive development

Defeating Naxalism: How the red corridor was reclaimed

While the nation heaved a sigh of relief on March 30 when the Union Home Minister Amit Shah proclaimed in the Lok Sabha that "Naxalism has been more or less wiped out from Bastar" the security forces continued to scour the forests in Left Wing Extremism-affected States for the remaining Maoists who chose to cling to their path of violence. The following day, 35 Maoists surrendered in five districts of Chhattisgarh, prompting the Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sahai to declare that the state was free of Naxalism. Nine others crossed over to Gadchiroli (Maharashtra) and surrendered before the police there. A significant achievement to float over.

The relentless pursuit of Maoists by the commandos of the elite Cobra Battalions, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Chhattisgarh police, the District Reserve Guards (DRG), Bastar Fighters of

Chhattisgarh police and Battalions of the Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) viz, the Border Security Force, Indo Tibetan Border Police, Sashastra Seema Bal apart from the CRPF during the last few years displaced them from their hitherto safe sanctuaries in Abhujmad forests. Heavy casualties suf-

fered by the Maoists in encounters, arrest of many and large scale surrenders drastically reduced their strength from over 4,000 armed cadres to just a handful of them. In the past three years, 706 Maoists were killed, 2,218 arrested and nearly 5000 surrendered.

CAPF Battalions had to pay a heavy price in the initial years of deployment due to lack of robust intelligence set up and lack of road connectivity in the interiors. Maoists would gather in hordes of hundreds to ambush and attack security personnel without their getting a whiff of it. Movement of vehicles on unmetalled roads proved disastrous as they were blown up by Improvised Explosive Devices (IED) resulting in heavy casualties.

Despite stiff resistance by Maoists who threatened contractors and the labourers, the construction of roads were taken up in the right earnest under the security cover of CRPF. Efforts made in 2017 to construct



M P NATHANAEL
Former IGP (Anti-Naxal Operations), CRPF

the roads resulted in the martyrdom of nearly 40 CRPF personnel who were securing the under-construction roads. The Maoists had the alacrity to bury IEDs deep in the soil before the roads were macadamised and trigger them at their will when vehicles pass over them to inflict heavy casualties on the security forces.

The construction of over 12,000 kilometres of roads facilitated the movement of vehicles in the interiors. As many as 406 CAPF camps were established in the Maoist bastion, forcing them out of their sanctuaries. The visibility of governance by the state infused confidence and fearlessness among the villagers dotting the mountainous forests. The Maoist intelligence network was dismantled and replaced by the state intelligence apparatus. Information regarding the Maoists began to flow. With the backup of hard intelligence, operations were launched, and their hideouts raided, resulting in heavy casualties

to Maoists. It was the surprise element that caught them unawares. Though guarded by over 26 Maoists, Basvaraju, the general secretary, was killed along with all his guards by the DRG on May 21 last year in Narayanpur, which had an immense demoralising effect on the cadres.

The raising of DRG by recruiting a good number of former Maoists was a step in the right direction. Not only were they familiar with the battle craft of Maoists, but they were also acquainted with the jungle tracks as the back of their hands, which proved to be an unassailable asset in operations. Along with the CRPF and Cobra battalions, the DRG has achieved commendable success in joint operations. zzzThe intense pressure built up by the security forces brought the Maoists to their knees last year, pleading for peace talks with the Government. Rightly did the Governments, both at the Centre and the States, decline to hold any talks till they surrendered with their weapons? After the 21-day-long incessant operations launched by the CRPF, Cobra and other forces in Karregutta hills, in which 31 Maoists were killed, some who managed to escape in

small groups were in complete disarray and left without any directions or leaders. The surrender of Bhupathi, a central committee member, along with 60 of his comrades, came as a huge setback to the movement.

The general secretary Thippiri Tirupathi alias Devuji branded him as a traitor and goaded other Maoists to continue with their struggle. Despite his call, the wave of surrenders continued in the affected states. The lure of a comfortable life promised to those who surrendered drew them in hordes.

His appeal notwithstanding and the strength of Maoists almost depleted, Devuji reconciled to the changed circumstances and surrendered to the Chief Minister of Telangana, A Revanth Reddy, on February 24, along with 21 others, marking the end of the Maoist movement in India.

While the states are verifying their antecedents and rehabilitating them, care needs to be taken to prevent the resurgence of the movement.

CONTINUED ON >> PII



Eradicating Naxalism

THE FINAL COUNTDOWN (2004 TO 2026)

September 2004: The PWG and the Maoist Communist Centre of India (MCCI) merge to form the CPI (Maoist)

2006: Prime Minister Manmohan Singh labels Naxalism the "greatest internal security threat" to India

April 2010: Dantewada Ambush - The deadliest single attack, where 76 CRPF personnel are killed in Chhattisgarh

2011: Security forces kill top leader Kishenji in West Bengal, signaling a shift toward intelligence-led operations

2013: Maoists kill 24 Congress leaders in the Darbha Valley attack

2017-2021: Major ambushes in Sukma and Bijapur continue, but the "Red Corridor" shrinks from 180 districts to under 70

April-May 2025: Operation Black Forest (Kagar) clears the Karregutta Hills, resulting in the death of general secretary Nambala Keshava Rao and 30 other insurgents

October 2025: Over 170 Naxalites surrender in Chhattisgarh in a single day, part of a trend of 10,000 surrenders over a decade

February 2026: Chhattisgarh Deputy CM declares the insurgency is in its "final phase"

March 30, 2026: The Indian government declares victory, stating all insurgents have surrendered or been eliminated, except for two commanders at large

CONTINUED ON >> PII

The end of the red shadow: How Indian Security Forces defeated Naxalism

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

In the dense forests of central and eastern India, a six-decade-long insurgency once threatened the nation's unity. Naxalism, born in the 1967 peasant uprising at Naxalbari village in West Bengal, evolved into a Maoist armed rebellion under the banner of the Communist Party of India (Maoist), formed in 2004. At its peak in the mid-2000s, the so-called 'Red Corridor' stretched across nearly 200 districts in ten states, claiming thousands of lives, civilians, security personnel, and insurgents alike. It crippled development in tribal heartlands, extorted locals, and challenged the Indian state's sovereignty. By 2014, 126 districts were officially Naxal-affected. Yet,

by March 31, 2026, Union Home Minister Amit Shah stood in Parliament declaring India 'Naxal-free'. The Politburo and Central Military Commission of the CPI(Maoist) lay dismantled. Organised left-wing extremism (LWE) had been crushed.

This was no accident. It was the result of relentless security operations, a determined political will, and an integrated strategy that combined force with development. The decline did not happen overnight. Successive governments had tried 'Operation Green Hunt' in the late 2000s, 'Salwa Judum' in Chhattisgarh but gains were patchy. Violence peaked around 2010 with over 1,000 incidents annually.

What changed after 2014 was a national policy that treated Naxalism not



Naxalism in the country is now on the verge of extinction... The country will be informed once the entire process is formally completed, but I can say that we have become Naxal-free

— AMIT SHAH, Union Home Minister

as a mere law-and-order issue but as India's biggest internal security threat.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi Government's National Policy and Action Plan on LWE, approved in 2015, laid the foundation. Central support flowed to states through funding, intelligence, and paramilitary forces. The real acceleration came under Amit Shah, who

assumed charge of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) in 2019 and set a clear, time-bound target: eradicate Naxalism by March 31, 2026. Shah's approach was encapsulated in the SAMADHAN strategy, unveiled in 2017 but executed with ruthless efficiency in his tenure.

The acronym stood for Smart Leadership, Aggressive Strategy,

Motivation and Training, Actionable Intelligence, Dashboard-based monitoring, Harnessing Technology, Action Plan for each theatre, and No Access to Financing. It was not rhetoric. Dashboards tracked every district's progress in real time. Financing was choked through coordinated raids on extortion networks and hawala routes. Technology drones, satellite imagery, AI-driven intelligence, and encrypted communication transformed operations in jungles supposedly impenetrable.

The Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), its elite CoBRA (Commando Battalion for Resolute Action) units, state police's District Reserve Guards (DRG) and specialised task forces formed the backbone.



Central support flowed to states through funding, intelligence, and paramilitary forces. The real acceleration came under Amit Shah, who set a clear, time-bound target: eradicate Naxalism by March 31, 2026



Geopolitics and Nepal's path ahead

Nepal must not remain under the illusion that if India undermines it, China will come to its rescue, or vice versa. It may have been somewhat relevant in the past, but in today's age of information and technology, it is no more than a simplistic argument



The Gen-Z movement that took place in Nepal on September 8th and 9th laid the foundation for a political transformation. In the election held under the leadership of Sushila Karki that followed, the Rastriya Swatantra Party emerged as the largest party in Parliament, securing nearly a two-thirds majority. The traditional parties that had long struggled to establish democracy — particularly the Nepali Congress and CPN-UML — suffered a significant defeat in the election.

This clearly shows how dissatisfied the people had become with parties that believed they could do anything once in power. The fact that not even one-third of the electorate supported them in the polls reflects the depth of public frustration and disenchantment with the traditional ruling elite. These parties had grown accustomed to blaming neighbouring or other foreign countries for their inability to deliver, invoking the fear of external threats to capture power. This time, however, the people rejected them decisively. Forgetting that power is never permanent, these parties had entrenched themselves across all state institutions, assuming they could remain in power indefinitely through corruption and misgovernance.

This illusion was shattered as voters turned against them.

In the 2026 general election, the people gave a majority to the Rastriya Swatantra Party, electing 182 representatives out of 275 seats in the House of Representatives. By doing so, they entrusted the nation's future to a younger generation, appointing 35-year-old Balendra (Balen) Shah as Prime Minister. The new government faces the primary task of addressing widespread misgovernance and poverty and improving the standard of living of the people. At the same time, it must strengthen democratic practices, maintain mutually beneficial relations with neighbouring countries, and coordinate effectively with international powers. Nepal's neighbours, China and India, are already established global powers.

Maintaining balanced relations with both, while also fostering friendly ties with Western countries, is a major challenge for Nepal. Being situated between democratic India and commu-



JAGADISH PANT
Geopolitical analyst

nist China, Nepal must also balance the interests of the United States, a distant but influential advocate of democracy. Understanding US interests in India and China and shaping diplomacy accordingly is a complex task. Nepal must anticipate what these powers expect and respond with diplomatic skill.

Nepal, located between India and China, is not only geographically significant but also politically important to global powers. Amid growing polarisation among major powers, Nepal has become strategically important.

As the United States expands its global influence, its approach towards China and India is likely to have direct implications for Nepal. The United States may seek, in some way, to use Nepali territory to keep China within its strategic radar while maintaining relations with India. This possibility cannot be ruled out. Agreements with China prohibit the use of Nepali territory against China, and similarly, agreements with India prohibit its use against India. In such a context, there may be a perception that Nepal, situated between the two, provides a convenient base for strategic planning. Nepali diplomacy must remain alert to this possibility. This concern is already present among the general public. If Nepal fails to adopt a balanced diplomatic approach, the country risks being caught in the pressures of global powers.

The old political forces, particularly the Nepali Congress and CPN-UML, which alternated in power by leveraging relations with India and China, have now been rejected by the people. The time has passed when parties could win votes by blaming India or China for development failures. These parties failed to recognise this shift. Attempts to mask incompetence by criticising neighbouring countries no longer resonate with the electorate. Blaming neighbouring countries for internal political instability while ignoring internal conflicts and declining public trust has cost these traditional parties dearly. A balanced neighbourhood policy is a hallmark of strong diplomacy, and the newly formed government must prioritise this approach.



Although the United States may have no intention beyond assisting Nepal, public suspicion remains that such involvement could lead to interference in Nepal's internal politics

There has been much speculation regarding the MCC (Millennium Challenge Corporation) agreement between Nepal and the United States. Along with MCC, the proposed SPP (State Partnership Programme) agreement may also bring elements of US security policy. If Nepal assumes that India and China will naturally accept the presence of US security frameworks in the region, such thinking would reflect immature diplomacy. China is already cautious regarding US involvement in Tibet-related matters, and India may perceive US interest in its northeastern states as a security concern.

Nepal's strategy in addressing these legitimate concerns will play a crucial role in determining its future. Although the United States may have no intention beyond assisting Nepal, public suspicion remains that such involvement could lead to interference in Nepal's internal politics. The government must take wise and transparent steps to address these concerns. If Nepal, under the influence of American power, allows itself to become a strategic platform between India and China, there is a real possibility that these

two countries could come together and determine Nepal's future themselves.

China, for instance, might even urge India to manage Nepal in its own way if it perceives Nepal's diplomacy as inadequate. Nepal must not remain under the illusion that if India undermines it, China will come to its rescue, or vice versa. This way of thinking is outdated. It may have been somewhat relevant in the past, but in today's age of information and technology, it is no more than a simplistic argument.

It is natural for neighbouring countries to remain alert to the possibility that Nepal could be used in ways that threaten their security. It is equally important for Nepal to be cautious about foreign-funded NGOs and INGOs potentially raising border disputes in ways that could strain relations with India. Whether with India or China, Nepal must resolve border issues through mutual agreement based on historical evidence. Following the formation of Sushila Karki's government, the fact that the Dalai Lama was among the first to offer congratulations may have raised concerns in both China

and India. Similarly, the increase in Rohingya refugees in Nepal's Terai region along the Indian border — from Purnia to Champaran — and the increased presence of Americans in the Himalayan region after the formation of the new government may have been perceived as security concerns by neighbouring countries.

While Nepal cannot compromise on its sovereignty and self-respect, it is its diplomatic responsibility to address such concerns and dispel the suspicions of its neighbours. The United States may primarily seek to expand its trade in the vast populations of India and China, while also maintaining a strategic balance. In that context, it may view Nepal as a convenient vantage point to observe China. However, India may fear that U.S. presence in Nepal could also extend its gaze towards India. Under such

mutual suspicions, India and China could find common ground and jointly influence Nepal's future. A country that fails to formulate a clear foreign policy yet complains that others do not act in its interest reflects weakness. Nepal must move beyond the flawed policies of the past and define a clear national strategy. Nepal may find success by adopting a cultural diplomacy approach — presenting Pashupatinath to India as a symbol of Sanatan Hindu spirituality.

At the same time, Nepal's economic, social, religious, and cultural ties with India are deeply embedded in everyday life, making the relationship naturally unique and special. These bonds have evolved over centuries and must be acknowledged with equal depth. Nepal's goal should be to establish itself as a strong and prosperous nation by maintaining relations with the United States, Europe, and other countries based on the principles of Panchsheel and peaceful coexistence. By developing as a centre of Eastern philosophy and spirituality, Nepal can position itself as a global hub of peace on the world stage.

The writer is a Kathmandu-based geopolitical analyst and South Asia observer

FROM AGENDA COVER

Defeating Naxalism: How the red...

With no leaders, weapons or finances, resurgence in near future is well-nigh impossible. The intelligence wings of the states will however have to maintain an eagle's eye to ensure that any effort at resurgence is nipped in the bud.

Since IEDs have been planted in the jungles, the security forces cannot afford to be lax until all IEDs are removed. Last year, about 900 IEDs were detected and removed in Bastar and more are being removed with the help of the surrendered Maoists. The IEDs have proved to be obstacles in the operations launched in Serenda forests to apprehend Misir Besra, the last of the top leaders and his group in Jharkhand. The only other top leader Ganapathy is reported to be ailing and in touch with Telangana police to surrender after recovery. Though Maoists movement has ended, the continued deployment of security forces would be a deterrent for any kind of resurgence. The forces could be a bridge between the local population and the Government for the overall development of the regions that were deprived of welfare schemes launched by the states.

The author served as Commandant, commanding a CRPF battalion in Karimnagar, Ramagundam, Bellampally, Mancherial and Adilabad districts of Telangana from 1996 to 1998

The end of the red shadow: How Indian...

Over 1 lakh personnel were deployed in multi-state operations like Operation Kagar (launched 2024) and earlier drives such as Octopus, Double Bull and Chakrabandha. Fortified police stations jumped from 66 in 2014 to 612 by 2026. New security camps, helipads and 400 bulletproof vehicles strengthened logistics.

Inter-state coordination became seamless under Shah's oversight. Intelligence-led "Trace, Target, Neutralise" missions dismantled the Maoist hierarchy. Top leaders, including Politburo members, were eliminated or forced to surrender. MHA data speaks for itself. Between 2024 and March 2026 alone, security forces neutralised 706 Naxalites in encounters, arrested 2,218 and facilitated the surrender of 4,839. In 2025, 270 were killed, 680 arrested, and over 1,200 surrendered in a single year.

Brave jawans of the CRPF, state police and CoBRA paid with their lives in ambushes and IED blasts. Yet their sacrifice steadily reclaimed territory. Bastar division in Chhattisgarh, the epicentre of Maoist power saw Naxalism "almost eradicated," as Shah noted. Once a no-go zone, it now hosts schools in every village, roads, and administrative out-



posts. The Red Corridor shrank dramatically: from 126 affected districts in 2014 to just two or three by early 2026. Most-affected districts fell from 35 to zero. States like Bihar declared themselves Naxal-free after the surrender of the last armed cadre. Jharkhand, Odisha, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh followed suit as violence incidents dropped over 77-89 per cent from 2010 levels. Civilian and security force deaths plummeted by over 91 per cent.

Shah repeatedly emphasised the

"Clear, Hold, Develop" doctrine. Security operations cleared areas; forces held them with permanent camps and patrols; development followed swiftly. The MHA pumped resources into Left-Wing Extremism-affected regions through the Security Related Expenditure (SRE) scheme and Special Infrastructure Scheme (SIS). All-weather roads under PMGSY pierced forests, enabling markets, schools and hospitals to reach tribals. Electricity, telecom towers, banking, and postal services

arrived where Maoists once blocked progress. Tribal welfare schemes such as housing, scholarships, skill training addressed root grievances of alienation and underdevelopment.

Surrender policies offered rehabilitation packages, land, jobs and security. Thousands of former Naxalites, disillusioned by the leadership's hypocrisy and the futility of violence, laid down arms. Local communities, long caught between the gun and the state, began cooperating with forces, providing vital intelligence.

Amit Shah's personal oversight was decisive. He held regular high-level reviews, visited affected states, and coordinated with chief ministers. In Parliament and public addresses, he blamed decades of neglect under previous regimes particularly Congress rule for allowing the insurgency to fester. Under his watch, the narrative shifted from containment to elimination.

"Naxalism in the country is now on the verge of extinction," Shah declared in the Lok Sabha days before the deadline. The Maoist central structure was "almost completely dismantled." On March 31, 2026, as the government's self-imposed target was met, Shah announced that India had become Naxal-free. The formal declaration followed exhaustive verification: no major incidents, no active armed squads, and development indices rising in former

hotbeds.

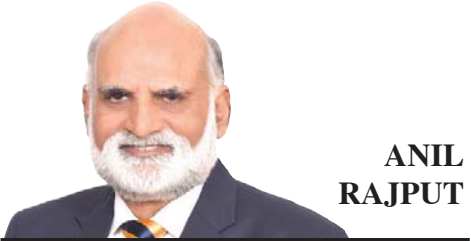
The victory belongs first to the men and women in uniform, the CRPF jawans who patrolled malaria-infested forests, the CoBRA commandos who survived booby-trapped trails, the state police officers who built trust in villages. It belongs to the intelligence agencies that mapped every hideout. It belongs to the tribals who chose peace over fear. And it bears the imprint of Amit Shah's iron resolve, a Home Minister who refused to accept perpetual insurgency as India's fate.

Today, the forests of Bastar and Dandakaranya echo not with gunfire but with the sounds of tractors, school bells, and mobile phones. Roads connect once-isolated hamlets to markets. Children study without fear. Farmers till land without extortion. The end of Naxalism is not merely a security milestone; it is a developmental revolution. It proves that determined leadership, professional forces and an integrated approach, security plus development plus governance can heal even the deepest wounds. India's success offers a global template: insurgencies thrive on neglect and division; they die when the state delivers both justice and opportunity. Bharat honours its security forces and salutes the political will that refused to compromise.

The writer is the Resident Editor of The Pioneer

“TO ME, FOOD IS AS MUCH ABOUT THE
MOMENT, THE OCCASION, THE LOCATION
AND THE COMPANY AS IT IS
ABOUT THE TASTE”
— HESTON BLUMENTHAL

Easter Day: Faith, renewal and the culture of celebration



ANIL
RAJPUT

Easter Day, commemorating the resurrection of Jesus Christ, stands as one of the most significant observances in the Christian calendar, marking not only a moment of spiritual triumph but also a reaffirmation of faith, renewal, and continuity. This sacred occasion is marked by prayer and church services and brings with it a sense of rejuvenation and devotion. Easter follows a profound period of transition shaped by the preceding season of Lent that is observed over forty days, as a period of fasting, restraint, and introspection that symbolically reflects Christ's time spent in the wilderness. The festival thus brings with it a sense of purification and contemplation that is expressed as much in the church as in the kitchen. The Easter cuisine, accordingly, transcends mere indulgence, emerging instead as an expression of spiritual renewal, collective memory, and the quiet joy of a community moving from restraint to abundance.

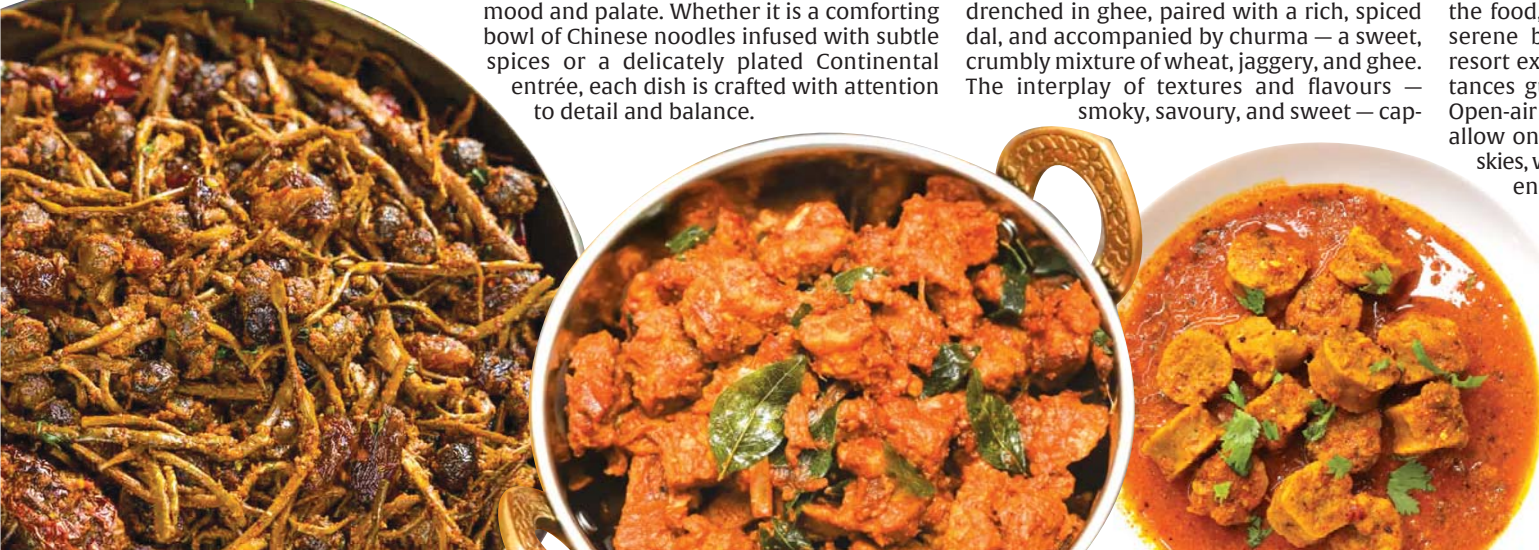
The origins of Easter, three days after the crucifixion of Christ, that is marked as Good Friday, lie at the heart of Christian theology. Historically, the festival also aligns with ancient springtime traditions that celebrate new beginnings and rebirth. The significance of Easter, therefore, extends beyond its doctrinal meaning of resurrection and eternal life as it embodies the universal belief in the cycles of life that resonate across cultures. Within this arc, the celebratory meal of Easter assumes deeper importance, symbolizing both spiritual restoration and the return of abundance after the austerity of the Lent season, making it a moment where faith, history, and sustenance come together in a shared cultural expression. Easter cuisine also reflects a distinctive confluence of Christian tradition and regional influences, resulting in a menu that is both familiar and uniquely local. From the coconut-rich preparations of Kerala to the Indo-Portuguese flavours of Goa, and the baked cakes and breads of the East, festive dishes often incorporate indigenous ingredients, spices, and cooking styles while retaining their symbolic significance. Roast meats, spiced curries, sweet breads, and delicacies



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Born out of a land of extremes, Rajasthani cuisine is a remarkable celebration of resilience, ingenuity, and royal indulgence. Shaped by the arid climate and scarcity of water, its dishes rely on hardy ingredients, generous use of ghee, and a masterful blend of spices to create bold, long-lasting flavours. From rustic village kitchens to the opulent tables of Rajput royalty, the cuisine reflects a unique balance of simplicity and richness — where every preparation tells a story of survival, tradition, and cultural pride. Whether it is the earthy comfort of Dal Baati Churma or the fiery intensity of Laal Maas, Rajasthani food offers a deeply satisfying and unforgettable culinary experience.

Nestled amid the tranquil hills of southern Rajasthan, Akashganga Heritage Hills Resort & Spa offers far more than just a stay — it curates a refined culinary journey that lingers in memory long after the visit ends. Located near the Ahmedabad-Udaipur corridor, this heritage-inspired retreat blends nature, architecture, and gastronomy into a seamless experience of indulgence and calm. At the heart of this experience lies its thoughtfully curated dining. The resort's all-day café presents a rich spread



prepared with jaggery and coconut illustrate how Christian food traditions have been thoughtfully adapted to Indian tastes.

In Kerala, Easter is welcomed with preparations that reflect both delicacy and depth, where appam and mutton stew often form the centre of the meal. The preparation of appam is elaborate and is an exercise in patience, as rice is soaked, ground, and fermented overnight to achieve a batter that produces its characteristic soft centre and sharp edges. Cooked in a curved pan, each appam is accompanied by a rich stew. Mutton stew is prepared by slowly cooking tender pieces of meat in coconut milk, and then infused with whole spices, ginger, and green chillies, ensuring a flavour that is deep and seasoned. For the vegetarians, the stew is similarly cooked using seasonal vegetables like beans, cauliflower and carrots. Alongside this, fish molly offers a lighter preparation, where fish is gently poached in a coconut based gravy with turmeric and curry leaves, allowing the natural taste of the fish to remain prominent, and is typically enjoyed as a softer, more delicate contrast to the richer meats. Duck roast, another popular preparation, is marinated in spices, slow cooked, and then added to a thick gravy that coats the meat, creating a dish that is both robust and balanced, and is often served as the more indulgent highlight of the meal. These dishes, when brought together, form a meal that is complete without being excessive, and ideal for a shared table of family and guests.

In Goa, Easter cuisine carries a distinct imprint of Portuguese influence, resulting in preparations that are bold, layered, and deeply aromatic. Sorpotel remains one of the most characteristic dishes, prepared from meat cooked with vinegar, spices, and a carefully balanced masala that develops depth over time, and is enjoyed after marinating, when its flavours have matured fully. Often made the previous day, it is allowed to mature, ensuring that its flavours are fully absorbed and deepened. Vindaloo, another defining preparation, involves marinating meat with garlic, vinegar, and red chillies before slowly cooking it until tender, creating a dish that balances acidity with richness and is relished for its sharp yet rounded flavour. These are complemented by sannas, soft steamed rice cakes that provide a gentle contrast to the intensity of the gravies and are used to absorb the rich sauces. Xacuti introduces complexity through the use of roasted coconut and spices, creating a deep, nutty gravy that is savoured slowly, while cafreal, prepared with a green masala of coriander and herbs, offers

freshness with the meal and is enjoyed for its vibrant and succulent profile. The preparation of these dishes often becomes a



family activity, where children join the elders to grind spices and prepare condiments, making the process an integral part of the celebration.

Moving eastward, Easter cuisine reflects a quieter expression shaped by local ingredients and traditional methods of cooking. Chicken roast with spiced potatoes often forms the main course, where a full chicken is marinated with garlic, pepper, and herbs, then roasted slowly to achieve both tenderness and depth of flavour. This is normally carved before being served with potatoes that are fried to be crisp on the outside and soft within, then garnished with herbs, making it a delicacy by itself. Vegetable cutlets, prepared from beetroot, carrots, and peas, are shaped and fried to a crisp exterior, offering contrast in both texture and flavour, and are often enjoyed as an appetiser.

Across many Christian households, roast preparations remain central to the Easter table, reflecting both tradition and adaptability. Roast lamb, marinated in yogurt, garlic, and aromatic spices, is cooked slowly until tender, often basted repeatedly to preserve its moisture and enhance its flavour, and is served as a celebratory centrepiece. Roast chicken, seasoned with pepper, cloves, and cinnamon, is prepared with similar care, ensuring a crisp exterior and a succulent interior, and is enjoyed across generations as a familiar festive dish. In certain regions, glazed ham appears as a festive centrepiece, its surface caramelised with sugar and spices, offering a subtle interplay of savoury and sweet, and is sliced and shared among guests. These preparations are often accompanied by breads such as pao or freshly baked loaves, which serve as accompaniments with gravies and juices.

Rice based dishes provide both structure and familiarity within the Easter spread, giving the meal a sense of completeness. Vegetable pulao, prepared with fragrant basmati rice and whole spices, provides an ideal accompaniment to the richer meat preparations and is enjoyed for its subtle aroma and balance. Biryani, layered with marinated meat and aromatic rice, reflects both craftsmanship and celebration, and is sealed and cooked on dum so that the flavours are infused gradually. The process of preparing biryani, from marination to dum cooking, requires atten-

tion and patience, ensuring that each grain of rice carries flavour without losing its individuality, and it is often served as a highlight of the meal. In some households, plain rice accompanied by a light curry provides balance, allowing the other dishes to retain their prominence without overwhelming the palate.

Within this unfolding meal, sweet and savoury preparations coexist naturally, emerging as part of the culinary experience rather than distinct courses. Hot cross buns, marked with the symbolic cross, are prepared with flour, butter, and dried fruits, their gentle sweetness complementing the savoury dishes that surround them, and are often served warm when they are fresh from the oven. Coconut macaroons, made from grated coconut and egg whites, offer a crisp exterior and soft interior. Bebinca, prepared through the careful layering of coconut milk and eggs, reflects patience in its preparation and is enjoyed for its rich, layered texture. Marzipan, shaped into fruits and decorative forms, adds an element of artistry to the table and has a decorative appeal. Preparations such as bread pudding and caramel custard extend the range of textures and flavours within the meal, offering softness and depth, while rice based sweets such as kheer, flavoured with cardamom, and regional variations of payasam prepared with coconut milk and jaggery, further integrate sweetness into the broader composition of the meal. An array of home-baked cakes that reflect both colonial legacies and regional tastes form an integral part of the Easter cuisine. Rich fruit cakes, with dried fruits and warm spices, remain a staple, alongside lighter sponge and butter cakes prepared for festive gatherings. In regions such as West Bengal and Assam, bakeries and homes alike showcase variations by mixing and matching local flavours, including hints of citrus, jaggery, and indigenous ingredients. These cakes, shared among family and community, embody the celebratory spirit of Easter, where baking becomes an expression of hospitality, continuity, and

festive abundance. Beverages accompany this progression with equal thought, responding to both climate and the richness of the food. Fresh fruit juices prepared from seasonal produce such as mango, pineapple, and watermelon are extracted and served chilled, often without excessive sweetening, offering immediate refreshment and a natural sweetness that complements the meal. Nimbu pani, prepared with freshly squeezed lemon juice, water, a touch of sugar, and a pinch of salt, provides a careful balance of acidity and sweetness that aids digestion and is enjoyed throughout the meal. Spiced buttermilk, lightly churned from yogurt and diluted with water, is seasoned with roasted cumin powder, salt, and sometimes curry leaves or ginger, serving as a cooling counterpoint to heavier preparations and ensuring that the meal remains balanced. In certain communities, homemade wines prepared from grapes or other fruits are fermented over weeks, resulting in a mild, aromatic drink that is shared in moderation, marking the celebratory nature of the day. Tea and coffee, brewed fresh and served warm towards the close of the meal, extend the gathering, allowing conversation to continue in a setting of ease and familiarity while gently concluding the dining experience.

In many households, the act of sharing food extends beyond the family, where neighbours and friends are invited to share the meal, reinforcing a sense of inclusivity and generosity. Portions are prepared with this in mind, ensuring that abundance is experienced not as excess, but as an opportunity to share. The meal itself unfolds gradually, with dishes brought to the table in a manner that encourages conversation and connection, rather than haste. What is created, therefore, is not simply a feast, but an experience that integrates nourishment with community.

As the Easter celebration comes to an end, what remains is not only the memory of a shared meal, but a quiet recognition of the principles that sustain it. I believe that the cuisine of Easter offers an unique example of how food can serve as a bridge between faith and daily life, between history and the present, between individual practice and collective experience. In reflecting upon these traditions, one is reminded that nourishment extends beyond the physical, carrying with it the values, relationships, and continuity that define a community. As a community with shared moral, cultural and civilizational heritage, I believe that we must collectively sustain and carry forward these culinary traditions. Easter, after all, is experienced not merely as a celebration, but as a lasting reflection of renewal, balance, and shared humanity.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Royal flavours of the Desert



of multi-cuisine offerings, bringing together flavours from across the globe — from Asian stir-fries and Chinese delicacies to elegant Continental fare. The menu reflects both variety and finesse, allowing guests to shift effortlessly between cuisines depending on mood and palate. Whether it is a comforting bowl of Chinese noodles infused with subtle spices or a delicately plated Continental entrée, each dish is crafted with attention to detail and balance.

Yet, it is the authentic Rajasthani cuisine that truly anchors the dining experience in its cultural setting. Here, traditional dishes are not just served — they are celebrated. The iconic Dal Baati Churma is a highlight: crisp, golden baatis baked to perfection, cracked open and drenched in ghee, paired with a rich, spiced dal, and accompanied by churma — a sweet, crumbly mixture of wheat, jaggery, and ghee. The interplay of textures and flavours — smoky, savoury, and sweet — cap-

tures the very essence of Rajasthan's culinary heritage.

Another delight is Gatte ki Sabzi, where gram flour dumplings simmer in a tangy, yoghurt-based gravy infused with aromatic spices. It is a dish born out of the region's arid landscape, where fresh vegetables were scarce, yet ingenuity transformed simple ingredients into something deeply satisfying. Guests can also savour the lesser-known but equally flavourful Sanganeri Curry, a speciality inspired by the Sanganer region. Characterised by its delicate balance of spices and often featuring soft paneer or vegetable preparations, it offers a milder yet richly layered taste, showcasing the diversity within Rajasthani cuisine itself. Complementing these are classics like Ker Sangri — a unique desert bean and berry preparation cooked with spices and oil, delivering a tangy, earthy punch — and Laal Maas, a fiery red mutton curry traditionally relished by royalty, known for its bold use of red chillies and robust flavours.

However, what truly transforms dining here into a memorable experience is not just the food, but the ambience. Set against the serene backdrop of the Aravalli hills, the resort exudes a quiet charm that gently distances guests from the noise of urban life. Open-air dining spaces and verandah settings allow one to savour meals under expansive skies, with cool breezes and soft natural light enhancing every bite.

There is an unhurried rhythm to the place. The gentle rustle of leaves, the distant silhouettes of hills, and the thoughtfully designed haveli-style architecture together create an atmosphere of stillness and grace. Guests often find themselves lingering longer at the table — not just to eat, but to absorb the surroundings. The hospitality, marked by warmth and attentiveness, further deepens this sense of comfort.



DESSERTS FROM THE DESERT

Rajasthani cuisine is a treasure trove of rich, ghee-laden desserts reflecting its royal heritage. Its obsession with sweets is visible in the mouth-watering dishes that define Rajasthani cuisine: **Ghevar**: Known as the "King of Sweets", this disc-shaped cake features a unique honeycomb texture. It is made from a flour batter fried in ghee and soaked in sugar syrup. **Mawa Kachori**: A speciality of Jodhpur, this indulgent pastry is filled with sweetened khoya and dry fruits, then deep-fried and dipped in syrup. **Churma Ladoo**: These are sweet balls made from coarsely ground wheat flour, ghee, and jaggery. They are famously served with Dal Baati **Laapsi**: A wholesome traditional dessert made by roasting broken wheat (dalia) in ghee and cooking it with jaggery and cardamom.



Tourist and a Pilgrim: Take The Journey Within

Most people in life are just tourists without even being aware of it. Only a few make their life a pilgrimage. Tourists come, look around, take pictures in their minds, only to come back again. Pilgrims are at home everywhere and are hollow and empty

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Both of them are on a journey. Then, what is the difference between a tourist and a pilgrim? While a tourist is satisfying the senses, a pilgrim is in the quest for truth. A tourist gets tired and tanned, while a pilgrim radiates with spiritual energy. Every move a pilgrim makes is filled with sacredness and gratitude, while a tourist is often preoccupied and unaware. A tourist compares with other experiences and places, and so the mind is not in the present moment. But a real pilgrim has a sense of sacredness, so he tends to be in the present moment completely.

Most people in life are just tourists without even being aware of it. Only a few make their life a pilgrimage. Tourists come, look around, take pictures in their minds, only to come back again. Pilgrims are at home everywhere and are hollow and empty. Tourists go from place to place looking for beauty, but they return tired and tanned.

Do you know which is the most beautiful spot in the world?

When you come here, you find that wherever you are, everything is beautiful. Where is this place? Don't look here and there. It's right within you.

If you are unhappy, you find the sweetest things nauseate you, good music disturbs you, and even the moon or the rain irritates you. When you are calm and centred, noise is musical, clouds are magical, and rain is liquid sunshine. Often, people run after parties and celebrations, but for the one who doesn't run after them, parties and celebrations simply follow. If you are running after parties, loneliness comes to you, but if you are in the solitude of the self, parties surround you. It all depends on you.

The dilemma of life is that everyone is looking for a perfect balance. People who are in the company of others all the time look for the comfort of solitude. People who are in solitude feel lonely and want companionship. People who are in a cold place want to be in a warm place. People who are in a warm place would do anything to get away somewhere cooler. But few people know that perfect balance is like a razor's edge. It can only be found in the Self.

There is a story. Ten people were travelling from one village to another. On the way, they had to cross a river. After crossing, they wanted to be sure everyone had crossed. Each one started to count and counted only nine people. They were very distraught and began to cry over the loss of the tenth one. A wise man came along and asked them, "My dear friends, why are you crying?" One of them replied, "We were ten, but now we are only nine." The wise man saw they were ten, so he asked them to count again. Each counted nine but left themselves out. Then the wise man made them count again, and he said to the last person, "You are the tenth!" and they all rejoiced for having regained the tenth.

Similarly, the five senses and the four inner faculties (mind, intellect, memory, ego) all lament



“INNER JOURNEY AND EVENTS IN THE WORLD REFLECT EACH OTHER. IT IS A BIG SECRET. IF YOU ARE HAPPY INSIDE, YOU ARE ABLE TO WORK DYNAMICALLY OUTSIDE THE MORE DYNAMIC YOU ARE, THE DEEPER AND BETTER YOUR REST AND MEDITATION”

— GURUDEV

when they lose sight of the Self. The joy is in finding the ever-present.

With the knowledge of the Self, everything is truly joyful. Wisdom that doesn't give rise to feeling is incomplete. Feeling that doesn't translate into action is incomplete. Action that doesn't give rise to fulfilment is incomplete. Fulfilment is returning to the Self.

Often, people think of the Self as only this mind-body complex. This is an erroneous notion. Neither the body nor the mind is the Self. All the yoga you do is for the body. All the meditation you do is for the mind. Whether calm or disturbed, your mind remains the mind. Whether sick or healthy, your body remains your body. But the Self is all-encompassing.

Among all the planets in the solar system, the Earth is privileged to host life in its many forms, and among all species, humans are most privileged, for they can host knowledge. Again and again, you must remember that you are peace, you are love, you are joy, and that you are hosting the Creator. This gratitude is important to

embark on the inward journey. If you are blaming and complaining, how can you move closer to your Self?

The only purpose for this body to exist is to make you aware of how beautiful you are, and to make you aware that it is possible to live all the values you cherish and create a world of divinity around you. Like the birds returning to their nests, again and again come back to your source; only there can you realise that you host the Creator.

If we take out some time, say two or three days in a year, to be in silence and simply observe our own thoughts and emotions, then you will get a sense of what quietness is, what beauty is. The ease with which you are able to handle your environment, or the situation around you, is what I would call being able to utilise your full potential. When you are in touch with your full potential, nothing or nobody can shake you. Silence puts you in touch with your own Self.

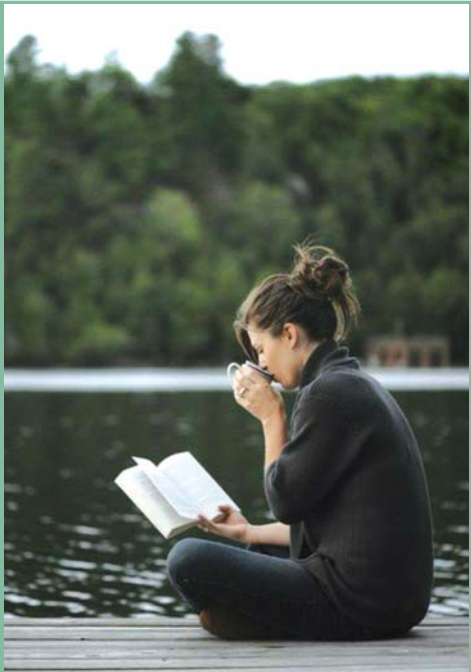
Becoming spiritual simply means recognising life everywhere, the spirit everywhere. I don't see

a division between the spiritual and the material. The finest aspect of matter is spirit. The gross aspect of spirit is matter. It's like body and mind. You see through the eyes, but actually the eyes are the means through which the mind sees. The mind is the spirit. The whole world is a combination of spirit and matter.

Inner journey and events in the world reflect each other. It is a big secret. If you are happy inside, you are able to work dynamically outside. The more dynamic you are, the deeper and better your rest and meditation. Therefore, being spirited, happy, compassionate, loving, and generous are also spiritual practices.

See your whole past as a dream. In the future too, you will accomplish many things, and they will all pass like a dream. Knowing this and being aware of it, the space within us starts to open up, and we experience heightened awareness.

Repose in that peaceful, cool, calm, serene depth of your being - this is precious. Bring the mind, which is all over the place, back to its source. It is only when you come to yourself that every place looks beautiful. And wherever you go, you add beauty and bring comfort to others. Book yourself on a trip to this most beautiful place in the universe. Then you will find that every day is a vacation and a celebration. Become a pilgrim.



DO YOU KNOW WHICH IS THE MOST BEAUTIFUL SPOT IN THE WORLD?

WHEN YOU COME HERE, YOU FIND THAT WHEREVER YOU ARE, EVERYTHING IS BEAUTIFUL. WHERE IS THIS PLACE? DON'T LOOK HERE AND THERE. IT'S RIGHT WITHIN YOU. IF YOU ARE UNHAPPY, YOU FIND THE SWEETEST THINGS

NAUSEATE YOU, GOOD MUSIC DISTURBS YOU, AND EVEN THE MOON OR THE RAIN IRRITATES YOU. WHEN YOU ARE CALM AND CENTERED, NOISE IS MUSICAL, CLOUDS ARE MAGICAL, AND RAIN IS LIQUID SUNSHINE. OFTEN, PEOPLE RUN AFTER PARTIES AND CELEBRATIONS, BUT FOR THE ONE WHO DOESN'T RUN AFTER THEM, PARTIES AND CELEBRATIONS SIMPLY FOLLOW. IF YOU ARE

RUNNING AFTER PARTIES, LONELINESS COMES TO YOU, BUT IF YOU ARE IN THE SOLITUDE OF THE SELF, PARTIES SURROUND YOU! IT ALL DEPENDS ON YOU.

Reclaiming the lost capital of wealth

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

History, as it is often told, has a habit of centring power around familiar names — Delhi, Agra, Kolkata. Yet, every so often, a work emerges that compels us to redraw that mental map. *Murshidabad — The Unknown Wealth Capital of the World* by Pradip Chopra is one such intervention — an evocative and persuasive attempt to restore Murshidabad to its rightful place in the global economic imagination.

At its core, the book advances a striking proposition: that Murshidabad, in the early 18th century, was not merely a provincial capital but one of the richest cities in the world. As the administrative and financial heart of Bengal under the Nawabs, the city thrived on a sophisticated network of trade, banking, and artisanal production. Silk, in particular, functioned as a global commodity, and Murshidabad's merchants and financiers - most notably the powerful Jagat Seth banking family - exercised influence that rivalled international financial houses of the time.

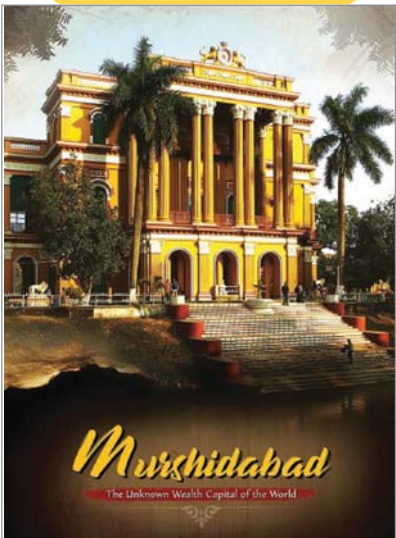
Chopra's greatest strength lies in his narrative approach. Rather than presenting a dense academic treatise, he crafts a story that is both accessible and immersive. The reader is transported into a world of opulence - of grand palaces, bustling markets, and intricate political manoeuvres. The city is not described in abstraction; it is felt, almost seen, through richly textured prose.

But the book is not merely a celebration of past grandeur. Its emotional and intellectual weight lies in its portrayal of decline. The turning point, as expected, is the Battle of Plassey - a moment that altered not just the fate of Murshidabad, but arguably the trajectory of global economic power. Chopra subtly underscores how colonial intervention dismantled indigenous systems of wealth generation and redirected economic flows, leaving once-thriving centres like Murshidabad in relative obscurity.

Thematically, the book operates on multiple levels. It challenges Eurocentric narratives of economic history by foregrounding India's pre-colonial prosperity. It also serves as a cultural document, highlighting the



BOOK REVIEW



Title: Murshidabad - The Unknown Wealth Capital
Author: Pradip Chopra
MRP: ₹200
Publisher: iLead Foundation

city's architectural and artistic richness. Most importantly, it functions as a reminder - almost a warning - of how quickly centres of power can rise and fall when political and economic forces shift. However, the book is not without its limitations. At times, Chopra's admiration for Murshidabad borders on romanticisation. The central claim - that it was the "wealth capital of the world" - while intriguing, is not always backed by the depth of empirical analysis that more academic readers might

expect. A more rigorous engagement with sources could have strengthened the argument and broadened its scholarly appeal.

Yet, these limitations do not significantly detract from the book's overall impact. Its true achievement lies in sparking curiosity and debate. It urges readers to question received histories and to look beyond the usual narratives that dominate textbooks and popular discourse.

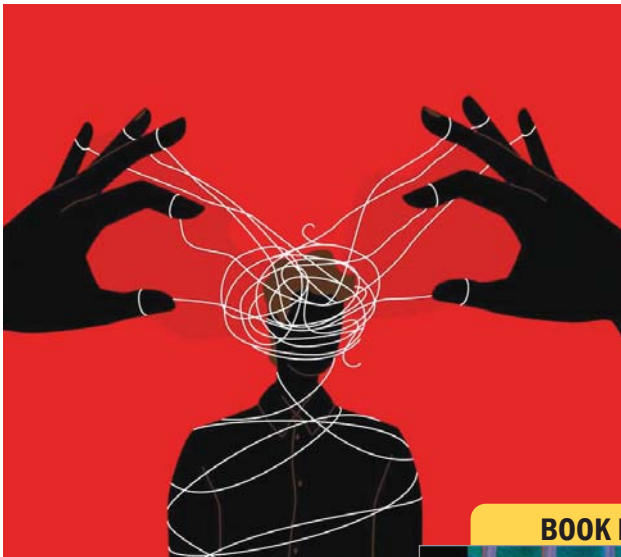
In a broader sense, Murshidabad - The Unknown Wealth Capital of the World is not just about a city; it is about historical memory. It asks a simple but profound question: how many Murshidabads have we forgotten?

For readers interested in history, economics, or the untold stories of India's past, this book offers both insight and provocation. It is less a definitive account and more an invitation — to explore, to question, and to rediscover.

Author's exploration of Murshidabad acts as a vital correction to the typical Bengal history lesson. Most accounts linger on Kolkata, yet this volume refocuses attention on a city that once stood as the world's wealth capital. The narrative details how the Nawabs and Sheherwali Jains built a financial powerhouse responsible for a massive share of India's prosperity.

Through stories of silk and architectural grandeur, the book resurrects a period of extreme opulence. It provides a rare look at a district that essentially fuelled the global economy. This remains an essential read for anyone seeking to understand India's true heritage. It is a striking tribute to a forgotten era.

Portrait of justice, guilt and redemption



BOOK REVIEW

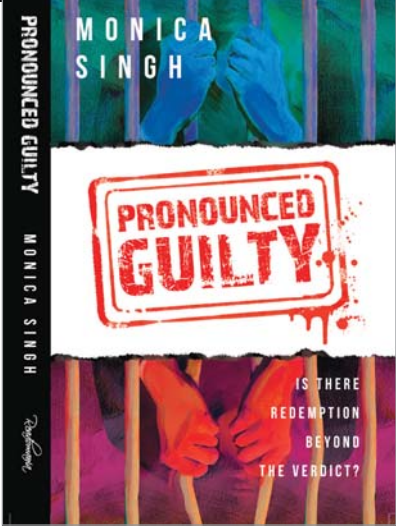
TEAM AGENDA

In *Pronounced Guilty*, Monica Singh crafts a debut that moves beyond the conventions of a legal thriller to examine the deeper moral architecture of justice. Set within the complexities of India's criminal justice system, the novel asks a question that is both unsettling and urgent: is punishment enough, or must justice also allow for redemption?

At the centre of the narrative is Advocate Dushyant Dave, a man shaped by personal tragedy. Haunted by his son's suicide following a false accusation, he seeks not just professional relevance but systemic change. His response is radical — the creation of Bandi Mukti Morcha, an open prison designed to rehabilitate long-term convicts and reimagine the purpose of incarceration.

The narrative draws its strength from the interplay of its central characters. Vijendar Singh, an ex-convict desperate for a second chance, and Anusuya Savarkar, a psychologist navigating her own grief, bring contrasting yet complementary perspectives to the idea of reform. Through them, the novel constructs a layered exploration of guilt - not as a legal verdict alone, but as a psychological and social condition.

Singh's writing is marked by a keen engagement with the moral ambiguities of her subject. Rather than offering easy answers, she situates her charac-



Title: Pronounced Guilty
Author: Monica Singh
MRP: ₹ 399
Publisher: Readomania

ters within a system fraught with contradictions — where institutional inertia, political pressures, and societal prejudice often undermine the very idea of rehabilitation. The open prison becomes both a symbol of hope and a site of tension, exposing the fragility of reform in the face of entrenched structures.

A pivotal narrative turn - the suspicious death of an inmate - introduces a layer of intrigue while simultaneously

“A COMPELLING DEBUT THAT CHALLENGES THE VERY IDEA OF JUSTICE, ASKING WHETHER SOCIETY IS WILLING TO MOVE BEYOND PUNISHMENT TO EMBRACE THE POSSIBILITY OF REDEMPTION”

reinforcing the central dilemma of the novel. Can systems designed for punishment genuinely accommodate transformation? And if they fail, is the fault of the system, the individual, or society at large?

What distinguishes *Pronounced Guilty* is its psychological depth. The novel is less concerned with courtroom theatrics and more invested in the inner lives of its characters — their traumas, motivations, and moral conflicts. Singh's prose remains accessible, yet it carries an undercurrent of introspection that compels the reader to engage with the ethical questions at the heart of the story.

At times, the narrative leans into its ideological debates, but this also becomes its defining strength. The novel does not merely tell a story; it initiates a conversation — about justice, accountability, and the possibility of change within individuals and institutions alike.